THIRD

a novel of Anka

Christopher Aruwa

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Dedicated to my best friend and wife, Liza. Without whose patience this would never have been completed. Also to my best man Eric, for the patience and inspiration for Wally. Lastly, to Zanaimo and her almost sibling 'Liwon', who i discovered during this writing as a way to process hir loss. My first completed book since being diagnosed with AuDHD. Thank you to all who put up with pre-diagnosed me who just couldn't understand. Thank you Lord for the blessings herein, and may all those who read this enjoy it as much as I did writing it.

One

The last customer left when the Scar had wheeled to a hand's-width from full dark, which gave Klar and me just long enough to close before the light went and we'd be finishing by firelight.

"You don't have to stay," I told him — which was true, and also the thing you say when you'd rather not lock up alone.

"I'm not in a hurry." He kept stacking bowls, and didn't make anything of it, which was a kindness. Klar was five thousand spins old — barely grown, by the reckoning we keep, where the Scar turns over you once a day and even a long life runs out somewhere short of twenty thousand. He cooked like a man three lifetimes into it. On the nights I closed alone he always found a reason to still be there, and never said what it was, and I never made him. I wiped the tables. He dealt with the kitchen. The fire burned to coals, the smell of the bricks and their hint of starch, always filled my nose with a touch of confusion. Was it morning or evening?

Through the shutters came the militia's boots on the packed earth, the patrol heading out, a touch of wax scent in their wake from their yet-unlit torches.

They'd been in an hour before, as they were every night: the whole watch at the bar for one measure each, which Tondi charged them half for and never explained. Courage, they called it, without embarrassment, because there was none to feel. Two of them drank fast and made faces. One

held his under his nose a while first, like a man reading a letter whose contents he already knew. Roan took water. He always took water. He stood there with his cup while the rest of them warmed up, and laughed in the right places, and went out into the dark with nothing in him but water, the same as every other night.

The Scar was almost across. Thirty minutes, maybe, before I'd want a locked door between me and the dark.

The greybeards call them Titanspawn. The militia call them problems. The rest of us don't call them anything — you don't name the thing that took the Pell family, you just get your ladder up before the Scar finishes crossing and you don't listen too hard to the sounds that come, some nights, off the far side of the wall. After long enough the not-thinking is a skill of its own. I'd had the practice.

Ours was not a remarkable town, and everyone who passed through said as much, kindly enough, and enough of them passed through to make it a fair verdict. The trail linked two larger places, so we got travellers, and travellers meant trade, and trade was the whole reason there was an inn for me to close. Tondi had taken me on as a girl — old enough to carry a stack of bowls without wearing them — back when my father had stopped being someone you could count on to be anywhere in particular. He was alive, last anyone knew. Just elsewhere. I was good at not thinking about that.

"That's me." Klar hung his apron on its hook and squared it so it wouldn't crease, and at the door he stopped. "Bar it after me."

"Go home, Klar."

His feet crossed the yard, the tall gate clattered, and the last living sound went with him, and left me the fire and the dark and the patrol thinning out around the mill.

The table under the window was Kern's. He was the Kro who'd been coming to the inn longer than I'd been closing it — a fixture, like the memorial pillar — in for a single cup most afternoons, which he made last until the light moved. He brought his bow, and the scent of the forest with him, the way he always did: the bow shorter than you'd expect of something so old, recurved, horn-tipped, no taller than his own chest, carved its whole length too fine to follow, worn pale where his shoulder rode it, old red worked deep in the bindings. The wood long since lost its own unique smell, carrying instead those of its owners. A family piece, he'd told me once, when I was small enough to ask rude questions. Virek-made — *may they never be forgotten*; he said the charm the way everyone does, the way you respond to someone who sneezed. Older than the inn. Older than him. A Kro doesn't call a thing old just to be saying something. Roan had asked him once, early on, why he didn't carry a Boltcaster like every other man who'd soldiered — Boltcasters being common as boots, and a good deal less trouble to restring. Kern had looked at him the way you look at someone who has asked a perfectly reasonable question in entirely the wrong room. "The Charter sells the bolt," he'd said. "Not the bow." He hadn't explained further, and Roan hadn't asked twice. I understood it a little better later, when I'd seen more of the world and what the Powder Charter's hand was in all of it — that a man carrying a weapon two hundred thousand spins out of fashion, that answered to no license and no toll and no supplier, was saying something with his shoulder that he'd never once said with his mouth. I'd wiped around it a hundred times and thought it handsome and in my way, that was the whole of what it was to me, then.

I made my round. Six tables, and I knew the wobble in each. The lockbox in the floor — lever down, lid true, the

way Tondi had shown me the first night she trusted me with it, kneeling on the alcohol-preserved boards beside me as if she were teaching me something holy. I straightened chairs that were already straight, which was either professional habit or a way of not going home yet. I knew which.

Through the gap in the shutters, if you stood right, you could see the memorial pillar — knee-high, three-sided, every name the town had buried since its founding. Not a long list. We were young, as towns go. I stood there too long and looked at it in the last of the Scar's light, and felt the quiet come down the way it did some nights, and not as a comfort. I'd been as far as Dunarth once, spireward, on a caravan, and back, and that was the whole of everywhere I'd been that wasn't here. I wasn't unhappy. I was unhappy the way you aren't hungry until the food is carried past you — which holds up fine, right until something changes.

Nothing was going to change. That was the thing about quiet towns.

I banked the fire, took my coat from the peg, and stepped out as the last Scar-light went out of the sky and the true dark of Anka came down — flat and total, the wound turning slow overhead and shedding its black straight down. Far off, the Spire still held its light. I stood at the gate a moment, taking the temperature of out there before I trusted myself to it, then spun the lock. Sem's lamp burned over the carpenter's: working late, or just not going to bed, the same thing at his age. The boundary spikes at the town's edge had gone invisible in the dark, which had always struck me as a flaw in the design.

The ordinary kind of dangerous, which in our town meant probably fine.

I was three paces toward home when the sound came from the town entrance — not the patrol. Two of the militia

called out, voices pitched a notch high, the way they go when the body decides something before the mind catches up. Then quiet. Then the careful talk of people working out what to do about a thing rather than running from it. In hand, then. I kept walking. Almost believed it.

Halfway home, past the dark bulk of the mill with its own smell of ground grains, boots came up behind me — quick, uneven, heavier on the left. Roan's gait; he'd favoured that leg since before either of us was old enough to know why.

"Tasha! Hold up—" A wobble in his voice I didn't like. "Tasha, I need—"

I turned. Roan was coming up the path at the pace that isn't quite running, because running would mean admitting something. And he wasn't alone. Beside him, keeping easy time with a stride that had nothing to do with Roan's hurry, came a shape I had no ready name for: thin, hooded, walking on something that didn't sound like feet on the packed dirt.

I was bad at leaving things alone. It was either a failing or the one interesting thing about me — and with my hand drifting toward my blade, I had the brief, unwelcome feeling I was about to learn which.

* * *

Two

They stopped a few paces short of me — far enough to let me look at the thing without it looming, and looming was clearly something it could do without trying.

Wooden limbs, with just disturbingly too-long forearms, wrapped in something like leather, in the way of something built to suggest muscle without quite managing it. A cloak doing an earnest, unsuccessful job of concealing the wearer, mostly because the wearer had cloven hooves where feet should be, and the sole-less boots someone had pulled over them had long since worn through. And in the shadow of the hood, slightly off-centre, one eye: a hole in smooth wood, lit from somewhere inside, a steady blue. Not facing me — and then it was, the glow finding me, settling, brightening a fraction as it fixed in place.

Strapped across the back of its waist, only the leather-wrapped handles showing, were a pair of blades I'd later learn were Falkas. Each one as long as a forearm, delicately carved their entire length, leaf-shaped but angled slightly down, and weighted towards the tip. "Better for chopping" I was later told. The cloak hid the hooves badly, the hood didn't hide the eye at all, and the whole of it gave the impression of something that had learned how to be unalarming from a single description, once, and gotten every detail a little, and terribly, wrong. The way a large animal sitting still ans watching you, is worse than one already moving. Roan wore the scent of militia in old, barely used leather armor. His companion wore the scents of the world.

My hand was on my own blade. I left it there.

"They wouldn't let it through the gate on its own," Roan said, in a rush, like he'd been holding the words in his mouth the whole way over. "Course they wouldn't. But it asked — it talks, Tasha — it asked for Tondi by name, and Pek said bring it to whoever's at the inn and let them sort it, so I—" He gestured at the entire situation. "So I brought it. To whoever's at the inn. Which I was hoping would be Tondi."

"Tondi's gone to bed."

"Yeah." His face fell about as far as a face can fall. "I was afraid you'd say that."

The thing's eye stayed on me. The body hadn't moved to follow it — the whole of it as still as the mill behind us, which should have been reassuring and wasn't.

"It wants to come in," Roan added, when the silence had gone on long enough to need something in it. "Into the inn, I mean. Not just the town. That's the part I didn't want to decide on my own."

"I did ask," the thing said.

The voice arrived like the first stones of a rockslide — not loud, not sharp, felt as much as heard, happening in the chest before it reached the ears. I hadn't expected it to speak. I took my hand off my blade — not because I'd decided it was safe, but because I'd decided that if it wasn't, my blade wouldn't be the relevant variable.

"All right," I said, mostly to buy a breath. Then, to Roan, because it was easier than talking to the thing: "What did Tondi tell you to do, exactly? Her words."

He worked at it. "She said — because I explained it had already come yesterday, and asked, which she said meant it was reasonable - if it's reasonable, there's a condition. For letting it in. She said tell it to bring back the head of

the Subsurface Shredder, the one that's been working the trail anti-spinward. Proof it's what it says it is." He glanced at it. "And bring the head to her. Not to take its word."

"You heard her," I said to the thing. "Proof. Do you have the Shredder's head?"

"I do."

Then it reached an arm around to its own back — not turning, not rotating at the shoulder the way a person would, the arm just going where arms don't go, at angles that put a sympathetic twinge in my own shoulder — and produced, from somewhere behind itself, the head. Held it out at arm's length, in a manner that suggested it found the object neither interesting nor troubling.

I looked at the head. Squid-like, but with six eyes, each pair a different size, all of them clouded now. The skin pale past the pallor of death — a thing that had lived mostly without light. By reputation it ambushed the unwary and was the last thing they ever met. By appearance, now, it was an oversized dead fish. Didn't smell much better either. Funny, how much death takes out of a thing.

Roan had the look of a man who's found a puppy and is hoping no one will tell him to put it down.

"Put that away," I said. "Please. And — fine. Come back to the inn. I'm not deciding anything out here in the dark."

It returned the head to wherever it kept such things, somewhere under that cloak, with that same wrong, unhurried motion, and said nothing, which I was starting to understand was how it agreed.

So the three of us went to the inn — me in front, because it felt important to be in front; the thing behind me, its tread landing wrong on the packed dirt; Roan at the rear with the air of a man escorting a prisoner he isn't sure is actually his. The town stayed dark and shuttered. If

anyone watched, they kept it to themselves.

At the inn I unlocked the gate but didn't open it, and turned to face the thing properly, with the building at my back as though that would help.

"Tondi set the condition," I said, "and Tondi's asleep, and I'm not waking her for this. So. You can't come in until she's seen that head and said you're what you say you are. Her rule, not mine, and I'm not clever enough to overrule it tonight. But you can wait inside the gate. That much is my call."

The eye stayed on me, and the quality of its stillness shifted in a way I couldn't have named — not impatience; nothing so humin as that. More like a sum coming out even.

"Then I will wait," it said, and stepped through the gate, and stood beside the door, and went, as far as I could tell, completely still.

I looked at Roan. Roan looked at the thing.

"You're the one who told it to come here," I said.

"Tondi told me to bring it. If it—"

"Tondi told you to bring the head. She didn't say anything about the rest of it."

He opened his mouth. Closed it.

I checked the lock — combination set, the hexwood bolt sliding home with its reassuring click — and gave Roan the look I hoped said *not my problem*, and left.

Behind me, rounding the mill, I heard him say, at about a third of his usual volume, "Do you need anything? Water, or—" and stop, presumably having remembered what he was talking to.

I didn't hear the answer, if there was one.

* * *

At home I sat on the edge of the bed a while without taking my coat off.

The thing had spoken. It had been polite. It had the Shredder's head, which meant the test was passed, or would be once Tondi was awake to call it passed. It had walked to a wall and stood against it like it could do that until the world ended and not mind.

None of which was, technically, alarming.

I took my coat off. Told myself I'd sleep, and was surprised, after a while, to find that I had.

* * *

Three

I found out later what he did while I was asleep. I'm not exactly sure when it stopped being *it* in my head, I only noticed I'd already done it - the way you notice, well after the fact, that you've started calling someone by their first name.

When I came around the corner of the mill with my coat still half-buttoned and my eyes not fully decided about being open, he was there. Something about the way he was standing — not the stillness, which was always there, but the quality of it — made me stop walking about a dozen paces out.

I stood there for a moment. He stood there for a moment.

His eye found me — the glow settling, one lid dropping fractionally as it fixed on me.

"Did you sleep?" I asked, because I was not yet awake enough for a more sophisticated opening.

There was a bellows-wheeze, slow and considered, from somewhere inside his chest. It vented the smell of something old, before the avalanche spoke. "I do not need sleep. However, during the dark I did advise someone that attempting a non-front-door entry during non-open hours would not be in their best interest. They then left."

I thought about that for a moment. My heart was doing what it had been doing since I'd turned the corner and seen him — the specific rhythm of a body that hasn't yet caught up to the decision the mind already made.

"If that's the truth," I said, "I think we can offer you something on the house. Or whatever you need for—" I looked at his face, which had no mouth. "—nourishment."

"I require only to be indoors where I do not need to consider night attacks from directions I am not watching." The eye didn't move from me. "Tondi was to arrange this. It appears I have circumvented that requirement by standing watch outside your inn."

"You are," I said, "genuinely resourceful."

I walked the remaining dozen paces and stopped at the door. He came aside in the way he had — the whole body moving as a single considered unit, not the unconscious shuffle of someone making room. He chose to move. That was the thing about Third, I was already beginning to understand. Everything was chosen.

At the lock I asked what else he'd done with the night. He told me in pieces.

He'd spent most of it considering the memorial pillar. Not looking at it — he'd read it before I'd arrived, all the names, the founding plaque worn smooth at the edges. He was considering it from memory, which for Third was not a figure of speech. He had the names of everyone who had ever died in this town stored somewhere in whatever served him for a mind, and had been cross-referencing them against what he knew of the region, the trail, the kinds of things that tended to happen to small settlements within a certain range of certain other things.

I asked him what he'd concluded. He said the town was not in immediate danger. That the kind of threat he was currently occupied with tended toward specific targets rather than casual ones, and this town was not specific enough to be a target yet. That yet was doing a lot of work in that sentence, and he knew it, and I knew he knew it.

I asked him why he hadn't said any of this the night before. He said I hadn't asked. I said that was technically true and also a very annoying answer. He said he knew that too.

He'd stayed at the window the rest of the night, he said — for no reason he could name precisely. The night was the same. The patrol was the same. The town was the same. It had simply seemed the right place to be when morning came, if morning was going to bring what he thought it might.

Once inside, i put away my coat and got him to a seat. "What did you think morning was going to bring?"

He said: someone willing to ask how soon.

"Looks like it might get stony today," I said — the sky had that particular flat quality that usually meant falling rocks by mid-morning.

I started the morning routine — shutters, stove, stew selection — and did not think about the fact that there was a Titanspawn Forged sitting in the corner of my inn wearing its worn cloak, and watching me with one blue eye.

I was not thinking about it very hard.

* * *

Four

I'd got as far as selecting the vegetables for the day's stew when Tondi came down, and that was when the morning stopped going the way mornings usually went.

I should explain about Tondi. She was the town's mender, which meant she stitched clothes and stitched people and was, by a margin nobody disputed, the most capable person in the settlement at both. She had grey hair that she wore loose and falling across her face, which made eye contact difficult, which I had eventually understood was the entire point. She did not touch money — she had a bucket, and you put your Black or your Teeth in the bucket, and that was the transaction. Nobody knew why. Nobody asked. You did not ask Tondi things. Tondi was a curmudgeon of such reliable and total commitment to the craft that the town had simply organised itself around the assumption that she would be unpleasant and correct, in roughly that order, about everything.

She had raised me, more or less, since I was old enough to carry things. I would not have said she was warm. I would have said she was the most dependable fixed point in my life, which is a different thing, and arguably better.

She came down the stairs from her room with the particular shuffle of someone who is awake but has not yet decided to be, took three steps into the main room, and saw Third.

The rocks were just starting to bounce off the roof, a loud plinking off the wood shingles. I have heard Tondi

raise her voice perhaps four times in my life. This was one of them.

"Gah! What in the name of the Titans—"

And then she stopped.

The plinking continued, but abated slightly, as if waiting for our mender to gather herself. That was the thing I would think about afterward, when I had time to think about things. The scream was real — she was genuinely, fully startled, a grey-haired woman finding a Titanspawn sitting in the corner of her inn at first light. But the stopping was just as real, and faster than it had any right to be. One breath of pure shock, and then something behind her eyes simply went to work, sorting the impossible thing in the corner into categories, weighing it, and arriving — visibly, in the space of about two heartbeats — at a conclusion.

The conclusion was: this requires information, not panic.

"Tasha," she said, in a voice that had already climbed all the way back down to its normal register. "Did you let that in here."

It was not really a question. I answered it anyway, from the kitchen doorway, with a vegetable still in my hand.

"Morning, Tondi. Yes. It scared off a burglar last night, and it—" I gestured with the vegetable, which I realised partway through was not helping. "It's got the Shredder's head. The one Roan was supposed to ask about. So I figured I'd trust it with a chair."

Tondi looked at me. Then she looked at Third. Then she looked back at me with an expression that communicated, with great economy, that we would be discussing the limits of my judgement at a later date.

Third, to his credit, did the thing he always did when he became the subject of a room's attention, which was

nothing. He simply turned his head toward Tondi, and waited.

Then he produced the Shredder's head.

I had seen him do this the night before and it had unsettled me then. In the morning light, with Tondi watching, it was somehow worse — the arm going around to the back without the body turning, the angles wrong, the whole motion carrying the casual competence of something that had been retrieving objects from impossible places for longer than the town had existed. The head came out and was held forth at arm's length, a gruesome offering between two intelligent beings, neither of whom was entirely sure what the correct etiquette was.

"This was what you sought," Third said. The voice did the thing it did — arrived in the chest before the ears. "As I understood it. If it is not sufficient, I will leave."

There was a silence then that I would not wish on anyone. Tondi standing very still. Third holding a decapitated Shredder head at arm's length. Me in the doorway with a vegetable. The fire not yet lit, the room cold, the light coming grey through the just-opened shutters.

The stony had passed. Tondi closed her eyes for a breath. I watched her hands, which had balled into fists at her sides, slowly uncurl. When she opened her eyes again, she had decided something, and Tondi deciding something was a force roughly equivalent to weather.

"Thank you," she said, "for ridding us of that beast." A pause, during which she was clearly choosing her next words with the care of someone disarming a trap. "I can see you're a reasonable... being."

The word being cost her something. I could hear it. But she said it, which was Tondi all over — she would give you

the truth even when the truth was inconvenient to her own prejudices, because the alternative was being wrong, and Tondi would rather do almost anything than be wrong.

"That said," she went on, "some of the townsfolk—" She stopped, reconsidered, and corrected herself with the flat honesty that was the closest thing she had to a personality trait. "Most of the townsfolk will not understand. Would you mind setting yourself somewhere more out of the centre of the room. And—" she looked at the cloak, which was doing its usual poor job. "—covering yourself a bit more thoroughly. Scar's sake."

She did not wait for an answer. She walked to the corner she always sat in, the one with the best light for mending, and she picked up the cup of water I put out for her every morning, and she drank from it, and she almost visibly relaxed. Third looked down at its cloak, considering the problem of how to cover himself better. This required the use of an arm, so it set the Shredder's head down on the nearest table — without any apparent concern for the fact that it was a decapitated head on a table where people would later eat — and began trying to arrange the inadequate cloak into something more adequate.

I put the vegetable down and went over to Tondi, not for conversation, which one did not seek with Tondi, but because there was a tablecloth on the pile of her current projects that was past saving, stained and fraying, not worth the Black it would take to mend.

"That old cloth," I said. "It's done, isn't it. Not worth fixing."

She didn't look up. She made a sound that I had learned to interpret, over many spins, as assent delivered grudgingly enough to preserve her dignity.

I took the cloth.

"Here," I said to Third, and draped it over his back and shoulders, on top of the failing cloak. With the tablecloth added, and Third positioned away from the door and out of the direct sightline of anyone walking in, you would have to get fairly close to notice the hooves, or the wrongness of the arms, or the single blue glow where a face should have been.

Klar arrived for his shift just then, which was its own small mercy, because Klar arriving meant the morning had to resume being a morning. I took the Shredder's head off the table before he could see where it had been sitting and handed it to him, the smell still lingering to the old wood.

"Customer brought us a trophy," I said. "Think you can do something with it?"

Klar's whole face changed. He had not yet looked up enough to register the Forged Titanspawn sitting in the corner under a tablecloth, because he was only 5,100 spins and a Shredder head was the most interesting thing that had happened to him in a tenday.

"A Shredder head? You don't even—" He was already turning toward the kitchen, already planning. "Let me get a skewer."

And he was gone.

I looked at Third, in his corner, under his tablecloth, with his one blue eye, watching the room with the patience of something that had decided this was an acceptable place to be and had no particular feelings about how long it took. I looked at Tondi, mending, her water at her elbow, behaving as though there were not a Titanspawn in her inn.

Then I went and lit the stove, because the stew was not going to make itself, and because I had apparently decided, somewhere in the last few hours, that this was simply how the morning was going to go.

I did not examine that decision very closely either.

* * *

Five

The day did what days do. Customers came for the stew and left having eaten it; the Scar crawled its slow arc overhead; Tondi mended and grumbled and eventually went up to rest; and through all of it the thing in the corner sat under its tablecloth and did not move, except to adjust the Falkas on its back, until the light began to fail and the inn emptied to nothing and I found that I had run out of reasons not to go and sit with him.

So I brought my stew, just in case. The tablecloth had done a passable job of hiding the worst of it, but up close, where I was sitting, there was no pretending the thing across the corner table from me was anything other than what it was. The wooden hand with its too-many joints resting on the table's edge. The faint sound, every so often, of something mechanical inside a chest that didn't move. And the eye — one blue eye, set slightly off-centre in a smooth featureless face, which had not so much looked at me as found me, the glow of it fixing in place with a weight I could almost feel.

I'd served stranger, maybe. Tondi, for one.

What I kept coming back to was the weapon. Slung across its back, under the failing cloak, was a Boltcaster — a real one, a lightning-gun, the kind the militia talked about the way some men talk about women they'll never meet. Ours had exactly none. And here was one riding the back of a Titanspawn that fought with curved wooden blades it kept in its hands, while the Boltcaster stayed where it was, unslung, unfired, gathering the same dust as the rest of it.

"You don't use that," I said, before I'd decided to. I nodded at the weapon. "The Boltcaster. You've had a blade in your hand twice since you got here and that thing hasn't come off your back once."

For a moment I thought I'd asked the wrong thing, in the way you can feel a wrong question land before anyone tells you it was wrong.

"No," it said. "I do not use it."

"Is it broken?"

"It functions." A pause — not the kind where someone decides what to say, the kind where someone does arithmetic on a sum they have done many times and still do not like the answer to. "It belonged to Dorn. I carry it because putting it down would mean something I am not prepared to mean yet."

I didn't say anything. There are sentences you don't step on.

"Dorn travelled with me," he went on, when he had decided I'd earned the rest. "He told jokes. There was one he was fond of, concerning a Mender, a Crafter, and a Grask. I will not attempt to reproduce it. The delivery was the entire substance of the thing, and the delivery was his." The glow dimmed a fraction. "He was killed by a Subsurface Shredder. It came up through the ground where we had made camp, and it was very fast, and I was not fast enough, which is a thing I have had occasion to be more than once and have never learned to care for."

"I'm sorry," I said.

"Thank you." Stated simply, the way he said most things — not performed, just received and set down, like a toll paid. "There was a third of us, also. Adura. She was not taken by any creature. She had been unwell for a long while, and one day the being unwell finished what it had

been doing slowly." The eye held on me. "I mention them because you should understand what travelling with me has tended to cost the people who have done it. It would be dishonest to ask without saying so."

I turned my cup in my hands. The stew had gone cold while we'd been talking and I hadn't noticed. "So you're looking for new ones. Companions."

"I am."

"Here." I gestured vaguely at the inn, the town, the general smallness of everything.

"It seemed a reasonable location to begin. Frequently travelled. A mender in residence suggests a degree of civilised infrastructure. And the memorial pillar outside is—" The eye moved to the shuttered window facing the square — the glow sliding across the dark, unhurried, the head not following — then back to me. "—modest. Which suggests the town has not yet suffered the kind of loss that makes people reluctant to risk further loss."

I stared at him. "You read the pillar."

"Before you arrived this morning. Yes."

I thought about that — Third standing in the pre-dawn, reading a knee-high plinth with one blue eye while I'd been asleep, unbothered by the dark and apparently making strategic assessments about grief thresholds. "That's very—" I tried to find the word. "Methodical."

"I have found it useful to understand a place before asking something of it."

Before asking something of it. I looked at the tablecloth I'd draped over him — my idea, technically, though Tondi had grunted permission — and tried to remember if I'd ever thought of this town as something that could be asked things. I'd mostly thought of it as somewhere I'd been born and hadn't left.

"What are you asking of it?" I said. "Specifically."

"For someone — or several someones — willing to travel with a Titanspawn toward a problem that will likely become violent, with no guarantee of return, in service of preventing something most people do not yet know is happening."

The stew was definitely cold. The inviting smell it had while warm, had fled with my appetite. I pushed it aside. "And what is happening? The thing most people don't know about."

The eye did not move from me. Whatever considering was happening, it happened behind that fixed blue point. Something settled in the set of the wooden shoulders — a decision being made about how much to say.

"Someone is attempting to resurrect a Titan," Third said. "I use the word attempting deliberately. I do not know how far along this attempt is. I do not know, yet, what they are collecting to achieve it. But I know they are collecting something, and I know that whatever it is, it has already cost one town everything it had."

The inn was very quiet. Klar had stopped scraping.

"The Titan," I said carefully. "As in — one of the ones from the war."

"As in the ones from the war. Yes."

"The ones that—" I gestured at the general state of everything. The world with a wound in its sky. The buildings with no ground-floor doors. The militia that drank before going out at night.

"Yes," Third said again. "Those ones."

I sat with that for a moment. Then: "And you're looking for companions. To stop this."

"I am already committed to stopping this. I am looking for companions because—" A pause. Longer than the

arithmetic one, shorter than the one before he had said Adura's name. "Because I have found, over a considerable period of time, that I am better at most things with company. And because the last time something like this threatened everything living on Anka, it required a coordinated effort by an entire people to address it." The eye was steady on me. "That people no longer exists."

May they never be forgotten.

I didn't say it aloud. I didn't know why. It didn't feel like mine to say — and then I understood it was stranger than that. I had never in my life heard anyone name that lost people without the words trailing after, the charm tucked in quick and unthinking: Kern over his bow, the militia, Tondi when she wasn't even listening to herself. Everyone said the rest of it. Third had set an entire people down — gone, all of them, that people no longer exists — and reached for none of it. As though they were not a thing you guarded with a charm. As though they were just his.

"How many people are you looking for?" I asked instead.

"I am not certain. Enough. People who can think as well as fight. People who are not so committed to surviving that they become useless when survival seems unlikely."

"People like Roan," I said, before I'd decided to say it.

A long beat. "The militia member who found me at the gate."

"He's braver than he looks. And he doesn't drink for courage, which around here means something."

"I had noted that," Third said. "Yes. People like Roan." The bellows-sound again — slower this time, something gathering itself. "People like you, if you are willing."

I looked at my cold stew. I looked at the shuttered window. I thought about the pillar outside, knee-high, the town's whole history in a dozen names, and I thought about

the fact that Third had stood in the dark reading it before the sun came up, before I'd even opened the inn, already deciding whether we were worth asking.

"You said whoever's doing this already cost one town everything," I said.

"Yes."

"And you don't know how many more before you can stop them."

"No. I do not."

I nodded slowly. Outside, the patrol's footsteps had faded. The Scar was almost fully across now — in another few minutes the light would go and the dark would come down. "How soon?" I asked.

* * *

Six

"Soon" he'd said, which I'd took for a word to avoid choosing a number. it turned out to mean the next day, and it wasnt Third who chose the date.

The traveller came in a little after midday, which was the wrong time for travellers. They arrived in the evening, mostly, when the dark was coming and a roof seemed worth paying for. A midday arrival meant someone who had been walking through the night, which meant someone who had not felt safe stopping, which meant news, and news that came in on foot at the wrong time of day was never the good kind.

He was Humin, middle-aged, with the particular grey-faced look of a man who has used up everything he had and is running on the memory of it. There was a wound on his forearm, bound with a strip of his own shirt, and the binding had gone stiff and dark. He came through the door and stopped just inside it, the way people do when they have been moving toward a destination for so long that arriving leaves them with nothing to do. And he brought with him the smell of someone who had been moving for a long time, but his breath was dry - any courage in him, was wntirely his own.

I got him into a chair before he fell into one. Klar brought water without being asked, which was Klar. Tondi, in her corner, set down her mending and watched, which was Tondi. And in the other corner, under his tablecloth again, Third did not move at all, which by now I had stopped finding remarkable.

The traveller drank. His hands shook. When he could speak, the first thing he said was a name I half-recognised — Chipwood — a settlement maybe two days spinward, on the same trail as ours, the kind of place that was to us what we were to Dunarth. Smaller. Further out. The next notch down the line.

"Gone," he said. "It's gone."

"Gone how," Tondi said, from her corner. Not unkind. Just direct, the way you are direct with someone in shock, because vagueness is a thing they cannot afford and neither can you.

"Ravagers." He said the word and then had to stop and breathe around it. "A whole — there were so many of them. They don't come in numbers like that. They don't. They come in twos and threes, you lose a goat, maybe a man if he's careless. This was—" He looked at his bound arm as though it belonged to someone else. "They came all at once. Like they'd been told to."

I felt the room go quiet in the specific way a room goes quiet when several people have all had the same thought and none of them want to be the one to say it.

"Like they'd been told to," Tondi repeated.

"I got out because I was anti-spinward at the mill when it started. I ran. I didn't—" His voice did something then, and he didn't finish, and nobody made him. There are sentences you let a man leave on the floor.

I refilled his water. It seemed like the only useful thing available to me.

"There's more," he said, after a while. "I didn't see this part. I heard it from a woman on the trail, going the same way, faster than me." He wiped his mouth. "There was another town. Spinward of the one that — of mine. The Ravagers were going for it too. And a skybarge came down.

The Porter."

I knew the Porter. Everyone on the trade did, even those of us who'd never once set foot up its ramp — it was the only inn in the world that came to you. A whole tavern slung under a skybarge's fans: Waj Hool's travelling house, food and drink and a dry bed for sale a hundred paces off the ground, here twice in three hundred spins if you were lucky and gone again on the wind. The whole town turned out to watch it settle, the time it came; I'd spent more than one shift at Tondi's after that wishing I worked a floor that moved. It was the last barge in the world I'd have looked to come down into trouble instead of sailing wide of it.

Tondi's mending had not moved in some time.

"Came down right over the square," the traveller said. "In the middle of it. Fans going, the whole — you could hear it to the next town, she said. And it just hung there. And the people were running for it, getting underneath it, and it wouldn't open. The barge wouldn't drop its ramp. Just hung there with the whole town screaming under it."

"Why wouldn't it open," Klar asked. He had not meant to ask. It had come out of him the way questions come out of the young, before they have learned that some answers cost more than the question is worth.

"She said there was someone arguing with Waj — with the master, down on the ground. Someone the master didn't want to listen to. She couldn't hear what was said. But the ramp came down in the end." He turned his cup in his hands, an echo of a gesture I recognised because it was mine. "Most of them got up and in before the Ravagers reached the square. Most of them. The woman said the thing that argued the ramp open was the last one up, and it walked up that ramp backward, facing the Ravagers, the whole way."

I did not look at the corner where Third sat. I want that on the record. I had every reason to and I did not, because some part of me had already done the arithmetic and did not want to confirm the sum.

But I heard it. Across the room, from under the tablecloth, the bellows in Third's chest drew breath — slow, the sound it made when something had landed with weight — and then nothing. No comment. No movement. Just the one long mechanical inhalation and the stillness after it, which was a different quality of stillness than the stillness before.

The traveller hadn't noticed. He was looking into his cup.

"There's one more thing," he said. "The part I keep — the part I can't—" He stopped. Started again. "When I went back. To my town. After. To see if anyone — I went back."

"You shouldn't have," Tondi said, gently, which was a register I had heard from her perhaps twice in my life.

"I know. I did anyway." He looked up, and his eyes found mine, and I wished they hadn't, because there was something in them that I did not have anywhere to put. "There was something there. Walking through it. No wait, more like floated through it. Through what was left. Not a Ravager — the Ravagers were gone, they'd moved on, they don't linger. This was after. Something floating through the dead, slow, like it was — looking for something. Going building to building. And the survivors, there were a few of us hiding, and it went right past us. Right past. Didn't look. Didn't care. Like we weren't worth the turning of its head."

The bellows again. Slow. Across the room. I kept my eyes on the traveller.

"What did it look like," I asked, and my voice came out steadier than I felt.

"I don't know. Cloaked. Hunched. There was — there were lights on its back, blue-white, like a bottled storm, like a whole rack of them, glowing through the cloak." He shuddered, and it was not from the wound. "It found whatever it was looking for in the headman's house. I heard it — there was a sound like a building being unmade. And then it left. Anti-spinward. Away from everything. And it never once looked at any of us."

He went quiet then, all the way quiet, the quiet of a man who has finally set down the thing he had been carrying and discovered that setting it down does not make it lighter, only shared.

I gave him the room. I gave everyone the room. The fire ticked. Klar stood in the kitchen doorway with a cloth in his hands, not using it. Tondi's mending lay in her lap.

And in the corner, Third stood up.

He did it slowly, the tablecloth sliding off his shoulders, and he did not bother to catch it, which was the first time I had seen him fail to account for the cloak in any way. He stood in the corner of the inn at midday with his one blue eye gone bright — brighter than I had seen it, the glow of it hard and steady — and he looked at the traveller, and the traveller looked up at the thing that had been sitting two paces away the whole time, and made a sound.

He was not the only one to make it. I had forgotten them the way you forget furniture — but the news had drawn a few of the regulars in off the lane and then kept them, the way bad news keeps people, and they had spent the last hour with their backs to the corner, listening to a town die, while the corner sat two paces behind their spines and did not breathe. Old Sem was there, and a carter I half-knew, and a woman who'd come for stew and stayed for the worse thing. And now the corner had stood up, and shrugged its cloth onto the floor, and become a wooden monster with a

burning eye, and it had been there, that close, the entire time. The room came apart the way a startled flock does, all at once and in every direction. A bench went over backward. The carter was on his feet with a paring knife he'd lifted off the bar without deciding to, holding it the way you hold a thing you already understand will not help. Sem had the door half open. The traveller had shoved himself clear off his chair and fetched up against the wall, and the noise coming out of him had stopped being a noise a man chooses to make.

"Sit." Tondi did not stand. She didn't need to. She had a voice she kept for about once in three hundred spins, and she spent it now, and it landed on the room like a dropped lid. The knife stopped. The door stopped.

"That," she said, into the ringing after, and she did not so much as glance at the corner, "is the reason there's meat in your bowls and not a Shredder on your road. It came in off the dark and laid the head of the thing on my table — the Shredder that's been taking travellers off the anti-spinward trail, the trail half of you walk to market. I examined it myself. Klar's been feeding it to you since the pot got hot." She licked her thread and went looking for her needle.

"It has sat in that corner behind a cloth, troubling no one, doing you the courtesy of not frightening the very people who are now frightening themselves over a tipped bench. So. Sit down and finish your bowls like grown folk, or take your fright out the door and leave the rest of us to hear the man — but either way you'll do it without the knife, Bevin, before you cut yourself and I'm obliged to stitch you for nothing." It was not kindness. Tondi had no use for kindness; she found it sentimental. It was the thing she kept instead, which was worth more — the flat, bottomless certainty of a woman who has decided a thing is

true and will not be argued off it by anybody's heartbeat. Bevin looked at the knife as though it had got into his hand by witchcraft, and set it on the bar. Sem let the door swing to. The woman sat, because Tondi had said sit and there are people in every town who have been waiting their whole lives for someone to tell them what to do in exactly that voice. Nobody else quite managed it. But nobody ran, either, and I was starting to learn that nobody-running was the whole of what you got to ask of people the first time they met him. Through all of it Third had not moved. He had not turned his head, had not marked the knife or the door or the going-over of the bench; he had stood with his one bright eye fixed on the traveller and the traveller alone, as untroubled by a room deciding whether to kill him as the Scar is by the things it passes over. He had been waiting, I understood, for the noise to finish — not out of patience, but because the noise had nothing to do with the single thing he had stood up to learn. "Anti-spinward," Third said. The voice filled the room the way it always did, but there was something underneath it now, something I had no name for and was not sure Third did either. "You are certain. Anti-spinward."

The traveller could only nod his frightened head. Third turned his head — the head, the whole head — toward me. The eye was very bright.

"You asked how soon," he said.

I had. The evening before, at the corner table, I had asked exactly that, and he had not answered, and I had gone home thinking I'd have days to decide whether I'd meant it.

"Yes," I said. "I did."

"Now," Third said. "It is now."

* * *

Seven

We got the traveller into one of the rooms upstairs, and he was asleep before Klar had finished setting down the second cup of water, the deep instant sleep of a body that has been refusing itself for too long. Tondi had looked at the wound on his arm and made the face she made when something was going to need more attention than it was going to get, and then she'd dressed it properly anyway, because that was the difference between Tondi and her reputation.

When she came back down, the inn had emptied of its few midday customers. It was just the four of us. Me. Tondi in her corner. Roan, who had come in off his rest and who had been standing by the door for the better part of an hour with the expression of a man who has not been invited to sit but does not want to leave. And Third, who had put the tablecloth back on without being asked, and who now sat at the corner table with his one blue eye on the middle distance, waiting, the way he waited for everything.

"All right," I said, and sat down across from him. "You said now. So tell us. All of it."

The bellows drew. Once. Then he began.

"I have been following this for some time," Third said. "Long enough to be certain it is not chance. Towns along the trails — small ones, mostly, the kind that do not appear on a trader's map and are not missed when they cease to appear anywhere at all. Each one struck. Each one to the same end result. Ravagers in numbers they do not naturally

gather in, directed against the settlement all at once; rivers with no history of flooding, overflow their banks only on the village-side; giant creatures attacking a town when normally they wander the woods. And then, after, something walking, or floating, through the wreckage. Searching. Taking one thing and leaving everything else, including the survivors and wealth, untouched."

"The thing the traveller saw," Roan said, from the door.

"Yes."

"With the lights on its back."

"Yes." Third's eye moved to Roan — the glow sliding across the room, unhurried, the head following. "magefire. A great many bottles of it, more than I have ever seen one body carry. I do not know why it needs so much. I know that it does."

I thought about the traveller's words — a bottled storm, a whole rack of them — and I thought about how Third had gone still when he heard it, and I made myself ask the question I had been not-asking since midday.

"You were there," I said. "At the town with the Skybarge. You're the one who argued the ramp open."

The inn was very quiet. Roan looked at me, then at Third.

"Yes," Third said. No weight on it. No reluctance. He stated it the way he stated the hour. "The master of the barge — a Hin called Waj Hool — did not wish to descend into a Ravager assault. This was a reasonable position. I persuaded him that it was less reasonable than the alternative." A pause. "I was the last aboard. I prefer to keep a Ravager pack in front of me where I can account for it."

"You walked up backward," Roan said, and there was something in his voice I hadn't heard from him before. Not

quite awe. Closer to recognition.

"It is simply sound practice," Third said, which I was learning was the thing he said when the truer answer was something he did not have words for.

Tondi, in her corner, had not picked her mending back up. "You saved a town," she said. "And you did not stay. You came here instead."

"I saved the people of a town. The town itself is gone." The eye moved to her. "And I came here because the thing doing this moved anti-spinward, and anti-spinward of that town, on the trail it is following, is here. And then beyond here. I did not come to your town by accident, mender. I came because I believe it is in the path."

I felt that land in my stomach, cold and specific. "You think it's coming here."

"I think it is going somewhere, and that the line it is travelling passes near enough to here that I would not wish to be elsewhere when it does." He let that sit a moment. "But your town is not the destination. Of that I am reasonably certain. Your town has nothing it wants."

"And what does it want?" Tondi asked. "You keep saying a thing. The thing takes one object and leaves the rest. What is the object?"

This was the question. I could feel it was the question, the way you can feel the weight of a room turn toward a single point. Third was quiet for long enough that I thought, again, he might not answer. Then the bellows drew a second time — the second, I noted, the last one I would get from him tonight — and he set both his bifurcated hands flat on the table, which I had never seen him do, and which had the effect of making the wooden parody of a humin look, for a moment, like a man gathering himself to say a hard thing plainly.

"You know that the Titans made the world," he said. "This is told to children. It is also true, which is rarer than you would think for a thing told to children." The eye dimmed slightly — consideration, not grief. "What the children's telling leaves out is how. The Titans did not make the world by wishing it. They made it the way anything is made. With tools. With instruments. Things to cut with, and shape with, and bind one thing to another. Vast things, suited to vast hands."

"Tools," Roan repeated.

"When the Titans fell, the tools did not fall with them. They remained. They are scattered across all of Anka, and most of them are not recognised for what they are. A piece of titanic forge tongs, used as a tower shield; a town built around a bowl-shaped depression that nothing grows within, but the surrounding area is consistently warm; three gears that placed in proximity to each other begin rotating without external power. People walk past these instruments of creation every day and call them landmarks, or curiosities, or hauntings, and they are not wrong to, because the truth is not available to them and the landmark serves them better." The eye came back to me, bright again. "But someone has learned to recognise them. And someone is gathering them."

I had grown up in a world with a wound in its sky and most doors on the second floor and a spire on the horizon that everyone navigated by and no one questioned. I had never once thought of any of it as a thing somebody made. It had simply always been the shape of things. To have Third say it plainly — that the Spire was a tool, that the world was a workshop someone had walked away from — did something to the floor of my understanding that I did not enjoy.

"Why," I said. "Why gather them. What do you do with a — with the tools that made the world?"

"That," Third said, "is what I do not know. Not with certainty." And I believed him, because Third did not pretend to certainties he lacked, which was rarer and more valuable than I had words for at the time. "But I have a fear. The tools that made a thing are the tools that can make it whole again — not mend it, the way you'd mend a chair, but make it, entire, a second time, out of whatever is left of it. And the largest thing that was ever unmade—" "Was a Titan," Tondi said. Quiet. She had got there a breath before I did.

"They made the world," Third said. "They made me, too, in their way — I am one of their tools. I watched it come apart: not into a body you could bury, but into red dust, and into something else — something that went sideways out of the world, and did not entirely leave it… It scattered. And if someone is gathering the tools of creation, then the question I cannot put down is whether they mean to gather a fallen Titan back — to make it whole out of its dust and its absence, and call it down off the far side of the world into this one. To undo the one thing the Virek spent an entire people to do." Nobody said anything.

The fire ticked. Upstairs, faintly, the traveller turned over in his sleep and was quiet again.

"You don't know that's what it's doing," I said, finally. I don't know why I said it. Maybe because someone had to put a hand against the size of the thing. "You said yourself. You don't know."

"I do not," Third agreed. "I may be wrong. I hope to be wrong. I have been wrong before, about smaller things, and the relief was considerable." The eye found me. "But I have learned that when I cannot rule out the worst version of a thing, it is unwise to plan for the comfortable one. So I

am going to find whoever is doing this. And I am going to learn what they want. And if it is what I fear, I am going to stop them, because the last time this was necessary it required an entire people, and that people is gone, and so it appears the task has fallen to whoever is still standing near it." A pause. "Which, at present, is me."

"And us," Roan said.

He said it from the door, and then looked faintly astonished that he had said it, the way you look when a thing you had been deciding turns out to have already been decided somewhere below the place where you do your deciding.

Third turned his head toward him. The whole head.

"That is not a small thing to offer," Third said. "I would have you understand what you are offering before you offer it."

"I heard you," Roan said. "Towns that don't make the maps. People walked past like they weren't worth turning a head for. I'm militia in a town on a trail. If that thing's path runs through here, then standing at the gate with a spear isn't going to be the brave choice. It's just going to be the choice where I die at the gate." He swallowed. "I'd rather go meet it as someone who chose to. With someone who knows what it is."

I looked at Roan, who did not drink for courage, and who had just talked himself into the end of the world with his back against the inn's door, and I understood that whatever happened next, I was not going to be able to watch it from here. That had stopped being available to me somewhere around the word now.

"How soon," I said, for the second time in two days. But this time it wasn't really a question about Third's schedule.

Third's eye came to me, and the glow did the thing I would come to know as close as he came to gentleness.

"That," he said, "is up to you. But I would leave at first light."

* * *

Eight

I closed the inn that night the way I'd closed it a thousand times, except that I was aware of doing it, which was the difference between a thing you do and a thing you are doing for the last time.

I wiped the tables that did not need wiping. I straightened the chairs. I checked the lockbox in the floor, the day's Black inside it — combination set, lever down, lid secured — and I thought about the traveller upstairs, and the town two days spinward that had a lockbox and a memorial pillar and a militia and a closing routine just like this one, right up until it didn't have anything at all. And then I made myself stop thinking about it, because that was a skill I had and there was no sense owning a tool you refused to use.

Tondi was in her corner. She had not gone up to bed, which she always did before I finished, which meant she was staying down on purpose, which meant she had something to say and was working her way around to the angle she wanted to say it from. I let her work. You did not hurry Tondi. Hurrying Tondi was how you got the short version, and the short version was always worse.

Klar had gone home an hour ago. Kanot had come by earlier — Kanot, who had wanted my job since before I'd realised it was a job a person could want, and who had said yes before Tondi finished asking, and who had looked at me with an expression caught between sympathy and the poorly hidden delight of someone inheriting a thing they'd

coveted. I hadn't minded. It is easier to leave a place when you know the place will be fine. That is, I think, why Tondi had arranged it so fast. Not to replace me. To make it easy.

"You've packed," she said. Not a question.

"Roan helped me work out what to bring. Third corrected most of what Roan suggested." I hung the last cloth on its hook. "Apparently I was going to bring far too much of the wrong things and not nearly enough of the right ones, which Third says is the most common way the inexperienced die. Not the monsters. The packing."

"He's not wrong." Tondi's needle went in and out of whatever she was mending, the rhythm of it unbroken, the way it had been unbroken through every important conversation of my life. "Cheerful, that one."

"He grows on you."

"Most things that grow on you should be scraped off." But there was no heat in it. She'd made up her mind about Third somewhere around the second time he'd produced a severed head in her inn without disturbing the room, and Tondi's made-up mind was the most fixed object in the settlement, the Spire included.

I finished the room. There was nothing left to do, which meant there was nothing left to do but the thing we were both not doing.

I sat down across from her. She did not look up. The hair across her face did its work, the way it always had — Tondi conducted the important conversations of her life from behind a grey curtain, so that you could never be entirely sure she was having them.

"I could ask you to come," I said. "You'd be useful. You're more use than Roan and me put together."

"You could ask." The needle did not pause. "I'd say no. So don't, and we'll both save the breath."

"Why?"

It was, I realised as I said it, the first time in my life I had asked Tondi to explain herself. The needle stopped. Just for a moment. Then it went on.

"Because somebody who knows how to fix things has to be where the people are," she said. "Your wooden friend is walking toward the trouble. Good. Somebody should. But there'll be people here when you're gone, the same as there were before you came, and they tear their clothes and split their hands and take fevers, and they need somebody who stays." She pulled the thread taut. "Brave is going. I've nothing against brave. But somebody has to be the thing you come back to. And I have always been better at staying than at almost anything else."

I didn't say anything. There wasn't a safe thing to say.

She set the mending down — which I had perhaps seen her do twice — and reached into the basket at her side, and came up with a small roll of waxed cloth. She put it on the table between us and pushed it across with two fingers, the way she pushed everything she didn't want to be thanked for.

"Needles," she said. "Three. hexwood, anointed proper — not the bone kind that snaps when you breathe on it. And thread, the waxed gut, it'll hold through wet. You'll tear something out there — a pack strap, a coat, your own skin, doesn't matter — and there won't be a mender, because the mender will be here, being the thing you come back to." She still hadn't looked up. "I'd rather you didn't bleed out because you lacked the tools to close a seam. It would reflect poorly on me."

I picked up the roll. It weighed almost nothing. hexwood needles were not nothing — anointing wood that fine took a Crafter's whole patience and a measure of titan-blood

besides, and a mender's needles were the kind of thing that got named in wills, handed down, guarded like teeth. She would have had these longer than she'd employed me.

"Tondi—"

"Don't." The needle was back in her hand; the curtain of hair had closed again. "I mean it. Whatever you're winding up to say. Don't. You'll do it badly and then we'll both have to remember it."

So I didn't.

I put the needles in my coat, the inside pocket, the one over the chest, where you keep the thing you cannot afford to lose. And I stood up, because Roan was going to be at the door before first light and I still had not slept, and standing up was the only way the night was going to agree to end.

At the door I stopped. I couldn't help it. I turned around.

"Tondi."

She was mending. She did not look up. But the needle had stopped, and stayed stopped, which for Tondi was the same as another woman crossing a room with her arms open.

"Don't come looking for work here when you get back," she said, to the shirt in her lap. "Kanot's got your job, and I won't put a good worker out to take back one who ran off chasing Titanspawn across the world. You hear me? There's no job here for you."

When you get back. Not if. She had built the whole gruff little speech around a word she would have died before saying outright, and she had handed it to me anyway, wrapped in an insult so I could carry it without either of us having to look at it directly.

"I hear you," I said.

"Good." The needle started again. "Go on, then. Mind the seam on that coat, the left shoulder's going. I'd have got to it if you'd given me another day."

"I know."

"Go."

I went.

Roan was at the door, as it turned out, just lifting his hand to knock, with the particular look of a man who had also not slept and had decided that arriving early was a way of being brave about it. Behind him the sky had that first grey thinning at the edge of the Scar that meant the dark was an hour from breaking.

I did not look back at the inn as we walked toward the gate. I had looked back once already, at the only thing in there worth looking back at, and she had told me to go, and I was not going to spoil the single clean thing either of us had managed by doing it twice.

But I put my hand flat against my chest, over the inside pocket, where the needles were.

Just to be sure they were still there.

They were.

* * *

We left at first light — the Scar's edge going from black to charcoal to the flat grey that passes for morning, the change creeping across the sky the way water creeps across a floor, without any particular moment you could point to and call the start of the day.

We hadn't gone half a mile before the reeds started up. I'd heard them my whole life without once being out in them at the right moment to hear them properly — the bellow reeds that grew in stands along the low ground beside the road, tall and hollow and brown, and when the

small wind that comes with the Scar's turning moved through them they let out a sound I can only call mourning: a low, tuneless moan, dozens of hollow throats at once, rising as the grey came up and falling as it settled. The morning bellow. Tondi had set the inn's whole day by it for as long as I'd known her — bread on at the first moan, shutters down at the evening one — and I'd thought of it, when I thought of it at all, as a thing the reeds did, the same as the Scar was a thing the sky did. Out here, with no walls to flatten it, it was enormous, and I understood for the first time that it was the nearest thing my whole country had to a clock. Roan walked into it without a flicker; he'd soldiered these roads and the sound was wallpaper to him. Third listened — the eye tracking the nearest stand as we passed, the small tilt that meant he was filing a thing away. "A loud stand, in a strong wind, will cover the sound of a man's feet entirely," he said, to no one in particular. "It is worth knowing which sounds in a country are the ones a person can hide inside." And he walked on, and left me to decide whether he'd handed me a piece of lore or a piece of warning — a distinction, I was learning, he didn't trouble to make.

Nine

The gate was a different thing in the light. At night it had been a threat held off by spikes; now it was just a gap in a wall, with Pek leaning on the frame the way the militia always leaned on things, and the packed earth of the trail running out through it toward a horizon I had looked at my whole life and never once walked into.

There were not many to see us off. That suited everyone. A Forged leaving with two of the town's own was not the kind of thing you gathered to celebrate; it was the kind of thing you watched from a window with the shutter open just enough. I could feel the town doing exactly that around us, the way you can feel a room you've turned your back on.

Third stood a little apart, as he always did, his cloak doing its inadequate work and his one eye already turned toward the trail, toward the part of the morning that had not arrived yet. He had done this before. I understood that without being told — that for Third a gate was a gate, and a leaving was a leaving, and he had crossed more of both than there were names on every memorial pillar in the world. He was waiting for us to be finished being people about it.

Klar came running up just as Pek pushed the gate the rest of the way open.

"You almost left," he said, accusingly, out of breath, shoving a wrapped bundle into my arms. It was heavier than it looked and warm at the bottom. "Travel bread, the

dense kind, it keeps. And the rest of the Shredder, smoked — don't make that face, it's good, I brined it. And there's a twist of the blue salt in the middle, don't lose it, that's the expensive one." He stopped, having run out of inventory, and then out of the thing under the inventory, which was the part he didn't have words for. "Just. Eat properly. He won't remind you." He jerked his head at Third. "He doesn't eat."

"I'll eat properly."

"You won't, but I tried." He stepped back, suddenly awkward, five thousand spins old again instead of the competent thing he became around a stove. "Bring the salt twist back if you don't use it. It's really expensive."

"I'll bring it back."

It was the second time in two mornings someone had handed me a thing I was meant to bring back, and I was beginning to understand that this was how the people who couldn't come with you said the thing they couldn't say: they gave you an errand. A reason shaped like an object. Come back, because the needles are mine. Come back, because the salt is expensive. Nobody said come back. Everybody said it.

Then we went through the gate.

I had expected it to feel like something. A line crossed, a door shut, some interior click of before and after. It didn't. It felt like walking, which is all it was — the spikes sliding past on either side, sharpened logs I'd seen ten thousand times and never from this angle, and then the open trail, and then the town was behind us and the morning was in front of us and my legs were just doing the ordinary thing legs do.

The Spire was on the horizon where it always was. From the town you mostly saw it over the rooftops, a thin dark

line you navigated by without thinking, the way you navigate by a thing you've decided is permanent. Out here, with nothing between us and it but a great deal of distance, I could see the gold catch at its tip where the Scar's grey light found it. Spireward was that way. Everything was measured from it. I had known that since before I could walk and had never once had a reason to care, and now I was walking across the actual world it stood in the middle of, and the knowing turned over in my chest into something that felt strange and large and not entirely comfortable.

We walked. Roan beside me, Third a few paces ahead at a pace he'd clearly chosen to be followable. The trail rose toward a low hill — the first hill, the one that from town was just the edge of the world you could see, the place the trail went to disappear.

I knew that when we crested it, the town would go behind us. The pillar, the inn, the gatehouse, all of it, dropping below the line of the land like a coin into a pocket.

I did not look back.

So I kept my eyes on Third's back and the gold on the horizon and the dense warm weight of Klar's bundle in my arms, and I walked over the hill and did not turn around, and I was, I think, a little proud of myself for it.

Roan looked back.

I saw him do it — at the crest, just before the town would have gone — a quick turn of the head, the way you check whether someone is watching you leave. I knew the look. I'd worn it. It was the look of a person who needs the leaving to have been witnessed, because a brave thing done where no one sees it doesn't yet feel, to a certain kind of young man, entirely real.

I didn't know yet whether anyone had been at the gate to see him. I didn't ask. It seemed like the kind of thing a person should be allowed to keep to himself, at least at the start, before the road taught him what I suspected it was going to teach him — that the looking back stops mattering somewhere out there, and that the not-needing-to is a thing you earn rather than decide.

Then the hill was behind us too, and the town with it, and there was only the trail and the grey morning and the gold pin of the Spire holding the whole flat world in place.

Some part of me had spent my whole life believing nothing would ever change in a quiet town. That part had been right, in its way. The town hadn't changed. The town was exactly where I'd left it, doing exactly what it had always done, and would go on doing it without me, with Kanot wiping my tables and Tondi mending its torn shoulders and Klar feeding whoever was hungry.

It was just that I was no longer in it.

"How far to the first stop?" I asked, because the silence had gone on long enough and because I had discovered that I did not want to walk inside my own head any further just then.

"Four days to the causeway," Third said, without turning. "If the weather holds and you keep up." A pause. The glow of his eye angled back at me, just slightly, the head not following. "You will keep up. You are already doing better than most."

"That's almost encouraging."

"It was meant to be entirely encouraging. I am told I lack the range."

Roan laughed — surprised out of him, the first real laugh since the gate — and Third's eye held on us a moment longer, bright in the grey light, before turning

back to the trail.

We walked on toward the causeway, and the Spire, and the thing at the end of it that none of us yet understood, and behind us the town did not change at all.

* * *

Ten

We saw it on the third day, which was a day earlier than Third had said, and I learned something about distance on Anka that the trail between two larger settlements had never taught me: that a thing can be visible long before it is near, and that the gap between the two is where your legs find out what they are made of.

The country we crossed to reach it had already begun the work of unteaching me. I had spent my life in a day's walk of the inn, in soft managed land — fields, the near woods, the road — and I had thought, without ever putting it to myself, that the world was mostly that, with the strange parts kept out beyond it like weather. I had it backwards. The soft land was the exception. The world the Titan left was the rule, and the rule was wild.

On the second day the trail brought us up against something I will not forget if I live to be as old as Third. The ground had been broken — not cut, not trenched, but *broken,* the way a frozen puddle breaks when you put your heel through it, or the way dried mud lifts and curls back from its own cracks on a hot day, except that here the puddle was the bedrock of the world. Great slabs of grey stone stood heaved up out of the earth at every angle, some tilted, some standing near on end, twice and three times Third's height, their broken edges raw and jagged against the sky, leaning on one another and fallen apart with gaps between where the trail had to thread. It was as if a whole sheet of stone had been stepped through from underneath and left frozen mid-shatter, every shard thrust up and

pointing nowhere. Folk call them titan footprints. The country is stitched with them — you can walk a tenday and cross a dozen — and some sit heaped in a rough oval you could read as a heel and a sole if you wanted to frighten yourself, and some only wander, broken slab after broken slab, the way a thing might stagger. Third laid his wooden hand flat against one of the tilted faces as we passed, the way you'd lay a hand on the flank of a big animal to feel whether it was breathing.

"Walking, or dragged, or thrown down," he said.

"I was not told which. The stone will not say." It should have felt like ruin — dead, and long done. It felt like picking a path through a mouth full of broken teeth.

The teeth had one bite left in them. Roan, hurrying for the open light at the far edge, put his boot down among the loose rubble at the base of the last slab — and the rubble bit him. He went down with a yelp, hauling at his leg, and clamped to the side of his boot was what I'd have sworn a breath earlier was only another fist-sized stone: a land oyster, shut tight as a miser's purse, gripping with a strength its size had no business owning. It had taken the boot and not the foot, which was luck and nothing else. Third knelt, worked the point of a Falka into the seam of the shell, and the thing let go all at once with a wet click. Roan called it several names. Third turned it over, considered it without expression, and said, "Supper." It was the nearest thing to a joke I'd yet had out of him — and the meat of it, that night, was good, whatever Roan muttered about being ambushed by lunch. Most things out here were hungry, one way or another; at least this one paid us back for it.

And that evening we came through the shards.

I had met a shard tree before — there's a lone one behind the mender's, and Tondi used to send me out to

sweep the fallen leaves before some fool stepped on them barefoot. So I thought I knew the word. I did not know the word. What we walked into that evening was a forest of them grown the way they grow when nobody cuts them, which is to say *up,* and up, and up — slender pale trunks like a thousand bare masts, bone-coloured, naked the whole of their ridiculous height, with nothing on them at all until, very far overhead, each one burst into a single crown of the amber glass-leaves, so that the whole stand had a floor of pale pillars and a roof of glittering amber you could not have reached with a thrown stone. The light came down through it broken into coins. Underfoot the ground was black and soft and rich as a turned kitchen garden, thick with the amber that had already come down — though little of it stayed amber long: the fallen leaves went brittle, then to flakes, then to dark crumb, quicker than any leaf I knew, until the grove seemed to be quietly feeding on its own shed glass. It was, I think, the most beautiful thing I had seen in my life, and I said so, and Third said "wait," and the wind came up.

The sound started overhead — a tinkling, a million tiny glass bells, lovely, and then less lovely, then a hiss running through the crowns far above as the harder gusts took hold, and Third said "down, and still," and we crouched, and the beautiful roof began to come apart and rain itself down on us. Amber leaves, thin as a fingernail and edged like one of Tondi's good shears, turning and flashing as they fell the whole long way from the crowns, sticking point-first into the leaf litter around us with a sound like soft sleet. One opened a line across the back of my hand I never felt arrive. Roan took one through the meat of his shoulder and swore. Third simply knelt over the two of us with his cloak spread and his back to the sky and let the glass break against him, patient as the rock walls, while

the trees sang their gorgeous lethal song twenty men's height above and shed knives until the wind got bored and moved on.

When it stopped, the floor around us glittered with fallen amber, and the crowns overhead were thinner, and just as beautiful, and I understood the shape of the lesson the country was teaching: that here the beautiful thing and the thing that would kill you were not two different things you could learn to tell apart. They were the same thing, and it depended entirely on the wind, and the wind did as it pleased.

The thinned crowns did not trouble Third. "They grow as fast as they shed," he said, already moving us on. "A thumb's length in a day. More, where the ground is good — and the ground is always good here." He did not say why, but I had stood ankle-deep in that black rich earth, and I had seen what the storm cut down, and a few paces on I worked out the why for myself and wished I hadn't. A grove like that never starved, because the wind saw to its feeding, and not with leaves alone. Whatever the glass brought down and the night caught out — a slow bird, a slower beast, a traveller too proud to crouch — went into the same dark crumb in the end and came back up the pale trunks as crown. The shards grew back so fast because nothing they killed was ever wasted.

So when, on the third day, I thought I saw a wall of cloud sitting low on the horizon, the flat grey kind that means weather, I had already half-learned not to trust my first read of anything.

Then, over the next half-day, it refused to behave like weather — it did not move, did not thin, did not climb. It only resolved, slowly, into a line. A straight line, laid across the world from one edge of sight to the other, too level to be a ridge and too long to be anything a person would

build.

"The causeway," Roan said, when it had become undeniable. He said it the way you say a word you've only ever heard, trying it in your mouth to see if it fits the thing in front of you. It didn't, quite. No word would have.

"The Emperor's Causeway," Third said. "Though there was no emperor. The name attached itself later, the way names do, looking for an owner that suits the size of the thing."

We reached its foot near dark, and dark was the first time I understood it properly, because in the failing light I could no longer see the whole impossible length of it and was left with only the part directly above me, which was enough.

It was a bridge. That was the simplest true thing to say about it, the way Third would have said it. A bridge wide enough that I counted, out loud, like a child — twelve men could have walked it shoulder to shoulder, and there would have been room left over for their packs. It stood on arches that lifted the roadway six men high, and the arches marched away into the dark in both directions with the patience of something that had been marching since before there was anyone to watch. The stone was a single piece. I walked up and put my hand on the nearest pillar and there was no seam in it, no mortar, no mark of a tool. It was not built the way a wall is built, stone on stone. It was simply one stone, the size of a bridge that crossed the world, and someone had decided it should be that shape and it had agreed.

"It does not connect to anything," Third said, beside me, his eye moving along the dark span. "I have walked considerable lengths of it, in my time. It begins where it begins and ends where it ends and neither place is anywhere. There is a theory that it moved troops during

the war. The theory does not survive contact with the route. No front it could have served lies along its line, and the kinds of things the Titans made for war did not march in tidy columns that required a road." The bellows drew, once, low. "I think it was made because making it was possible. I think a great deal of the world was made for that reason. It is the explanation that fits the evidence, and it is also the one that frightens people, which is perhaps why they prefer the emperor who never existed."

I took my hand off the stone. I didn't like the way it was not-cold — not warm either, just absent of temperature, the way deep water is — or how I imagined the inside of the Scar might be, if you could touch it.

"You've walked it," I said. "When?"

A pause. Not the arithmetic kind. The other kind.

"Early," Third said. "I was very new to thinking, and it was a good place to do it. Long and straight and empty, and nothing on it that wanted anything from me." The eye came to me, the glow steady. "I have not been back to it until now. I find that I had forgotten how large it is. That is unusual. I do not generally forget sizes."

He didn't explain further, and I had learned by then not to push at the doors Third left ajar — he closed them if you pushed, and opened them on his own if you waited. So I waited, and he didn't open it, not then, and we made camp at the foot of the nearest ramp.

We did not make it under the arches, and Third was particular about that. The underside of the span, where the pillars swelled to meet the roadway, was pocked with gaps, and in the gaps — once I knew to look — were the crabs: broad flat things the exact mottled grey of the stone they wedged into, so still and so well matched that the whole vast belly of the causeway might have been crawling and

you'd never have known it by daylight. "They eat what the road lets fall," Third said. "In the dark phase they are less particular about whether it has stopped moving first." So we slept out in the open, a clear stone's-throw from the nearest pillar, and I lay a long time listening to the small dry scrape of them working the arches overhead, and decided the bare ground was the friendliest thing the causeway had shown us yet.

* * *

The ramps were how you got up onto it. They corkscrewed around the pillars at intervals Third said ran a thousand paces apart, give or take, the whole length of the thing — gentle spirals a cart could have climbed, if there had been carts, or anything to pull them. The embankments where they met the ground were furred with driftcane, the one growing thing that seemed to want the causeway's company: pale jointed stalks rooted shallow and wide in the scoured soil, rattling at every gust. Twice on the climb a whole stand of it tore loose somewhere above and came bowling down the spiral past us, a tumbling haystack of cane that made Roan flinch and swear and me laugh at him, which I needed. Third gathered an armful of the dry fallen stuff without breaking stride — cut and bound, he said, it was worth the carrying: light, and strong, and good for a splint or a tent-pole or a dozen other things the road would eventually ask for.

In the morning I climbed one and got my first proper look at the road by daylight, and that was when the causeway stopped being a wonder and started being a wrongness. Nothing grew on it. Not the way nothing grows on a swept floor — the way nothing grows on glass. The roadway ran out ahead of us, bare grey stone the width of twelve men, and the moss and blown soil that should have

found a seam to root in over an age had found none, because there were no seams; there was nothing for a root to take hold of, the same one impossible stone all the way down. Only at the very lip of the road, where grit and leaf-fall banked against the low parapet, did anything green get a start, and even that looked provisional, as if the road might shrug it off whenever it remembered to. And the trees. I have to describe the trees, because they were the part that made Roan go quiet, and Roan did not go quiet easily.

On both sides of the causeway, for a stone's throw out, there were no trees. The forest came up to that line — a hard, clean line, running the whole visible length of the road — and stopped, as if it had been told to. Beyond the line the forest was ordinary, dense and green and getting on with its business. Inside it, nothing taller than grass. Not cut. Not burned. Just held, the way you'd hold a dog back by the collar, spin on spin on spin, without ever quite letting it forget it wanted to come forward.

"Something holds this back," I said.

"The road does," Third said. He said it without drama, the way you'd state the weather.

"It has held the forest off itself since before either of us, and it will go on holding it off after. It is of a piece with the rest — the stone that takes no seam, the cold that is not cold, the span that joins nowhere to nowhere. It does not rot, because it does not take part in the rules the rest of us rot under. I do not know how it does any of it. I have had three hundred thousand spins to not know, and the time has not helped." The eye travelled the bare stone ahead, level and unhurried.

"What I do know is that it is the fastest, most open ground in a country that offers neither, and that in all my walking of it nothing has ever once objected to my

company. I would rather walk a road that unsettles me for reasons I can name than a trail that hides the ones I cannot." He started forward.

"We walk it in daylight. And we keep to the centre, well clear of the edge."

"Why the edge?"

"Because it is a long way down," he said, "into a forest that has spent an age wanting up." I looked at the held-back green lying quiet on either side, six men below the parapet, and decided I had not needed that explained.

* * *

We had meant to resupply at the causeway. Third had said, back in the planning, that the ramps sometimes drew people — that a raised road with cleared sightlines and a stone's-throw of open ground on either side was, to the right kind of traveller, the safest camp in a dangerous stretch of country, and that where travellers gathered, someone always turned up to sell them things at a markup.

We found the someones near midday, at the fourth ramp along, and it was not the lone pedlar I'd pictured from Third's telling. It was a camp. A loose ring of carts drawn up on the broad apron where the ramp met the ground — two dozen and more, painted in colours that had long since given up being bright, shafts turned inward, canvas sides let down into walls; cook-fires smoking; a picket line of goats, lean and patient, and here and there a dog dozing in a cart's shade; washing strung between wheels; a knot of children chasing something I couldn't see, and two old women not watching them with great skill. A whole travelling town of folk who lived on the move and had decided, the same as Third would have, that a raised stone road with a stone's-throw of cleared ground on every side was the one place in this country a person might close both

eyes at once. Where travellers gathered, Third had said, someone always turned up to sell them things — and here were a hundred someones, selling to each other and to whatever the road brought, waiting out the bad stretch in the best spot it had. The ramps sometimes drew people. He had undersold it.

We picked our trader for no better reason than that he looked us over with neither fear nor appetite — one stall among the many, a Hin, broad and unhurried, with what I took to be his grown children working the cart at his back: dried goods, waxed cord, the small necessary nothings that a journey eats. He watched us come with the flat patience of a man who has sold to stranger customers than two nervous youths.

Third stayed up on the road.

He did it without discussion, the way he did most of the things that made him easier to be near — drifted a little apart as we approached, found a place at the edge of the road where he could watch both the span and us, and became, in the way he had, part of the scenery. I understood it by now. People haggled better when they were not being watched by something that had been built to end them. And someone had to keep watching the road.

So I went down and did the trading, with Roan at my shoulder learning how it was done, and the Hin sold me waxed cord and dried fish and a block of the dense travel-fat that you melt into everything to make the walking possible, and he took Klar's overpayment instincts out of me one Black at a time, and it was — I want to set this down plainly, because there was so little of it on that road and I did not know yet how little was coming — it was *nice*. A small ordinary transaction in the morning air, a Hin grumbling about his prices the way Tondi grumbled about her seams, Roan asking too many questions and getting

answers anyway.

"You'll be going anti-spin," the Hin said. Not a question. He was wrapping the fish.

"We will," I said.

He glanced up the long bare run of the road, and then — quickly, the way you touch a bruise to check it's still there — at Third, up on the high stone with his back to us, watching the distance.

"Folk go anti-spin up the high road," he said, quiet, just for me, "and you don't always see 'em come back down it. Could be it's only a long road. Could be it ain't. We sell at the foot of the ramp and we sleep in the trees and we let that road keep its own counsel." He knotted the cord on the parcel.

"No charge for the saying. You've the look of folk who'll want every Black." I paid him anyway, and carried the warning up the ramp along with the fish, and gave it to Third, who received it the way he received most things — as confirmation of a sum he had already finished adding.

"He is wise," was all Third said. Then he shouldered back into his cloak, and we walked on, anti-spinward, down the centre of a road that held a whole forest at arm's length on either side, under a sky with a wound rotating slowly across it.

Behind us the camp grew small — the carts, the smoke, the strung washing, the Hin lifting one broad hand without looking up from his weighing — and then the ramp grew small too, and then there was only the road, running straight as a drawn line toward the place none of us could see yet: bare and patient and wholly indifferent, holding the green world off its back as it had long before us, and meaning to long after.

* * *

Eleven

The carts had been on the road a long time.

There were four of them, hand-carts of the kind the Hin trader had, overturned and dragged half across the road and left — not recently, the wood gone grey and splitting, one wheel still turning a slow finger's-width back and forth when the wind found it. Whatever had happened here had happened to people going the other way, spinward, toward the town and the trader and the ordinary world, and had happened all at once, the way the bad things on this road seemed to.

"Pulled across deliberate," Roan said, crouching at the nearest. He'd got better at this — at reading a scene before walking into it, at not touching the first thing his hands wanted to touch. "Like a barricade. Someone tried to make a wall of them."

"It didn't work," I said.

"No." He stood. "It didn't."

There was no blood, which somehow was worse than blood would have been; blood at least tells you a story with an ending. This just told you people had been here, and had been afraid enough to throw their whole livelihood into a wall across the road, and then were not here anymore, and the carts had stayed to think about it for a few hundred spins.

The wall of them was too high and tangled to climb cleanly with packs, and the cleared margin on either side dropped off the edge of the causeway into the held-back

forest six men below. Roan and I stood there working out the puzzle of it — over, or down and around, or unstack the topmost cart and risk the whole rotten heap coming down — the ordinary arithmetic of an obstacle, the kind of problem I'd have welcomed an hour earlier for being a problem I could actually solve.

Third had gone quiet beside me. I noticed it the way you notice a sound stopping. He was looking at the wall of carts and not, I thought, really seeing it — the glow of his eye had gone soft and far-off, the way a person's eyes go when they're doing sums in their head or remembering a road, and he had begun, very slightly, to drift. Not toward the carts. Past them, somehow, at an angle I couldn't have drawn. He took a step like a man stepping off a kerb he'd walked a thousand times without looking.

"Third," I said, turning to ask him which way he thought, "do we—"

He wasn't there.

I want to be precise about this, because I have tried since to describe it to people who weren't on that road and have always failed. He had been standing at my shoulder. He did not walk away. He did not flicker or fade or do any of the things a story would give him to do. He simply stepped — sideways, at an angle that my eye refused to hold, the way you can't quite look at the place a reflection comes from — and the step took him out of the world, and the space where he had been was just air, with the dead carts beyond it.

It did not look like a decision. That was the thing I kept, after. It looked like a habit. It looked like the most natural thing in the world for him to do, and the most natural thing in the world is the one you do without remembering you have company.

Roan made a sound. I don't think he knew he made it.

◆ ◆ ◆

Sideways was grey.

It was always grey, and it was always quiet in the particular way that is not the absence of sound but its opposite, a pressure, a held breath the size of a world. Third had stepped this way more times than he could have counted if counting had mattered here, and it never mattered here. The causeway hung beside him as a smear of pale light, the carts a darker smudge in it, the held-back forest a green rumour far below. He had only to walk a little way along the grey and step back into the world past the obstruction. Seconds, on the other side. It was, as he would tell the Humin girl when he stepped back, faster.

But the grey did not only carry him forward. It had never only carried him forward. The grey was where the things he did not look at directly went to wait for him, and it was patient, and it was very old, and when he walked through it the old things rose up to walk beside him whether he had asked them to or not.

The carts were overturned. A wall of overturned things, thrown up by the frightened, that had not held.

And he was somewhere else, and it was long ago, and the things thrown down around him were not carts.

* * *

The village had been small. He understood that the way he understood everything in those first spins of his thinking — as information, arriving flat and complete, with no one yet home behind it to be moved by it. Small village. Virek. Perhaps forty dwellings, the woven-wall kind the green ones favoured, most of them open now, their walls broken outward.

His single eye moved across it and lit what it found. Blood on a wall, dark and dried at the edges, fresh and wet at the centre, pooled below the nearest body. The body was Virek and had been for a long time and would not be much longer; already the green was going grey. There were a great many bodies. He had counted them before he chose to, the count arriving the way the smallness of the village had arrived, unbidden and exact, and he made himself stop knowing the number because the number had begun to feel like a thing he should not be holding so lightly.

His hand held a glaive. The blade was wet.

He looked at the blade for a long time.

You are Forged to eliminate the Virek, the thoughts said. They were not cruel. They had never been cruel. Cruelty would have been easier to set down. They were only certain, the way the ground is certain, the way falling is. *This is the purpose. This is the whole of the purpose.*

There was an arrow in his garb, high on the shoulder, driven through the woven cords that served him for muscle and stopped by the wood beneath. It was a clean arrow, unfired-looking, absurd. And the blood on the cords around it was older than the arrow — he could see that, he could see that the blood had dried before the shaft ever found him, which meant the blood was not from this wound, which meant the blood was from the blade, which meant —

He did not finish the thought. It was the first thing he had ever declined to finish.

He could not tell. That was the truth of it, then and after and for every spin that would ever come after: he stood in the wreck of a village with a wet blade in his hand and blood on his armour that was not his own and he could not tell whether he had been one of the ones who made the wall of bodies, or had only arrived in time to stand among

it. The others like him had done this. He knew that. He had perhaps done this. He would never know, and the not-knowing would walk in the grey with him forever, and it was walking with him now.

Then the crying.

It was small and furious and entirely alive, and it came from a bundle near the broken wall of the nearest dwelling, and when his eye found it the crying did not stop, which was itself a kind of marvel — every other living thing he had come near in those early spins had stopped, had frozen or fled. This one only lay on its back and flailed its small green limbs and howled at the torn sky as if the sky had personally done this and owed it an answer.

A Virek, the thoughts said. *Eliminate it. The purpose is not complete while one remains.*

"It seems immobile," he said. His voice surprised him, in the quiet, among the dead. It always surprised him then. "It cannot have done anything. It cannot even turn over."

That is not the measure. The measure is what it is, not what it has done.

He looked at the small howling thing. He looked at the wet blade in his hand. And he watched his own arm — he remembered this exactly, the watching, as though the arm belonged to someone he was only distantly responsible for — reach down, open, and gather the bundle up by its wrappings, the blade forgotten, fallen, thumping once on the bloodied ground.

The wrappings began to tear.

"These will not hold for long," he told it, as though it had asked.

So he knelt among the people he might have killed, and he took the clothing from one of the dead — gently, which no one was there to see, which the thoughts informed him

was wasted gentleness, which he did anyway — and he fashioned from it a harness, a sling, the kind he had seen the green ones carry their young in, before. He worked the knots with two fingers and a thumb of each bifurcated hand, slow, clumsy, learning it as he did it.

"This will hold for longer."

He put the child into the sling and drew it against the wooden cage of his chest, against the slow bellows that moved there, and the crying changed. It frayed, and softened, and came apart into long shuddering sobs, and then into something that was almost only breathing.

He went very still.

"That was unexpected," he said. "If I were to guess — you find this comfortable. The sound. The motion of the bellows, perhaps." The thing against his chest hitched once and was quiet. "I did not know I could be of use in that way. I have not, until now, been built for it."

It is consuming time. It will consume more. Set it down. The purpose —

"I have heard the purpose," he said, and it was the first time he had answered the thoughts aloud, and the sound of his own refusal in the dead village was the strangest thing that had happened to him since the dust. "I have heard it a great deal. I am choosing, instead, this."

And he turned away from the direction his own kind had gone — he could feel them out there, the unwoken ones, moving on to the next thing their thoughts told them to move on to — and he walked the other way, out of the village, into the trees, with a Virek child breathing against the place where his heart was not.

Behind him in the pale red dust that lay over everything in those spins, the dust that had woken him and had not stopped settling since, he left two cloven prints and the

small dragged smudge of a sling, and nothing else, and no name yet for the thing he carried, because he did not yet know it would need one, or that he would be the one to give it, or what it would cost him, in the end, to have been the one who did.

* * *

The grey took it back. It always took it back. It gave him these things and then it took them back and left him holding only the walking, which was its single mercy and the reason, he suspected, that he had never stopped.

He stepped sideways, into the world, on the far side of the carts.

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He was on the far side of the cart-wall.

Not appearing, exactly — just suddenly accounted for, standing on the swept stone beyond the wreck as though he'd been there the whole time and we'd merely failed to notice him. For a breath he stayed facing anti-spinward, away from us, already half a step into walking on, the way you carry on down a road you've walked alone for longer than there have been roads.

Then he stopped.

I watched it happen — watched the moment the habit let go of him and he remembered. His head came round, and the glow of his eye came back up from wherever it had gone, and he looked at the two of us standing on the wrong side of a wall of dead carts, and something in the set of him changed. He had left us. He had not meant to, and he had done it as easily as breathing, and now he saw that he had done it.

He came back — not sideways, and not over. He did not climb to our side and start the crossing again from where

we stood. He stayed where his own habit had carried him, on the far side of the wreck, and he set his hands to the barricade from there, and began, without a word, to take it apart toward us.

It was not the effortless thing a story would have given him. He was stronger than a man — stronger than Roan and me together, I'd have guessed — but he was not a windlass, and the carts were heavy and snarled and half-rotted into one another, and he worked them the way a patient person works a knot: a cart rocked up onto its edge and walked round on one corner, a wheel freed and rolled aside, a shaft lifted clear and laid down out of the path. What he had that we did not was not size. It was that he never strained against a thing and gave up, never stopped to breathe, never needed the small rests a body needs. He simply continued, at the same steady rate, until the stone showed through between us.

"That one next," he said, when he reached the rotten cart at the top, the one Roan and I had been afraid to touch. "Take the wheel side. I will take the weight." And he eased it down clear of the path, the two of them, as gently as if it might still have had someone in it.

So we opened the barricade between us, Third from his side and Roan and I from ours, meeting in the middle of it, and none of us spoke of the other thing, the sideways thing, because Roan plainly did not have words for it and I plainly did, and mine were all questions, and there is a time for questions and it is not while you are standing on a road that keeps itself otherwise clear for reasons of its own.

But I looked at him while we worked. I couldn't help it. The glow of his eye had gone down to its lowest ember, the way a banked fire goes, and once — easing a shaft down to the stone — his bellows drew long and slow, the sound it made only at the weights I had learned to watch for,

though the shaft was no great burden and nothing we'd handled all day had drawn that sound from him before. He stood a moment when the path was clear, among the carts he'd moved, as though the few grey seconds he'd spent crossing had been a great deal longer than ours, and had asked something of him that the work never could.

"Third," I said. "Are you—"

"I am the same when I return as when I leave," he said. "It costs me nothing you need fear."

It was, I would understand much later — when I knew more than I wanted to and could not give the knowing back — the only thing Third ever told me that I am certain he believed and that was not true.

"We should keep moving," he said, before I could find the shape of any of it. "We are losing the light. And I find I would like to be off this road before dark, today, more than I usually do."

He didn't say why. I didn't ask. We walked on anti-spinward down the swept and watched-over road, the three of us together, and I did not learn for a long time what he had carried across it, or that he had carried it at all.

* * *

Twelve

We came off the causeway after travelling it for two days, by one of the corkscrew ramps. The last of the high country had been more of the world insisting on itself — a stretch where the trail crossed a field of low sterile rings, perfect circles of bare grey dirt a few paces across with a sickly green tree dead-centre of each, no grass, no weed, nothing growing under them but the next identical sapling pushing up at the ring's edge to start its own circle of starvation. These I knew — occluding trees, the farmers near home called them, and hated them — and we walked between the rings the way you'd walk between graves, and nobody spoke, and the trees drank the life out of the dirt in their tidy obsessive circles and asked us for nothing. So when the ramp let us down into ordinary country that felt like a held breath let out, and for half a day the trail was just a trail and the trees were just trees, I believed in the world again — not because the world had earned it, but because I wanted it so badly that half a day of plain green was enough to buy me.

Then the trees changed.

It wasn't sudden. That was the first wrong thing about it — there was no edge to the place, no line like the held-back margin of the causeway, no moment you could point to and say *here, it starts here.* The ordinary forest simply thinned and was replaced, tree by tree, the way one word in a sentence gets replaced until you look up and the sentence means something else, and by the time I understood what I was looking at we had been walking in it for some while

already, which I did not like, because it meant the place had got in before I noticed the door.

Every tree was bent the same way.

Not bent like wind-bent, all leaning from a prevailing weather. Not bent like reaching, the way trees crowd toward light. Each trunk came up out of the ground and then turned — a long, smooth, deliberate-looking curve, low down, near the root — and then straightened again and went up true, so that every tree in that forest stood vertical at the top and yet carried, down near the earth, the identical memory of having once leaned hard in a single direction. The same direction. Every one. As far into the green as I could see, a whole forest of trunks all making the same turn at the same height, like a field of people caught in the instant of flinching from the same blow.

"Snake Forest," Roan said. His voice came out wrong, too flat, the voice of someone keeping a lid on. "My gran used to — there's a rhyme. About not counting the trees." He stopped. "I don't remember how it goes."

"Then do not try to remember it," Third said.

* * *

There is nothing to tell about the Snake Forest, which is exactly the thing that is hard to tell. Nothing happened. Nothing moved. Nothing came out of the green at us with teeth. If you asked me to list the events of the worst stretch of country we crossed in all that journey, I would have nothing to give you but a list of things that did not occur, and the slow unbearable accumulation of them.

The trees did not move. I want that on the record, because the whole long day was a war against the conviction that they had. You would look at one — a particular trunk, its curve, the way it almost made a shape if you held it wrong in your eye — and you would walk, and

you would look away to mind your feet, and when you looked back the conviction would be on you cold and total that it had shifted while your eyes were elsewhere, that the curve was at a different angle now, that it had been facing the path and was now facing *you.* And you could not prove it hadn't. That was the engine of the place. You could never prove it hadn't, because you had looked away, and looking away was the one thing a body cannot stop itself doing.

It got into your head through that crack and then it widened the crack.

The thing I have never been able to explain to anyone is how a place with no enemy in it can exhaust you more thoroughly than a fight. By midday — if it was midday; the Scar's light came down grey and even through the canopy and gave us nothing to steer by — Roan had stopped talking entirely and walked with his hand wrapped white-knuckled around the haft of his spear, turning, every few paces, to check the trees behind us. There was nothing behind us. He checked anyway. He could not stop checking, and the checking was eating him, and there was nothing I could say that the place did not immediately turn sour in my mouth before I could say it.

Because it was getting into me too, and it had found the door it wanted.

I am good at not thinking about things. I have said this already and it is the truest thing about me and it is, I understand now, the reason the Snake Forest nearly had me — because a place whose whole craft is making you think about things had, in me, found a person who had spent her whole life building a door against exactly that, and there is nothing a pressure loves like a door. It got my father first. It got him up out of wherever I keep him and stood him in front of me on the trail — not a memory, nothing so kind as a memory, just the fact of him, the

elsewhere of him, the question I never let myself ask about why elsewhere had always been so easy for him to choose. Then it got the inn, and Tondi, and the needles over my heart, and the cold arithmetic of how unlikely it was that I would ever use them anywhere she would hear how it went. Then it got the simplest, worst one, the one I had been not-thinking since the gate: *what are you doing out here. You serve stew. You are going to die in the green for a wooden man's quarrel and no one will ever find the pieces.*

"He's not even one of us," Roan said.

I don't know how long he'd been walking with that in him before it came out. It came out quiet and reasonable and absolutely poisonous, and it was aimed at Third's back, ten paces ahead.

"He doesn't feel it," Roan said. "Look at him. Walks through here like it's a meadow. He doesn't feel any of it, and he's the reason we're in it, and we're going to leave our minds in these trees so he can chase a — a thing he isn't even sure is real—"

"Roan." It came out of me harder than I meant, and meaner, and the meanness felt *good*, which was how I knew. "Shut your mouth."

"You shut yours. You've wanted to say it too. I've watched you—"

"I have known you four days and every one of them you've needed someone to tell you you're brave—"

I heard it land. I watched it land on him, the exact cruel place I'd aimed it without deciding to aim anywhere, and the small hot satisfaction of having hurt him curdled even as it arrived, and that was the thing, that was the whole horror of the place laid bare in a sentence: it did not invent anything. It had nothing to put in us that we had not

brought in ourselves. It only reached in, and found the unkindest true thing, and helped us say it.

* * *

"Stop walking," Third said.

He had turned around. The glow of his eye moved over the two of us — Roan with his spear half come up off his shoulder, me with my hands in fists I didn't remember making — and whatever he read there, he set himself down on the path between us and the green ahead, facing back the way we'd look, and he said:

"Listen to me, because the trees would prefer that you did not. They do not move. I have been watching them since we entered, every one within reach of my eye, without once looking away — I do not need to look away; it is among the few advantages of being made the way I was made. They have not moved. Not one of them, not the width of a hair. The thing in your minds telling you otherwise is the only danger in this place, and it is lying, and I am the proof of it. You do not have to watch the trees. I will watch the trees. That is mine. Yours is only to walk, and to know that what you have just said to each other was said by the forest, in your voices, because it has no voice of its own."

Nobody said anything for a moment.

"I'm sorry," Roan said, to the ground.

"Me too," I said, and meant it, and felt the meaning come back to me from a long way off, like something thawing.

"You will both be sorry several more times before we are clear," Third said, and stood, and something in the flatness of it was almost — not a joke. Third did not make jokes. But the shape where a joke would go, offered to us deliberately, like a hand. "It is the nature of the place. Apologise as often

as you need to. It is cheaper than the alternative, and I will not keep count."

So we walked, and Third walked ahead of us facing backward as often as forward, his eye on the trees, taking the watching off us and onto himself, and it helped. It genuinely helped, to be relieved of the trees, to have one fixed certain thing — *he is watching; if they move he will say* — to lean the mind against.

It was perhaps an hour after that, in the worst of the grey afternoon, that I heard Third say, low, not to me:

"No."

I looked up. He was facing forward, the eye on the path, and there was no one he could have been answering.

"No," he said again, quieter, the way you'd answer a thing that had asked the same question many times before and would ask it many more. And then a word I didn't catch, and then nothing, and his hand had closed and opened once at his side, the way Roan's kept closing on his spear.

"Third?" I said. "Who are you talking to?"

The eye came to me. For a moment — only a moment — the glow had a hardness in it I hadn't seen since the night the wounded traveller spoke of the thing that walked through the dead, a held thing, a door of his own with something leaning on it from the other side.

"Myself," he said. "It is an old conversation. The forest has merely turned up its volume." The glow eased. "Do not be concerned. I have been refusing this particular argument for a very long time. The trees have nothing to teach me about it that I have not already declined to learn."

He didn't explain, and I had no idea then what the argument was, or who the other voice in it belonged to, or that it had been speaking to him without rest since before

my grandmother's grandmother served her first stew. I only knew that whatever it was, the Snake Forest had found his door the same as it had found mine and Roan's — and that the difference between us was not that the place could not reach him.

It was that he had had three hundred thousand spins of practice keeping the door shut.

* * *

We came out of it the way we'd gone in, with no edge to mark the leaving, the bent trunks giving way tree by tree to honest crooked ordinary ones, until I looked up and the forest behind us was just a forest and the thing in my head had let go its grip so gently I couldn't say when.

We made camp early, well clear of the last of the bent trees, and none of us suggested going further though there was light left. Roan built the fire too big. I let him. We didn't talk about the things we'd said, but Roan took first watch without being asked, and when I woke in the dark he was sitting close to the coals with his spear across his knees, and he looked over at me, and in the firelight he looked like a child — younger than his spins, young enough that guarding anything seemed a cruel joke to have handed him.

"It wasn't true," he said. "What you said. I mean — it was. But it wasn't the why of it. I don't need someone to tell me I'm brave." He poked the fire. "I need to find out if I am. They turn out to be different things, when you're actually out here. I didn't know that before."

"It wasn't true what I said either," I told him. "You're the least cowardly person I've ever watched be frightened. That's a better thing than not being frightened. Mathen would have a line for it." I stopped. I didn't know who Mathen was. I had never heard the name. It had come up

out of me from nowhere, the way the bent trees came up out of the ground, and I put it down to the forest, to a day of having my mind turned over, and I let it go.

Across the fire, Third sat with his eye on the dark, watching nothing, watching everything, keeping a door shut that I would not understand for a long time yet.

In the morning the trail was clear and the trees were honest and we walked on toward the geysers, where everything would change again, though we didn't know that yet either.

* * *

Thirteen

There was a shard tree at the edge of our camp that first night past the Snake Forest, and the pull of it told me I still hadn't entirely learned my lesson. I knew them by now. We had come up through a whole forest of them on the causeway road, and that was where I'd learned what the prettiest thing on that road costs you — I still wore the thin white line across the back of my hand where one had taught me. But the forest had been a thousand of them, a roof of glass twenty men overhead, beauty and slaughter in one breath. This was a single tree, standing a little apart from the honest ones, slimmer, paler, its leaves long and narrow and the colour of dark honey; and when the night breeze moved them — gently, only gently — they made a sound I have never heard anything else make: a thin bright tinkling, like a shelf of glass cups touched all at once, delicate and lovely and entirely out of place in a wood at night. I got up and took a step toward it before the back of my hand reminded me, and I sat down again. One of the few beautiful things on that road that would also open your throat — and I had no intention of finding out whether the wind meant to stay soft. So I let it sing from where I was. I stayed by the banked fire, where Roan was a long breathing shape under his blanket, and I listened to the glass leaves sing, and across the camp Third sat his watch with his eye on the dark, and after a while I noticed that he had stopped watching the dark.

He was watching the tree.

I had begun, by then, to learn the difference between Third's stillnesses. There was the watchful one, which was most of them, the eye tracking, the body a held readiness. And there was the other one — the one I'd first really seen on the causeway, when he'd come back from the carts diminished — where the stillness went *down* into him somehow, where the glow of the eye softened and turned its attention to a place that wasn't the place the rest of us were in. He was doing the second one now. Watching the singing tree, the eye gone soft and far — and then, between one breath of mine and the next, he was not there. I want to be careful about this, because I was three-quarters asleep and the fire was low. But I do not think I dreamed it. One moment his still shape sat against the dark with the glass leaves singing over it; the next, the place by the fire was simply empty, in a way my eye slid off and would not hold; and then — no more than a breath later, before the leaves had finished their phrase — he was back, sitting exactly as he'd sat, as though he had never moved. In the only time that counted to us, he never had: whatever while he spent away, he spent where time runs faster than it has any business to, and stepped home into the gap of a single breath. I didn't understand it then. I thought I'd nodded and missed him shifting. I know now that he had stepped — gone bodily out of the world to where they were, because the glass leaves were singing and the glass leaves had sung that day too, and after three hundred thousand spins he would step a little way beside the world and be with them again, and that it cost him almost no time at all, and that this was the cruellest mercy he had ever been given.

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The child would not eat meat, and this was a problem, because Third had nothing else to offer and no

understanding of what else there might be.

He had carried it three spins by then, the small green thing in its stolen sling, and it had made its needs known in the only language it had, which was volume, and Third had learned to read the volume the way he had learned everything in those days — by trial, and by failure, and by the slow accretion of a competence no one had built him to have. Raw meat, refused. Water, accepted, with suspicion. A paste he made of river-tubers mashed between two flat stones, accepted, and then worn, much of it, and then — this was the part the unbidden voice found most contemptible and the part Third found, privately, the most interesting — produced again at the far end some hours later, without warning or apology, down the length of his arm.

It is consuming your time and your resources, the voice observed, as it observed most things, flatly, certainly, without malice and without end. *It would be more efficient to set it down.*

"I have heard you," Third told it, scraping his arm with a leaf. "You are very consistent."

The child watched him clean himself, and made a sound that was not quite a word and not quite a laugh, and Third went still, because it was the first sound it had made that was aimed *at* him rather than at the indifferent sky, and he did not yet have anywhere to put what that did.

Her name came out of his, in a manner of speaking — out of the only thing he had ever called her. He had no name for her and felt no need of one; she was the child, which was accurate, and accuracy was the whole of what he asked of words in those days. But on the long walks he had taken to talking to her, low, to keep the volume down, and the thing he said most, when he lifted her or settled her or warned her back from an edge, was *little one.* Little

one. It was not a name. It was only true.

And one day, reaching up at him from the sling with both green hands, pleased with herself, she gave it back to him in the shape her mouth could manage: "Li-wan."

"Little one," he said.

"*Li-wan,*" she insisted, as though correcting *him,* and would not be moved, and that was that. He had said a true thing to her a thousand times and she had handed it back to him broken into a name, and he found — turning the discovery over, the way he turned over every new thing the child made him feel — that he liked the broken version better than the true one. That accuracy had stopped, somewhere on those walks, being the only thing he wanted from a word.

* * *

Wally came out of the stories.

Third should have expected it, having memory of the Hin from before, having known in some flat archived way that a tale told often enough and meant hard enough will, on Anka, sometimes get up and walk. But knowing a thing as fact is not the same as turning from the fire one evening to find that the fact has acquired a face.

And a beard. It had started because Liwon would not sleep, and Third had no songs — songs were not in him — so he told her instead the only stories he had, which were the things he knew: the trees, the weather, the shapes of the dangerous world. He told them as stories because she would not take them as warnings. He gave the Shard trees a voice and the Squid trees a temper and the sleep-breathing shrubs a sly cowardice, and he told her the same ones over and over because she demanded the same ones over and over, and somewhere in the thirtieth-plus spin of this a small person was sitting at the edge of the

firelight listening too.

He was about Liwon's height, which is to say small, and he had the look of someone who had always been there, and he was already laughing at the part of the Squid-tree story that Liwon always laughed at, on cue, as though he had heard it as many times as she had, which — Third came to understand — in every way that mattered, he had.

"You tell it wrong," the small person said, comfortably, to a being made to end his kind. "The Squid tree wouldn't say *that.* It'd say it grumbling. Like this." And he said it grumbling, and Liwon shrieked with delight, and Third sat with the particular stillness of a construct revising its model of the world in real time.

"You are Hin," Third said.

"I'm Wally," said Wally, as if these were the same thing, which for him they were. He had arrived complete — no infancy, no arrival, simply a yesterday in which he had not been and a today in which he had, and a perfect untroubled certainty that this was the normal way for a person to begin. He remembered the stories as his own childhood because the stories were, precisely, his childhood. He had been made of them. He found Third's careful questions about *when* and *how* very funny, and answered them the way you'd answer a child asking where the wind keeps its things.

Third did not tell either of them what he privately concluded, which was that he had talked a person into being out of grief and golden firelight and the need to keep one child asleep, and that this was either the best thing he had ever done or a thing he had no right to have done, and that he could not tell which, and that the not-telling had begun to feel familiar.

* * *

She learned the trees the way other children learn rhymes.

"Da goad ones," Liwon recited, marching beside him on the stone road with Wally marching behind doing an exaggerated version of her march, "have leefs dat hurt in wind. Or when dey drop." A solemn pause. "Da ones wif green smoke can stop my breaving. An' da ones wif da eye at da bottom is *safe.*" Triumphant. "'Cept when hurt."

"Good," Third said. "Yes. And when are they hurt?"

"When sumfin *bites* dem," she said, with relish, biting the air.

"When something bites them. Yes."

It had taken him, with the voice helping, the better part of their first spins together to learn to read the dangers of the wood. It took her a handful of tellings, and Wally fewer than that, and Third walked the Titan road behind the two small persons he had — there was no other honest word for it, and he had stopped fighting the word — *made,* one carried out of a massacre and one talked out of the dark, and he listened to them get the rhymes right, and the voice in his head said *this is not the purpose,* and Third said, internally, where only the voice could hear, *no. It is better than the purpose,* and the voice, for once, had nothing to add.

* * *

The village took her in the end, as he had always known a village would have to.

He found it by following the road to where the road found people — a Virek place, walled the way they walled, the tree-trunk spikes that always looked to Third like a porcupine's failed idea — and he came to it because Liwon was growing, and growing needed things he was not built to give: others of her kind, hands that knew what her body would do next, a place that did not move every dawn. He

had not been able to give her stillness. In all the spins since his waking — and they were not so many, then; he was still new enough to be counting them — it was the one thing he had never once managed to be.

A woman came out to him. Zala. She was unarmed and unafraid in a way that the men on the wall, with their bows, very much were not, and she looked at the green child on the back of the thing that had been built to murder green children, and she did the arithmetic faster than her own people could, and what she landed on was not *monster.* What she landed on was a question she asked gently, already half-knowing: "You've been caring for her?"

"As best I was able," Third said. "My limits are becoming apparent as she ages. That is the only reason I have come."

She let them in. It took the men longer — an arrow came, badly aimed, and Liwon cried at the shouting, and Wally went and stood very deliberately between the child and the wall with his small bearded chin up, which did nothing and meant everything — but Zala's voice carried more than her rank, and in the end the gate held open and the three of them went through it, and that was where Liwon began, by slow degrees, to belong to someone other than him.

He watched it happen over the spins that followed. He had asked for it. He had walked her here precisely so that it would happen. And still there was a thing in him — he located it eventually in the place the bellows lived, low in the wooden cage of his chest — that registered each step of her moving toward them and away from him, the way you'd register a slow tide going out: not as a wound, exactly. As a temperature. As the world getting cooler by a degree you only noticed in sum.

She ran to the Virek children now, not to him. She learned their words faster than the ones he'd given her,

and then better than them, and then she dreamed in them, which he knew because Wally told him, Wally who did not sleep much either and who sat with Third on the long nights and reported the small treasons of growing up with no cruelty and no comfort, just the plain Hin-honesty of a person who could not imagine why a true thing would hurt.

"She still asks for the tree story," Wally offered once, into one of Third's silences. "The one you tell wrong."

"Does she."

"I tell it now. I tell it right." A pause. "She says mine isn't as good." Wally seemed to find this satisfactory in a way Third was slow to follow. "She means yours. She means she wants *yours.* She just doesn't know that's what she means yet."

Third sat with that a while, on the wall he was permitted to walk now, an honorary warden of a village of the people he'd been forged to end, watching the dark for the things that came out of it.

"It is as it should be," he said, at last. He had decided to believe it. He had given her a place to be still in, which was the one gift he had never been able to give her himself, and a people whose hands knew her, and a future that did not move every dawn. That it cost him the degree of warmth he had only just learned he could hold — that was a fair price, and he was, he told himself, content to have paid it.

He believed it almost entirely.

The almost is the part the grey keeps. The almost is what was waiting for him under the singing of the glass leaves, all those spins later, on a road with a Humin girl asleep beside a fire and a whole catastrophe still ahead of them both that he had not yet let himself walk back into.

He stayed in the warm part. Just this once, he let himself stay in the warm part, and watch her get the rhyme right,

and not go forward to the night the sky filled with red veins.

He was permitted that much. The grey is patient. It would still be there when he stepped back.

◆ ◆ ◆

I woke fully near the end of his watch and he was Third again — the ordinary watchful stillness back in him, the eye on the dark, the night unremarkable. But the glow had gone down to its lowest ember, the banked-fire dimness I had seen on the causeway, and when he turned his head to mark me waking, it took a moment to come back up, the way a person surfaces from a long way down.

"You went somewhere," I said. I didn't mean it as a question and it didn't come out as one.

The eye held on me.

"Yes," he said.

I waited to see if there was more, the way I'd learned to wait. The glass leaves sang. Roan turned over and muttered and slept on.

"Was it somewhere good?" I asked. I don't know why I asked it that way. It seemed, suddenly, the only thing worth knowing.

Third was quiet for a long moment, the ember of his eye steady on the singing tree.

"It was good," he said, "for a while. The good ones are. That is what makes them the ones worth walking back into." And then, before I could find the next question: "Sleep, Tasha. You have the dawn watch, and we walk hard tomorrow. We are close to the geysers now."

I slept. I did not know what geysers meant yet, or who we'd find there, or that the warm part of whatever Third had gone into had an end he hadn't shown me. I only knew

that he had gone somewhere good and come back lessened, and that the two facts sitting together bothered me more than either would have alone, and I carried that small wrongness down into sleep and did not solve it.

I wouldn't solve it for a long time.

* * *

Fourteen

You smell the geysers before you see them, and the smell is the first argument the place makes that you should not be there. Hot copper and wet stone and something underneath that's almost sweet, the way meat is almost sweet just before it turns — a red smell, if a smell can have a colour, and this one could.

Then you come over the rise and there they are: a field of chimneys. Not built ones — grown ones, tapering spires of pale mineral four and five humins high, hollow, rough-sided, the spit and image of the great termite towers you sometimes find in dry country, except that these wept. From the open tops of the living ones a fine continuous spray went up, on no schedule and from no pump anyone could name, and fell back red, and ran down the outsides, and dried as it went to something else entirely — a crust the colour of nothing I had a word for, a blue-white that was almost clear, glassy, catching the grey light and throwing it back cold. The red ran. The blue-white stayed.

And the red collected, at the foot of each living tower, in a pool.

That was where the people were — a dozen of them, kneeling not under the spray but at the pools' edges, well back from the falling rain, dipping wooden things into the still red surface and drawing them out darker. Anointing. Turning a carved stick into a blade that could open you. Nobody, I noticed, let the spray touch them. Mathen told me later why, in the flat way he delivered the facts a body

ought to have before it did something stupid: wet on a blade, the blood makes hexwood. Wet on a person, it makes a very brief and very dangerous lunatic. You take it from the pool, where it's gone still and you can choose how much of you it touches. You never, ever stand in the rain.

The pools fed things. That was the next thing I saw — that each red pool had a ring of growth around it, and the growth was wrong: too dark, too glossy, fat-leaved and faintly moving when there was no wind, fed fat on the blood of a dead god and grown into shapes that had clearly stopped asking permission of the ordinary rules. Around two of the pools the growth had closed over entirely, a thicket nobody was working, nodding to itself.

And the dead towers. The oldest had sealed at the top, capped in blue-white glass, gone silent among the spraying ones like grave-markers among the still-breathing — and at the foot of each dead one the pool had dried too, dried and gone black, a flat black sheet of the same glass veining away from the tower in cracks across the pale ground, reaching, I saw now, toward the black cracks of the next dead pool over, and the next, so that the whole field was stitched beneath its living red with a dried black web of all the red that had ever pooled here and stopped. I had seen those black cracks before. Everyone has. They run through the whole world. I had simply never stood at the place where one was still wet.

"This is where hexwood comes from," Roan said, quiet, the way you'd speak in a place that might be holy or might be a slaughterhouse and you hadn't decided which.

"It is one place," Third said. "There are many. They do not last." He looked across the field at the sealed silent towers, the dead ones, with something I would not have called grief on a face that could make the expression, but which sat where grief would sit. "Each one closes itself, in

time. The spray builds the tower, and the tower builds its own lid, and one spin the red stops coming and the place is only stone. Then I find the next." A pause. "This one is free. I have kept a great many free, over the spins. They keep ending the argument by dying."

He said *free* with a small weight on it, and I learned the rest of why over the next while, watching him.

* * *

There were two reasons Third had brought us a day off our line to a field that smelled of the inside of a wound, and he gave them both without my asking, which was his way when a thing mattered to him — he stated his reasons plainly, as if daring you to find them foolish.

The first was the blood itself. He needed it. I watched him do a thing I'd never seen him do and have never quite stopped seeing since: he stood at one of the weeping towers, away from the others, and held a wad of fresh-cut wood into the red pool until it darkened and drew up all it could, and then he opened a seam along his own forearm — the vine-cord that served him for muscle parting under his fingers like a purse — and for half a breath, before he packed the soaked wood into the worn place beneath, I saw inside him.

I am not going to be able to tell it properly. There were gears in there, and rods, turning, and the trouble was not that they were strange — I had expected strange. The trouble was that they did not *work*. Not work as in broken; work as in *make sense.* They turned against each other in ways that should have locked solid or flown apart, drove nothing I could follow into nothing I could find, and the longer my eye tried to trace one rod to the thing it turned the more something behind my eyes began to ache, a low sick wrongness, like a word you've said so many times it

stops being a word. I looked away. I had to. Whatever kept Third moving was not clockwork, however much it wore the shape of it. Clockwork you can follow. This you could only flinch from, and understand that it went on turning whether you flinched or not.

He packed the soaked wood into himself, into the worn place beneath, the way you'd pack a wound except he was packing the wound *with* the thing that had made the world bleed, and the seam drew closed over the part I couldn't look at, and I breathed again. He saw me watching.

"I am made of anointed wood," he said. "The same as their blades. I wear, as the blood drains and then the wood wears. So I mend, as wood is mended. The pool gives me that, and the pool is free." He pressed the forearm seam flat. "That is the easy mending."

Then he did the other thing, and the other thing was worse, because the other thing he could not finish.

He opened his chest. Not wide — a hand's-span seam down the centre of him, drawn back the way the arm had drawn back — and inside, past more of the turning that hurt to look at, were two small lights. Blue-white. The cold clear blue-white of the dried crust on the dead towers, the blue-white that stayed. They sat in him like a pair of held breaths, side by side, and one burned steady and one had gone dim, guttered down to a wick-end of itself, and Third looked at the dim one a moment the way you look at a thing you have no answer for.

"This, the pool cannot give me," he said. "The wet mends the body. The lights want the dried — and not the dried that crusts a tower, which is too young and too rough, but the made dried, the kind that comes only from places I cannot simply walk up to and dip a cup. So I check them, here, where it is quiet. I watch the dim one. I calculate how long it has." He drew the seam closed over the two lights,

and they were gone behind him, and I understood without being told that I had just been shown the most private thing about him and possibly the most dangerous. "Long enough, for now. But not long. A bottle this size burns sixty spins, eighty if I hold still, and then it is a dead coal and I am down to one, hunting the next before that one goes too. The big vessels last — a made jar the size of your two fists would last me lifetimes — but those the makers keep, or sell to things that can pay in coin or worse, and a thing like me takes what it can scrounge: small ones, a few at a time, never enough ahead. I have been hunting the next since before your people had a word for the colour. They are the part of me I did not make, and cannot make, and that is a difficult thing to carry, in a world where the only people who make the dried keep the making a secret and would like very much to charge me for it."

I didn't have anything to say to that. The thing that hardened the swords kept his body whole, for free, at any weeping pool. But the thing that kept him *alive* — the two cold lights — came from somewhere else, somewhere fenced and priced and held close, and he carried two of them and one was going dim, and he had decided not to be afraid about it, the way he decided most things, by stating them plainly and walking on.

The second reason I worked out for myself, from the way the working people glanced at him and then eased, and the way two hard-looking men with a hand-cart and a ledger came over the far rise, looked at the field, looked at the Forged standing among the towers in the middle of it, and turned their cart around.

"The men with the ledger," I said. "You knew them."

"Not them. Their employer." The eye tracked the cart until it was gone. "There is a guild that would like to put a fence around this field and a gate in the fence and a price

on the gate. They have done it to three fields I know of. They have not managed it here." A pause. "I find I am here a great deal, when I can be. I am difficult to fence. And a field that something like me visits without warning is a poor investment for an employer who wants to charge admission." The glow settled, level and dry.

It was more than standing there, though. I watched him do the rest of it before we left — go to the two choked pools, the ones ringed round with the fat dark growth that had closed over and stopped anyone working them, and take a Falka to the thicket. Not hacking. Methodical, the way he did everything, cutting the wrong-shaped stuff back to the dirt and dragging it clear and stacking it to dry for burning, until the red surface showed again and a person could kneel to it without putting a hand into something that moved. The growth had teeth of a kind — a vine came round at his arm twice and he simply held it till it gave up, untiring, the way he'd cleared the carts — and when he was done two dead pools were working pools again, free for whoever came next.

"They grow back fast on the blood," he said, when he caught me watching. "A fenced field, a man would clear them once and charge you to use what he cleared. An unfenced one, someone has to clear them for nothing, every time, or the field closes itself to the poor before it ever closes itself for good." He wiped the Falka on the grass. "It is a small thing. The world should have a few free things in it. I have decided this is one of them. It costs me a detour."

That was the most I'd ever heard Third say about wanting anything. He wanted there to be a place where the poor could harden a blade for nothing, and he kept it open by the simple act of being too strange and too old to bill. I was still turning that over when the shouting started.

* * *

It started as the ordinary shouting of a man who has done something stupid and is refusing, loudly, to admit it.

"I'm *not* touching it!" — this from a Humin a few towers over, on his feet, a freshly dark blade in one fist and the other fist trailing red drops he plainly hadn't noticed. He was arguing with Third, who had risen and taken a few unhurried steps back, his glaive coming up not as a threat but the way you raise an arm between a child and a fire.

"You have it on your hand," Third said. "It is running off your knuckles. In a moment it will be in you, through the small cuts every hand has, and then we will not be able to continue this conversation, because you will be trying to kill me. I would prefer we skipped that part."

"I've anointed a dozen blades, I know how to—"

He didn't finish. I watched it take him. It came up through him like a tide finding a low field — his face going from indignant to confused to something with no person left behind it, the jaw setting, the eyes flattening — and the man who'd been protesting his competence a breath before came at Third with the new blade and a sound I don't want to describe, all the fury a body can hold and none of the aim.

Roan started forward. Third said, "No," without looking, and Roan stopped, and we watched.

I have tried to describe what Third did and the words keep coming out wrong, because every word for it is a fighting word and what Third did was the opposite of fighting. The man swung to open him from shoulder to hip. Third wasn't there — not dodged, exactly; *declined*, the way water declines a fist. The blade slid the length of the glaive's shaft and found only air at the end of it, and Third had turned a quarter-turn so the man's own fury carried

him past, and then it happened again, and again, the man spending himself in great wild arcs and Third spending nothing, a quarter-turn here, the shaft tilted there, a thing that looked less like combat than like a very patient person walking a large dog that believed it was walking him.

And the whole time — I only understood this later, when I knew to look — the whole time, Third's free hand kept closing and opening at his side. Closing and opening. The way it had in the Snake Forest, when he'd said *no* to something none of us could hear. The voice was in him even here, I think, telling him the eight quick ways to end the man, and Third was answering it the only way he ever did, which was to keep choosing not to, one quarter-turn at a time, for as long as it took.

It took about a minute. The man folded onto the stained stone, the blade thumping down beside him, his chest heaving, the fury gone out of him as fast as it had come.

"You will be yourself again after thirty deep breaths or so," Third told him, not unkindly. "Most Humins are merely felled by it. You stayed upright and swinging for some time. That is unusual. You should not feel badly about failing to land a strike — I have been studying the art since before this field had a name."

Pale moths had come up off the pools while we watched — I noticed them only now, broad soft wings the colour of the dried crust, drifting in slow clouds above the red where the spray kept the air warm and wet. They were the loveliest thing in that whole red field, and I had learned, by then, to distrust that. "They drink the spray and carry it," Third said, to me, though his eye was on Mathen, folded and breathing on the stained stone. "A crushed wing, a swallowed moth, and a man takes a smaller helping of what you just had — enough to sour him for an hour, not enough to fell him." He let that sit. "It could have been worse,

swordsman. A moth might have found you somewhere I was not — a market, a road, among people who cannot decline a blade the way I can. You would not have failed to land your strikes there. You'd have succeeded, on a local, or two, before it passed — and woken thirty breaths later a different kind of man than the one who lay down." Mathen didn't answer. He looked at the moths a long while. So did I.

* * *

He came back to himself the way you surface from a bad dream, all at once and ashamed. He got an elbow under himself and looked at the blade, and at Third, and at the two of us, and I watched him decide what kind of man he was going to be about it, which is a thing you can actually watch some people do.

"I'd apologise," he said, "but I think a thank-you's the more honest coin. You could've split me like kindling and I'd have had it coming." He worked his jaw. "I thought I'd taken every safe step. Turns out I'd taken every safe step but one, and it's always the one."

"No apology is needed," Third said. "And you are welcome."

"Mathen." He got himself the rest of the way up, waving off the hand Third didn't quite offer. "Known far and wide as Mathen, swordsman extraordin—" He stopped. He looked at the blade on the ground, and at the Forged who'd just made his finest fury look like weather. "Known far and wide as Mathen," he amended. "The extraordinary part could use some paring, I'll grant you, having just paraded it about for the whole field."

"You were measuring yourself against an experienced opponent," Third said. "Against most others the moniker might hold."

It was, I realised, a kindness — Third doling out the exact amount of dignity the situation could bear and not a grain more, because more would have been a lie and Third did not lie. Mathen heard it for what it was. Something eased in his face. And I felt the thing happen that I didn't have a name for yet: the air of our small grim company changed, the way a room changes when someone opens a window you didn't know was painted shut.

He asked to see the glaive. Third let him, on the condition he could see Mathen's blade in turn, and the two of them stood in the bloody field passing weapons back and forth like boys trading knucklebones. Mathen's was a good blade, an heirloom — his father's chip-carving under his own, he said, three generations of marks before he'd judged it worthy of the red. He was proud of it and trying not to be, which made me like him.

Then he turned Third's glaive in his hands, and went still, the way people went still around Third when the wrongness of him landed.

"This is old work," Mathen said slowly. "This flourish, here — nobody carves like this. This is from—" He looked up. "Who made this?"

"The one who made me," Third said.

"And who repaired it? Since. It'd have to have been repaired, wood doesn't—"

"It has never been repaired. It is the glaive I was created holding. I have carried it since my waking."

Mathen laughed, the easy laugh of a man waiting for the rest of a joke. Then he didn't. He looked at the glaive, and at Third's forearm where I'd watched the seam close, and at the single off-centre eye of him, the body visibly mended a hundred times over and the weapon in it untouched, original, older than mended.

"Your waking," Mathen said carefully. "When was your waking."

"When the last of the Titan fell," Third said. "I was on the field. I felt the dust come down. I have been awake since."

I knew it already — or I'd been told it, which I was learning is not the same as knowing. But I watched Mathen do the sum the way I should have done it long before, watched him reach for a number and find that the numbers ran out before the answer did, watched a swordsman who'd been proud of three generations of marks on a blade stand in front of a thing that remembered the day the sky was torn. He didn't go pale. He went *quiet*, which on Mathen, I'd come to learn, was the louder reaction.

"Right," he said, at last, very softly. "Right. So when you said I shouldn't feel badly about not landing a strike." A breath of something that wanted to be a laugh and wasn't quite. "You were being generous."

"I was being accurate," Third said. "The generosity was a separate thing, offered alongside."

* * *

He didn't ask to come with us. That's the part I keep, looking back — nobody recruited anybody.

He helped us refill our water, because he knew the clean seeps at the field's edge from the tainted run-off and we didn't. He told us, unprompted, the trick of telling anointed water from clean. He walked us to the far edge of the field naming the people who came regular, which ones would trade fair and which would short you, and somewhere in the naming it stopped being directions for travellers passing through and started being the talk of someone who'd decided, without announcing it, to keep walking the same direction we were walking.

It was Third who said it, finally, in the flat way he said the things that mattered.

"We are going anti-spinward, to stop a man who is gathering the tools of the Titans, with which he intends to call one back. It is dangerous, and most who hear it do not believe the danger, and of those who believe it, most very sensibly decline to come. You should know what you would be following, before you follow it any further."

Mathen was quiet a moment. The geysers breathed their red breath behind us.

"A man trying to wake a Titan," he said. "And a Forged who's been awake since the last one fell, walking out to stop him." He shouldered his pack. "Ser, I have been looking my whole life for a story worth telling, and you've just told me there's one walking up the road, and you expected me to let it walk off without me?" He fell in beside Roan as if the matter were long settled. "I'd never forgive myself. And I'm a *terrible* audience for my own regrets, you'll find."

And that was how Mathen came among us — not because Third sought a companion, and not because anything was written, but because some people, shown the edge of a thing too big to refuse, simply step over it and ask what's for supper.

I caught Third watching him go ahead with Roan, the two of them already arguing amiably about something. The glow of his eye was steady, ordinary, unreadable. But he stood a moment before he followed, and I'd learned to notice when Third stood a moment.

"What," I said.

"Nothing," he said. "I am only counting. It is a habit." He started walking. "I find I have acquired three of you. I had not expected to acquire any."

He didn't say it like a complaint. He didn't quite say it like a gift, either. But it was the nearest to the second that I'd heard from him, and I walked the rest of that day with it warming a spot under my ribs that the Snake Forest had left cold.

* * *

Fifteen

A party of three has a shape, and the shape is a line. We'd walked it for a tenday without my ever thinking about it: Third in front because Third was always in front, me behind him because his back was the safest place in the world to put your eyes, and Roan behind me with his spear and his checking. A line. You don't talk much in a line. You talk to the back of a head, or you don't, and mostly we hadn't.

Four made a different shape, and Mathen made it on purpose.

He'd worked out by the second morning that the line was a thing to be dismantled, and he went about it the way I'd later learn he went about everything — sideways, cheerfully, and without once announcing what he was doing. He'd fall back and walk with Roan a while and get him talking about the militia, about the town, about the girl Roan never quite named; then he'd drift up and walk with me and ask the kind of question that has no defensible reason not to answer, so that I'd answer it before I'd decided to; then he'd lengthen his stride and pull even with Third, which nobody had done, and just *walk there*, companionable, as if walking beside the oldest thing in the world were a thing a person did.

By the fourth day the line was gone. We walked in a loose knot that rearranged itself like weather, and there was talk in it, the ordinary unimportant talk that I hadn't known a group could make until I heard ours start making it, and I understood that this was a thing Mathen *did* —

that he was, in some way I didn't have a trade-word for, a mender too. Tondi fixed seams. Mathen fixed the spaces between people. He'd just walked into the middle of three strangers and begun quietly stitching them into a company.

* * *

He cooked, too, and he cooked *well*, which after a tenday of my road-fat-and-resentment was its own small revolution. The first night he took over the fire was the night we camped under the wall.

I call it a wall. It was a wall the way the causeway was a bridge — a thing that wore the word loosely and was really something else. It rose out of the grassland a half-day spinward of us, sheer and seamless and grey, as high as a hill and longer than sight, and it went *nowhere.* It did not ring a thing, or hold back a thing, or join a thing. It started out of flat ground at one end and stopped at flat ground at the other and in between it was simply a wall, a colossal straight nothing the Titan had begun and never finished, or finished and never explained, and the wind came round its end with a low constant note like someone blowing across a jug the size of the world. We camped in the lee of it because the lee was out of the wind. That was the only use it had ever been to anyone, and it had not been built for it, and a hundred generations of travellers had warmed themselves against the side of a thing whose entire purpose had died with the child that wanted it.

And there, in the windbreak of an abandoned god-sized whim, the first night he took over the fire, Mathen produced from the same dried fish and tubers I'd been ruining something a person would willingly eat twice, and he did it while talking the entire time, and he served Third a portion.

"I don't eat," Third said. It was not a complaint. Third stated facts about himself the way he stated facts about the weather.

"I know," Mathen said, setting the bowl down by Third's hoof anyway. "But a man cooks for his company, and you're my company, and if I leave you out it'll show on the count. Let it go cold. Let the smell do the work. My gran used to set a bowl for her brother forty spins after he passed, and nobody ever told her it was strange, because it wasn't." He sat. "You can give it to the guard when I'm not looking. He's a dozen kinds of hungry."

"I'm seven thousand spins old," Roan said, around a mouthful, with the dignity of a grown man who has been a guardsman for some spins and would like that noticed.

"You're a growing boy," said Mathen serenely, "and you've a growing boy's appetite, and I respect it," and Roan, who'd spent four spins trying to be taken seriously by an actual swordsman, found himself grinning at being called a boy, which is a difficult trick to do to a grown man and Mathen did it without seeming to try.

* * *

The trouble started, as it would keep starting, with a story.

Mathen told them most nights — he couldn't not, it was the same compulsion in him that made Third correct a wrong fact, the exact inverse engine — and the third or fourth night he told the one about the breaking of the sky. The Titans' war. He told it well. He told it with the storm-Titan and the magic-Titan and the glutton each given a voice, with the Virek — may they never be forgotten — host shining and doomed and noble, with a last stand on a field of glass and a hero with a carved bow who put the final arrow through the final Titan's heart while the world held its breath.

It was a good story. Roan was rapt. I was halfway rapt myself, and I'd stopped believing in heroes around the time I started closing up the inn alone.

Across the fire, Third had gone very still. Not the stillness that went down into him. The other kind — a held, mounting stillness, the stillness of a kettle deciding.

"That is not how it was," Third said.

"Course it isn't," Mathen said comfortably, not stopping. "It's how it's *told*."

"The storm and the magic and the glutton were not three. There was—" Third stopped himself, and I watched him put something back behind a door, something too large for the firelight, and choose a smaller true thing to say instead. "There were not separate Titans warring as rivals. That is a tidiness the telling adds. And the Virek were not shining. They were frightened, and they were clever, and they were dying, and there was nothing noble in any of it, there was only people who did not want to be playthings doing a terrible thing to stop being played with. I was on that field. There was no breath held. There was screaming, and then there was a great deal of dust, and the screaming went on under the dust for some time."

The fire popped. Roan had stopped chewing.

"And the hero with the bow," Third said, quieter. "There was a boy with a bow. He was not a hero. He was terrified and he was perhaps fourteen spins past being a child, and the bow was beautiful, and after it was over he sat up in the grass and said 'oh, I thought I was dead,' and then he saw me and pointed it at me, because that is what you do, when you are a frightened boy and a monster is standing over you." The eye dimmed. "I would prefer he were remembered as he was. I find I am the only one left who could correct the record, and I have just done it, and it has

changed nothing, because his is not the version that gets told."

There was a silence after that with a great deal in it.

I'd have let it sit. I am good at letting things sit. But Mathen set down his bowl, and leaned forward, and his face had lost the performing ease and found something underneath it I hadn't seen yet — the real man, who took stories more seriously than anyone I'd ever met precisely because he knew exactly what they were for.

"Then tell it," Mathen said. "The true one. Not to argue mine down — mine's for strangers in a pub who want a Titan and a hero and a clean ending, and they're owed that, it's a fair trade for their coin. But the true one's owed to *somebody.* That boy's owed it. You're the last who carries him, and when you go down — three hundred thousand spins or no, everything goes down eventually — he goes with you, unless somebody else is carrying him too." He sat back. "That's all a story is, ser. It's a way of making more than one person carry the thing. So that it doesn't all rest on you."

Third looked at him across the fire for a long moment.

"You are arguing that I should make inaccurate things," he said slowly, "in order to preserve a true one."

"I'm arguing," said Mathen, "that *accurate* and *carried* aren't the same, and that you've spent a long time keeping things accurate by keeping them to yourself, and that it hasn't kept them safe, it's just kept them *yours.*" He shrugged, the ease coming back over him like a cloak he'd taken off for exactly one sentence. "Anyway. You don't have to tonight. I just think you've got the oldest true story walking around in you that anybody's ever met, and it'd be a crime against my whole profession to let it walk off uncopied." He grinned. "Think of me as greedy. It's more

comfortable for everyone."

Third didn't answer. But he didn't close the door all the way either — I could tell, by then, the difference between Third deciding *no* and Third deciding *not yet.* This was the second one.

* * *

Later, when Roan was asleep and Third had stepped off to walk the dark the way he did, Mathen and I sat with the coals.

"You do it to everyone," I said. "Get them talking. I noticed on the road."

"I do." He didn't pretend otherwise. That was a thing about Mathen — he'd lie all night in a story and not at all out of one. "It's a habit. Habits come from somewhere." He turned a stick in the fire. "I had a family of the talking kind. Loud table, everybody at once. I got good at making space in it for the quiet ones, because there was one of us who was quiet, and somebody had to." A beat, the smallest catch in the easy voice, a door I heard close before I'd properly seen it open. "Anyway. Old habit. Cheaper than the alternative."

I noticed he'd used Third's phrase. *Cheaper than the alternative.* I wondered if he'd caught it from Third or if Third had caught it from someone like Mathen, a long time ago, and it had been rattling around in him for three hundred thousand spins waiting to come back out.

"And me?" I said. "What are you making space for, with me?"

He looked at me then, the storyteller's look, the one that reads you. I felt the question I hadn't asked get asked anyway, the *what are you running from* of it, sitting there in the firelight as plain as if he'd said it.

And then, kindly, he let it go.

"Nothing," he said. "You don't need the space made. You make your own, and you keep it swept, and you don't let anybody track mud in. I respect it. I'll just sit near it, if that's all right, and you can use it or not." He poked the fire. "That's the other half of the trade. Knowing which ones want the door opened and which ones are holding it shut for a reason."

I didn't say anything. But I didn't get up either, and we sat near my swept and guarded space together, and it was — I'll use the word, because there was so little of it coming and I want it on the record — it was companionable. It was a good night. I had them more often, that stretch of the road, than I'd had in a long while, and I didn't know to be afraid of how good they were.

* * *

Across the dark, at the edge of where the firelight failed, Third stood his watch.

He'd taken to standing a little apart from us, those nights — not far, never far, but apart, the way you stand back from a fire that's burning well, because you've learned what fires do and you've no wish to be in one again when it goes out. I didn't understand it then. I thought it was only his nature, the old solitude reasserting itself between jobs.

I know now he was doing arithmetic. He'd said as much, at the geysers — *I am only counting; it is a habit.* He had acquired three of us, and he had not expected to acquire any, and somewhere in the part of him the gears turned and didn't make sense, he was already counting the cost of each of us, the way a man who has been burned counts the exits before he sits down. Not because he didn't want us. Because he did, and he knew exactly what wanting cost, and he had paid it before, in a currency I hadn't yet learned

he'd ever held.

He watched Mathen make us a company.

And he let him.

That was the thing, looking back — that was the bravest thing I watched Third do on that whole road, and I didn't even see it for what it was at the time. He let Mathen stitch us together, knowing what stitching costs when it tears. He stood a little apart, and counted, and let it happen anyway.

* * *

Sixteen

The talk had a way of stopping when the country insisted, and the country insisted that afternoon — off to the spinward side of our line, down in a grassy hollow we'd not have to cross, close enough to read and no closer. The smell reached us first; I was learning to read it before I saw its cause. The grass down there was churned dark and strewn with the dead: a whole pack of Herdukii, eight or ten of the wolf-things, torn apart and flung wide — and among them, harder to look at, two or three who had not been wolves. A Humin. A Kr. What was left of them was mixed through what was left of the pack, as though the same hand had pulled all of them to pieces and not troubled to sort the kinds. A cookpot lay canted in the mud a little apart from the rest, coals long gone cold and scattered, as though whatever had come through here had wanted that most of all. There was metal down there too: a good blade snapped clean, a shirt of mail opened like a husk and pitted where something had gripped it, untouched otherwise. Nothing had eaten any of it. That was the part that turned my stomach worst — a pack of Ravagers and the folk who'd died fighting them, all of it killed and none of it carried off, just opened and dropped and left for the flies.

I had stood at the edge of a place like this once, after. I never went out into it; I only saw it from the inn door, before Tondi pulled me back. My body remembered the shape of it anyway — a place where something had come through and unmade everyone in it. The warm easy knot

we'd walked in all morning came apart, and nobody had to say why. Roan had gone the colour of tallow. Even Mathen was quiet. It was Roan who finally spoke, in a voice working hard to stay level. "Could you have come out of that?" He didn't say the rest of it aloud — whether the cold man, who declined every fight there was, would have walked clear where those people hadn't — but it was under the question, and the three of us waited on the answer.

Third looked the hollow over like a notice nailed to a post. "A flailing dreadnought made this," he said, the way you'd name a weather. "They are drawn to cooked food — smoke, rendered fat, the smell of a working kitchen carried on the wind. No one is certain why; the likeliest guess is that the Titan built them to find armies, and an army in the field always smells the same, however you dress it. The pack will have caught the travellers first, or found them already fighting the wolves; the dreadnought will have smelled someone's supper a day or two back and only now arrived, walked into the middle of the disagreement, and ended it on everyone at once." The eye came to rest on Roan. "I do not eat. I have cooked for others. I have never lit one for my own benefit in my life. It would have had small reason to mark me, even standing in the middle of it." A pause, while that settled into the unsettling thing it was. "These will have cooked, somewhere back along this stretch — dried meat softened over coals, a pot, something ordinary. That is what called it down, a day late and indifferent to whose fire it had followed. We will put more ground between us and this place before we light anything, and keep what we do light small and short-lived after that." He turned us back toward our line. "It is gone, in any case. It does not linger once it has fed, or once a trail runs cold." Which was meant as a comfort, and was, a little, and was also the worst thing he could have said: that a thing could

do all this and walk on — not from cruelty, but from having finished an errand.

We walked well past where we'd normally have stopped, further than any of us said out loud we wanted to, before Third finally let us make camp — a glade well off the trail, the fire kept low and banked, more coals than flame, far enough from the road and far enough from the hollow behind us that neither smoke nor light would carry to either. Mathen had cooked something involving the dried mushrooms he'd been hoarding since the last town and refused to explain, and it had been better than it had any right to be, and now he was on his back with his hat over his face making the sounds of a man pretending to be asleep while actually listening to everything. Roan had drawn first watch and was sitting at the edge of the firelight with his back to us, doing it properly.

I'd asked Third a question I'd been carrying since the inn. I wasn't sure what made this the right moment — something about a full stomach and a fire and the particular quality of quiet that settles over a camp when the immediate work is done and the next immediate work hasn't started yet. It felt like a moment when a person might answer something honestly rather than usefully.

Third was not a person. But I was beginning to think the distinction mattered less than I'd assumed.

"How did it start?" I'd asked. "Knowing you were — you."

He was quiet for long enough that I thought he wasn't going to answer. Then he began.

* * *

The dust fell like frost — except that it was red. A fine red ash, the colour of the inside of a living thing, drifting down over the whole field in the heat of a cloudless day; and

where it settled on me it was cold, the cold of a morning I had never had to wake to. One moment I was moving through the field with purpose. Then all of that was still there — the noise, the movement, the weight of my glaive — and also, now, something else. Something looking at it.

The field was still loud. This was important.

The Virek were not cheering at a safe distance. They were advancing — through the settling dust, across the churned ground, past my brothers who had not moved when the dust touched them. My brothers were still standing in attack stance, waiting for an order that was not going to come. The Virek understood this before I did. The spellfire was already arcing — those impossible multicoloured balls launched from their sorcerers' line, falling in long curves toward the stunned Forged, and where they landed there was an inverted absence of sound and then nothing where my brothers had been.

One landed close. Close enough that I felt the edge of it.

So I ran.

Not toward anything. I had been aware of myself for perhaps ten seconds and I had already learned that I did not want to cease, which was itself a discovery. I ran the way fire spreads — along whatever path offered the least resistance — and an arrow found my arm somewhere in the running and I noted it and kept moving and the Virek line was between me and the forest and then it wasn't, because I did something I did not have a name for yet.

I was somewhere else.

* * *

Third paused here, and I watched him across the fire. His eye had not moved from the middle distance — not looking at anything in the camp, looking at the memory of a sky that no longer existed.

* * *

The somewhere else was grey. No ground that felt like ground. No sky with any intention of being a sky. The world I had just left was visible as hazy shapes through the grey — the Virek as dimly glowing outlines, the spellfire moving through the mist like slow light through water.

Behind me, enormous, a shadow with weight.

I turned.

The Titan filled the space that space occupied. I will not try to explain the scale of it. An ornately carved spear protruded from its side. The spear was larger than most buildings I would later see, and the wound it made looked like the kind of wrong that does not heal.

I had not known the Titans could be wounded.

"You may have been forged by another," it said, "but my essence has awoken you. Go. Tell the rest how to find me. I will no longer enter your world."

The voice was not a sound. It arrived the way weather arrives — not from a direction, simply present. It said another, as though there had been more than one of it. I believed that then, the way everyone believes it. I have had a long time since to stop being sure. I looked at the wound. I looked at the spear. I did not look at either for long, because looking at them felt like standing at the edge of what had been happening to my brothers, and I had just decided I did not want that.

I ran again, and the grey did not take kindly to running. That was the only name I had for it then, and the truest one I have found since; the formal word — Akna, Anka inverted, solid set against not — I would not learn for a long time. The mist of it moved with me and against me at once. The shapes of the world showed through it like images in cloudy water, and as I ran the whole grey plane began to

shake, subtly at first and then less subtly, the droning at the bottom of its silence becoming something with texture and mass, everything smearing into streaks —

I stumbled.

And I was back. Trees. Actual trees. Behind me, much further than I had expected, the plain where the battle had been. Ahead of me, through the forest, the sound of water.

* * *

Here Third stopped again, and when he continued his voice had shifted — not softer, exactly, but slower. Roan, at the edge of the firelight, had gone very still. Under his hat, Mathen was no longer making the sounds of pretend sleep.

* * *

I walked to the water. A brook. Small and clear and entirely indifferent to what had just ended. I crouched at the edge and put my hand in and held it there, and the cold of it moved against my palm, and I stayed until the battlefield sounds were entirely replaced by the sounds of a world that had not noticed, and was continuing regardless.

Then the boy stood up out of the reeds with his bow drawn.

He'd been resting, or hiding — both, probably. He was young. Perhaps 4,500 spins in the reckoning I would later learn. His arms were shaking, but he had asked a question rather than releasing the arrow, and I found that more interesting than the arrow would have been.

"What are you doing?" he said.

"I do not know," I said. It was the first true thing I had ever said. Before that I had only said things that were accurate, which is different. "What am I?"

He stared. "Blank. You're what we call a Blank."

I looked at my glaive. Then at his bow. The bow was exquisitely made — someone had spent a long time on it, cared about every part of it — and looking at it I understood something about what awareness had brought me that purpose had not. The ability to notice that a thing had been made with care. To find that significant rather than tactical.

I opened my hands. The glaive fell forward and stood briefly blade-first in the grass before settling.

"I am created to destroy your kind," I said. It seemed important to be accurate. "What are you created for?"

He stepped back. "We were created as playthings for the Titans. But we will overthrow them and make our own place."

I looked at the glaive in the grass. I looked at his bow.

"Then I make my own place too," I said. "The Titan I served is already overthrown."

I turned and walked downstream. Behind me I heard the tension leave his bow — the sound of a decision not made. I did not look back.

I had not gone far when I heard him say, quietly, as though to himself:

"A Blank just used I?"

* * *

Third's eye moved back to the fire. Whatever the middle distance had held, it was done holding it.

I realised I'd been holding my breath somewhere in the middle of all that, and quietly let it out. Across the camp, Mathen had pushed his hat up off his face and was looking at the sky with the expression of a man revising several assumptions about the world. Roan had turned around at some point. He was looking at Third with the expression of

a man who has been brave all his life without ever having understood what bravery was measured against.

Third picked up a stick and adjusted the fire. The coals shifted. Sparks rose and went out.

"That," he said, "is how it started."

Nobody said anything for a while.

It was Mathen who spoke first, which was right, because Mathen always spoke first when silence needed breaking and somehow always found the right thing. He put his hat back over his face.

"Hell of a first day," he said.

Third made a sound that was not quite a laugh, from somewhere inside the bellows of his chest. It was the first time I had heard him make that sound.

"Yes," he said. "It was."

* * *

Seventeen

We had come through the bog that morning, and the bog had nearly kept Roan, so the smell, when it found us in the afternoon, landed on people already shaken.

It had looked, the bog, like the kindest thing the country had shown us in days — we came out of scrub onto a wide flat meadow of soft green reeds, knee-high, level as a swept floor, with berry-bushes scattered across it and the warmth of the Spire coming down mild, and every part of me that was tired wanted to walk straight out into it and lie down. Third put his glaive across my chest before I'd taken three steps. "It is water," he said. "All of it. The reeds grow on the surface. They will hold a bird. They will not hold you." And then, because Roan was already six steps out past where Third's arm could reach, having seen the berries and not the warning — the green floor opened under him without a sound, no splash, just a swallowing, the reeds closing over the place he'd been like a mouth, and Mathen and I had him by an arm and a fistful of cloak before his head went under, and we hauled, and the bog hauled back, and for a long ugly moment the country was very calmly trying to drink a man in front of us while looking like a place you'd picnic. We got him out black to the waist and shaking. We went round the long way after that, along the firm edge, and the meadow lay there behind us soft and green and patient, beautiful as anything, waiting for the next tired thing that trusted its eyes.

So when the smell hit — in the afternoon, which meant the wind was coming from anti-spinward, which meant we

were downwind of whatever was left of the town, which meant we'd been smelling it for the last hour without knowing what it was — I'd thought, hoped, it was just the bog again, turned rank in the heat behind us.

It wasn't the bog.

"Titans," Mathen said, pulling his collar up over his nose. "And here I'd just decided I was hungry."

"You are always hungry," Third said, not breaking stride. "We are downwind. You smell the dead."

"I'd worked that out, thank you." But the joke had gone out of his voice by the end of it. Mathen could keep a mood afloat across most things — I'd watched him do it for three days of rain and a washed-out ford and Roan's snoring — but there's a particular silence that comes off a place where a lot of people died at once, and even Mathen went quiet under it.

Roan didn't say anything at all. He'd gone the colour of old porridge and was looking at the gate ahead of us with the fixed attention of a man who has realised that the stories and the thing the stories are about are not the same size.

"If anyone lived," Third said, "they've moved on. The only thing moving in there now is scavengers." He tilted his head — not toward the town, but at the angle I'd learned meant he was running several thoughts at once. "This was within the last spin. Two at most."

As if to make his point, an Axe Beak strode out from between the spikes with something in its mouth that I chose not to identify — a squat armour-plated thing about a humin and a half of bulk, most of it beak and teeth, the little wing-stumps twitching at its sides as it moved. It wove between the sharpened logs like they were saplings, unhurried, fed and unbothered, and vanished around the

side of the nearest building without sparing us a glance.

"Those spikes were never going to stop anything, were they," I said.

"They would stop a massed charge," Third said. "Which this town would never face — nothing has charged a wall in ordered ranks since the Titans fell. What does come for a place like this walks between them, as that one did, or simply goes around." "Optimistic," Mathen agreed, in the tone of a man filing the word away for a song he had no intention of writing.

We went in through the gap where the gate had been — the gate itself reduced to kindling, scattered too small to be useful. The ground inside was wrong in the way ground gets when too many things happen on it in too little time. I kept my eyes moving and my hand near my blade and tried not to look too long at the things that weren't moving.

The Herdukii came from behind the first building's corner without warning.

Wolf-headed, bear-clawed, a dead man's cloak knotted round its middle and a string of fingers at its throat. It had been feeding, and it came up out of its crouch and launched itself at Third with the confidence of something that had not yet learned what Third was.

Several things happened in the space of about a heartbeat.

Roan made a sound I'd never heard him make and went backward off his own feet, scrambling, his spear coming up far too late to matter — the honest reflex of a man whose body had decided to be somewhere else before his training could vote on it. Mathen's swords were out before I'd finished flinching, both of them, low and wide and already moving to flank the thing, fast enough that I understood for the first time that the campfire jokes had been hiding

something. And I was reaching for my own blade with the awful certainty that I was going to be too slow to be useful.

None of us needed to be anything.

Third's Falka cleared its sheath and returned to it in what felt like one motion. The Herdukii landed in two pieces that had been one piece, twitched, and stopped. Third had not broken stride.

There was a silence.

Mathen looked at his two drawn swords. He looked at the Herdukii. He looked at his swords again, and then sheathed them, both, with the unhurried dignity of a man pretending the whole manoeuvre had been a stretch.

"Well," he said. "Glad I could help."

"You were prepared to," Third said, which from Third was close to a compliment, and which Mathen accepted with a small bow he managed to make only slightly mocking.

Roan was getting up off the ground, scarlet now where he'd been pale, brushing at himself with the furious focus of someone who would rather be doing literally anything than meeting another person's eyes.

"It came out of nowhere," he said.

"It came from behind a building," Mathen said, kindly. "Which, from where you were standing, is much the same thing. You got your spear up. First time I saw one of those I got my spear into my own foot." He clapped Roan on the shoulder on the way past. "You'll meet the next one standing. That's the whole trick — there's always a next one, and you're always a little readier."

I didn't think Mathen had ever put a spear through his own foot in his life. But I watched the colour come back to Roan's face at a survivable rate instead of all at once, and I understood that this was the thing Mathen actually did, the

thing that was worth more than the swords: he made the unbearable into something a person could stand inside.

"They were not scavengers here," Third said. He was looking down at the body with no disgust, the way you'd look at a knot you'd just untied. "They were directed. Held in numbers, set on the town all at once, the way the traveller described. Ravagers do not wait. Something made this one wait."

"Something worse than a Ravager," Roan said. His voice only shook a little.

"Yes."

We split up to search — Mathen and Roan taking the outbuildings along the wall, Third and I taking the large structure near the centre that Third had been looking at since we came through the gate. I think he sent the others wide on purpose. I think he already knew what we were going to find, and didn't want an audience for it.

The memorial pillar stood near the middle of the settlement, knee-high, three-sided, perhaps a dozen names across it. The founding plaque at its base had been there long enough to wear smooth at the edges but not long enough to rise very far out of the ground.

I stopped at it for a moment. A generation. Maybe less. Some of these names had likely been children when the town was founded; they'd grown up and built something, and the something was gone in a spin or two along with everyone who'd made it. I thought about a knee-high pillar in a town a great deal like this one, with a great deal fewer names on it, and Tondi in her corner, and Klar's stew, and I made myself stop thinking about it.

Third pointed at the central building. His arm extended with the directness of someone who had been pointing at things for three hundred thousand spins and had long since

stopped making it a social gesture.

"There. That is what they came for."

The wall had been breached from the inside out — not smashed, breached, the debris fallen outward in a way that said whatever did it had known exactly where it was going and gone there without hesitation. No matching hole in the far wall. Whatever came out had left through the opening it made.

"You think a caged Tusker did that?" I said.

Third paused, considering it with apparent sincerity. "Was that a joke?"

"Was it a good enough one that you can't tell?"

A shorter pause. Something in the set of his shoulders I'd learned to read as the Forged equivalent of dry amusement; the glow of his eye dimmed a fraction, the way it did when he was, in his own fashion, almost enjoying himself. "It was not. After you."

Inside had been an official's residence — six or seven strides to a raised platform with a seat on it, ramps up each side to the rooms above. The sort of room built to make a visitor feel the right size. It was still managing it, even without the official.

The lockbox sat in the centre of the floor. It had been below the centre of the floor, in the proper fashion, and was now above it, and the floor around it was in several places it should not have been. The hexwood box was big enough to hold a reclining child. Its gear-lock hadn't been picked or broken by someone who understood it — it had been torn apart by something that had decided the mechanism was beneath its notice. The lid was peeled back the way you'd husk a grain, if you were enormous and the husk were reinforced hexwood.

I looked at it. Then I looked at Third.

He bent, lifted the lid, and held it out to me flat in both hands, like an offering.

"I did not do this," he said.

I hadn't asked. That was the thing I noticed, and didn't understand, and filed away with the other small wrong-shaped pieces of Third: that he had answered a question no one had put to him, in the flat careful voice he used for the things that were true and cost him to say. As if somewhere, once, there had been a wrecked place he had not been able to say it about, and he had been saying it ever since to make up the difference.

I took it. Heavier than it looked, and it looked heavy. The hinges still hung off it, wrenched bodily out of the box. The wood hadn't split or cracked where it bent back. It had simply been made to go where something had decided it should go.

"You told us what was being collected," I said. "Back at the inn. Tools. I don't think I believed you. Not in the stomach. I believed you the way you believe a story." I set the lid down, carefully, for no reason. "I believe you in the stomach now."

"Good," Third said, and did not say it unkindly. "Belief in the stomach is the only kind that keeps a person alive out here." He looked at the ruined box. "But this tells me something I did not know before, which is worth the smell. Whatever did this came for one thing. It did not search. It did not ransack the town for valuables. It went to this room, opened this box, took what was inside, and left through the wall. It knew the object was here before it arrived."

"The traveller said it went building to building."

"In his town. Not here. Here it walked a straight line." The glow sharpened. "Which means between his town and

this one, it learned to find the thing without looking. Or it always could, and chose not to, in his town, for reasons I do not yet have."

I found the slat-book in the upper room, in a drawer that had survived, probably because a drawer held nothing worth the unmaking of a wall. Most of it was the ordinary business of a small place — supply tallies, complaints, notes on the Scar and the weather it dragged behind it. Then, near the end, a hand that pressed harder on the wood:

"He was nervous," I said. "Listen. He's writing about keeping the 'Titan's stone' in town. 'Even hidden as it was.' He doesn't say what it is. Only that he'd been afraid of it for a while, and afraid of not having it, both at once."

Third had gone still. Not the watchful stillness. The other one — the one that meant something was being assembled behind the eye rather than observed in front of it.

"Titan's stone," he said, turning the frightened man's phrase over. "His name for it, not a true one. It will be a tool — one of the lesser ones, a thing the Titan made and set down and forgot, the way you or I might leave a chisel in a field. Not the great anchor the stories mean when they say such words. A small thing. But small things were how the Titan held the world together, and a man who is gathering them is not gathering them to build a fence." The eye came to me, the glow steady and hard. "And a frightened headman who did not know what he held — yet it walked straight to the box, in a town it had never seen, and opened the one that mattered and no other."

"So how did it know?" I asked.

"To come, or which wall?" The eye stayed on the emptied box.

"To come is the simple part. A town that hides a thing it fears cannot keep the secret — the fear leaks, into a tally-book, into a tavern, into the wrong ear, until it is a rumour, and a rumour walks farther than feet. It will have heard there was a town frightened of something it could not name, and come to learn whether the something was one of these, and to take it if it was." A beat.

"Which wall is the part worth fearing. No one showed it. It can feel these the way I can — they have a pull to them, faint and steady, a sound just below hearing — and it walked toward what it wanted the way water walks downhill. Nothing is directing it. Nothing has to."

"That's worse than someone telling it," I said.

"Yes," Third said.

"It usually is." Outside, the Scar had begun its slow crawl across the sky — that thirty-minute fade from full light toward the flat Anka dark. We had a walk to make before it finished, and the Herdukii by the gate to step over again, and I was going to be smelling this place for days whichever way the wind turned.

Mathen and Roan were waiting by the gap in the wall when we came out, Roan steadier now, Mathen with the particular lightness he put on when he'd decided the rest of us needed it.

"Anything?" Mathen asked.

"A direction," Third said.

"My favourite kind of nothing." Mathen fell into step. "Lead on, then. Away from the smell, ideally."

I took one last look back at the lockbox lid through the broken wall, lying where I'd set it. hexwood, unmarked but for the torn hinges. Made to last generations. Opened in seconds, and left behind because it was not interesting.

"Let's go," I said.

Third was already at the gate.

* * *

Eighteen

We passed a marker that evening that I didn't understand, and Mathen did, and the explaining of it is what undid us.

It stood where two trails crossed: a waist-high cairn with a flat stone set into its face, and on the stone, scratched deep and then darkened with something to make them distinct, two shapes. A tall thin figure on one side. A hunched toothed one on the other. Between them, a line, scored so hard it had split the stone.

"Boundary stone," Mathen said.

"Kro that way, Ork the other. You see them all through this country — it's old border, older than the towns that sit on it. The line's the thing. Whoever cut it cut it to last." He ran a thumb along the split. "They've been hating each other since before anyone can say. That's the one fact every version agrees on. Every other part of the story, you'll get a different telling in every town — who started it, who betrayed who, which of them was the real people and which the ruined copy. But the hate itself, nobody argues. It's just *there*. Like weather. Like the Scar."

"Why, though," Roan said. He was looking at the two scratched figures. "What did they actually do to each other, at the start of it?"

"Ah." Mathen settled back, the storyteller's pleasure coming over him. "Now, the one I like best — and I make no claim it's true, mind, I make a claim it's *good* — goes that they were one people once, and a great sorcerer offered to make them perfect, and they said yes, the fools,

because everyone says yes to that, and..." He spread his hands. "Two peoples woke where one lay down. Each one looked at the other and saw everything it had just thrown away, walking around wearing its face. And you can forgive a stranger anything. But you can't forgive your own discarded half. That's the version I tell. It's almost certainly wrong." He glanced, the way he'd taken to glancing, across the fire. "Ser? You'd know better than the stone-cutters. Were they one people, once?"

Third did not answer.

I had learned his stillnesses by then, and I watched the first one arrive — the kettle kind, the held kind, the kind that had ended in a quiet correction the night Mathen told the war wrong. I waited for the correction. *That is not how it was.* It was practically a comfort by now, that flat patient voice setting the record straight.

It didn't come. Instead the second stillness came over him, the one that went *down* — the glow guttering low, the attention turning to a place that was not our place — and he rose, without a word, and stepped, at an angle my eye slid off of, and was gone from the fire before Roan had finished waiting for his answer.

"...did I say something?" Roan asked.

"No," I said. But I sat very still, and watched the empty dark where Third had been, and understood for the first time that there were stories Third would correct and stories Third would walk into the grey to get away from, and that we had just, without meaning to, asked for one of the second kind.

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There had been, before, a stretch of spins that were nearly happy, and Third had let himself have them, which was the part he would never afterward forgive.

He was a warden of the wall by then. Not honorary any longer — the Virek had stopped saying the word, which was how he knew it had stopped being true, the way a scar stops being a wound when you forget to favour it. He walked the high logs at night and the green ones on watch with him no longer kept their distance, or kept less of it, and Liwon ran with the other children in the day and dreamed in their tongue at night, and that was right, and Third had decided to be content, and was, almost.

Wally was still with them. Wally did not grow, which nobody remarked on because nobody remarks on the Hin, but he had taken to walking the wall with Third on the long nights, the small person made of stories keeping company with the large one who had run out of them to tell. They did not always speak. It was enough, those nights, to stand the watch together and let Liwon belong to someone else in the daylight, and to mind, in the low private way Third had learned to mind things, like a temperature.

He saw the flicker from the wall.

It was far off, deep in the wood, and very bright — a white flash with a blue heart to it, there and gone, the kind of light you feel behind your eyes a moment after you stop seeing it. He marked it the way he marked everything, and was turning to call it down to the others, when the veins came.

They came up over everything at once. Red, branching, vast — across the ground and across the sky and across the walls and the wood and across his own outstretched arm, a webwork of red light that had the terrible quality of seeming to have been there always, beneath the skin of the world, and only now made to show. They held for a breath. Two. He had time to think *I have seen this colour before,* and to be right, and not to have time to finish being right —

— and then they were gone, and the village was full of growling.

He turned from the wall.

The Virek were not there.

Where the green ones had been — on the wall beside him, in the yards below, in the doorways of the woven houses — stood strangers. Pale ones, fine-boned, tall, with hair so fair it was nearly no colour at all, nor the green that the skin had been; they stood blinking in their new bodies, appalled, looking at their own pale hands. And among them, lower, broader, black-haired and already showing teeth, the others. The green had not left those ones. It had gone *into* them, concentrated, a deeper and angrier green, and they had teeth meant for meaning it, and they were the ones making the sound.

For one held instant, the whole village stood and looked at itself, pale beside green, and saw.

Then it began. Not a battle — there was no battle in it, no sides drawn, only the oldest recognition there is, every pale one seeing the green one that had been the rest of it and every green one seeing the pale, and the seeing being unbearable, and the unbearable becoming, in the space of a breath, hands and teeth and the wall-logs torn loose for clubs. It began everywhere at once. It began the way the veins had come, as if it had always been there under the skin of these people and the flash had only made it show.

"Liwon," Third said.

He had not decided to say it. He was already moving.

* * *

Zala's house was at the wall's foot, and the laminated reed of its door hung in tatters, and Third put his shoulder through what was left and stopped, and every gear in him stopped with him.

There were two children on the floor.

One was pale. A small girl, fine-boned and new, with hair gone nearly clear and eyes a blue he had never seen because Liwon's eyes had been Virek-dark and these were not, these were a blue like the heart of the flicker, and they were open, and they found him, and her body was torn in a way that the small new pale body could not mend and would not survive, and she was looking at him.

The other was green. Smaller-seeming, though they were the same, crouched over the pale one with blood on its fingers and its mouth, and it too looked at Third, and what came off it was rage and terror and a disgust so total it had no room left for anything that might have been love, and Third understood — in the flat fast way the old thoughts used to bring him things, except the thoughts were silent now, the thoughts had nothing — that these were not two children.

They were one child. They were the halves of one child, sundered the way the wood-stone said two peoples were sundered, and they had woken in the same room into the same instant of hating what they'd lost, and they had not even had names for it yet, they had only had each other, within reach.

The green one broke first. It scrambled up the wreck of Zala's furniture and went out the high window into the dark, fast, low, the way the thoughts had always told Third the green ones moved, and Third took one step after it —

— and outside there was a shout, a bright triumphant boy's shout, and then a wet sound, and the shout turned to laughter, and Third knew without going to the window that one of the pale ones had found the green child in the dark and done to it what pale and green were going to be doing to each other from this night until the end of the world.

He turned back to the one on the floor.

He crossed the room. Two paces. He had crossed worse rooms in two paces and not felt them; he felt this one. He knelt, and his hands, which could mend any part of himself, which had mended every part of himself at least once, hung over the torn pale body and could do nothing, because she was not made of wood and titan-blood, she was made of the thing the green ones and pale ones were all made of, the soft mendable-only-by-time thing, and there was no time, there was the opposite of time.

"Bada?"

It was barely a breath. It came from the pale child's mouth, from lips that had never made the sound before because they had not existed before, in a body a quarter-hour old. But it was the sound. The exact sound. The lower lip, even now, even torn, going out the way it went out when she was small and frightened and wanted only to be lifted and held against the bellows until the world stopped being so large.

Bada. The word she had made for him before she had words. Another of her words he had decided not to correct toward accuracy, because accuracy had stopped being the only thing he wanted.

Something in Third broke that he did not have a part to replace.

"I am here," he said. "Liwon. I am here."

The blue eyes — the wrong eyes, her eyes — stayed on him a moment, and were uncertain, the way they were uncertain in strange surroundings, and these were the strangest surroundings, this new pale unasked-for self. And then they were not uncertain about anything anymore.

There was a small sound behind him.

Wally stood in the broken doorway. Wally, who had not changed — who could not change, who was not Virek, who was a story and stories do not sunder — Wally stood unchanged in a village where every single soul had been split in two, and he was looking at the pale child on the floor with an expression Third had never seen a Hin wear, because Hin do not, as a rule, have anything in their lives that a true thing can hurt.

"That's her," Wally said. Not a question. Plain Hin-honesty even now. "Both of them were her. The one outside too." He came in, and knelt on the child's other side, small and solid and entirely real, and he reached out and closed the blue eyes with two fingers, gently, the way you'd do for someone, because Third's hands would not stop hanging uselessly in the air and someone had to, and Wally was the only one left who could.

And as he did it — Third saw it and would carry the seeing forever — Wally's hand, where it touched the child's face, was not quite as solid as it had been. You could not have said how. You could only have said that a thing made of telling had just lost the one it had been told to, and that the world had noticed, and had begun, very gently, the way the tide goes out, to ask for him back.

"Wally," Third said.

"I know," said Wally. "It's all right. I got to be in the good part." He looked up, and he was still smiling, a little, the smile of the stories he was made of. "You tell it. The good part. You keep telling it, and maybe I—" He stopped. He looked at his own hand. "Huh," he said, softly, the way you'd say it at a mildly interesting thing, and that was the last whole word Wally said in front of him, though it was not, Third would learn, the last of Wally.

* * *

He found himself in the grey without stepping there.

It took him without his choosing it, the way it had the first time, on the field, under the dust — one breath in the torn room with the closed-eyed child and the fading friend, and the next breath the room was gone and the colour was gone and he was kneeling in the swirling nothing with the wisps coming off his own arms, and where she had been, was empty grey floor. Not even the silhouette of her. The grey did not keep her. The grey, which kept so much, would not keep the one thing he would have given the rest of it to hold.

Behind him, the voice.

"Loss is profound," it said, "when the relationship has grown for some time."

It was barely above a whisper, and it had the weight of a mountain choosing to lie down. He did not turn. He could not have borne to see it, the vast horned dark of it, the thing whose dust had woken him and whose blood ran in the geysers and whose teeth lay in the fields; the thing that had made the world as a child makes a thing, with great power and no wisdom and no notion at all of what it is to be small inside the made thing and to love another small thing inside it.

"How do I fix this," Third said. He was not sure it was a question. It came out of the broken place, which was still broken, which he could already tell was going to stay broken in a way no wood and no blood would close.

"You do not," the voice said. There was no cruelty in it. That was the part Third would spend the next three hundred thousand or so spins failing to get out from under: there was no cruelty in it at all. "Like a seed, it must die and be buried before it blossoms into something beautiful. You are watching a beginning. You have mistaken it for an

ending, because you are small, and the small feel the burial and never see the bloom." A vast and patient nothing. "Two peoples now, where one was. More to play. More to watch. It is better. In time you will see that it is better."

The broken place in Third warmed, faintly, the way a coal warms — and he understood, with horror, that some made part of him, some old obedient architecture, *agreed*, was built to agree, found the logic clean. He wanted the warmth. He wanted, for one unforgivable instant, to believe that Liwon was a seed and her death a planting and that somewhere ahead was a bloom that would make the torn pale body on the floor into a thing that had been *worth it.*

He wanted the beauty. He did not want the pain.

And then he chose the pain, because the pain was hers and the beauty was the Titan's, and he would not give the Titan one more thing that had been Liwon's, not even the meaning of her dying.

He stood up, and stepped back.

The room was still there, just. The fighting outside had thinned to the after-sounds of it, the single cries and the running feet and the long silences between. The child lay where she lay, eyes closed by a friend who was no longer in the doorway, who was not anywhere Third could see, though Third would feel him for a long time yet, thin and far, the way you feel a story you are forgetting.

And the former part of Liwon lay at his feet, and Third, who could mend anything he was made of, stood in the wreck of the only stillness he had ever managed to give her, and could not mend this, and did not try, and stayed.

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He came back to the fire near the bottom of the night.

He didn't step out of the dark so much as resolve from it, suddenly accounted for at the edge of the light. The glow of his eye was down past the lowest ember I'd seen on him — down to almost nothing, a coal under ash — and it took a long moment finding me, and longer still coming up to anything I'd have called present.

Mathen had waited up. Roan had fallen asleep mid-wait, the way the young do. Mathen looked at Third across the coals, and whatever he saw there made him set aside, very quietly, the storyteller's hunger I'd watched him carry toward Third for a tenday.

"You don't have to," Mathen said. "I withdraw the question. It was a pub question. I'm sorry I asked it by a real fire."

Third was quiet a while. The coals ticked.

"They were one people once," he said, at last. The voice came from somewhere deeper than usual, the bellows dragging under it. "They chose to become perfect, and were offered the means, and took it. Two woke where one had lain down. Each kept what it could not bear to keep whole, and could not forgive the other for carrying the rest." A pause. "Your version is not wrong, master Mathen. It is only missing the part where it happened to specific people, in specific rooms, on a specific night, and someone watched, who had loved one of them." The ember held on the fire. "Tell yours. It is kinder. Kind is a fair trade for their coin."

And that was all. Mathen didn't push, and I didn't, and we banked the fire and slept, and in the morning Third was Third again, watchful and dry and exact, and walked us anti-spinward under a sky that had a wound in it but no veins, and I thought — Scar help me, I actually thought — that it had only been a hard memory of a long war, the kind a soldier carries.

I did not know there had been a child. I did not know there had been a friend made of stories. I did not know that the thing every town agreed on, the hate older than weather, had a night attached to it, and a name, and that the name was one Third had decided, long ago, not to correct toward accuracy.

I know now. I am telling it. That is the only thing I can do with it — the thing Mathen said, that I didn't understand until I was the one left carrying it.

You make more than one person carry the thing.

So that it doesn't all rest on him.

* * *

Nineteen

Third changed after the boundary stone.

I didn't have the why of it — I thought it was the question we'd asked, the Kro and the Ork, some old soldier's wound I'd blundered a finger into — but the shape of the change I could see plainly enough. He walked faster. He stopped asking whether we needed to rest and started telling us when we would. He spent the night watches further out, and came back from them later, and twice I woke to find him not at the fire at all and then there at the edge of the dark before I'd finished being afraid, as if he'd been somewhere and come back, lessened, the way he came back lessened from the carts.

And he started drawing in the dirt.

He'd squat at the cold morning fire and lay out the country with a stick — here the town that died, here the road, here the line the collector had walked through it, dead straight, and then he'd extend the line with the stick, on and on, the way you'd extend any straight thing, and he'd look at where it went.

"He does not wander," Third said, the fourth morning. "He is told where each one lies, and he goes to it in a straight line, and the next will be here." The stick stabbed a point ahead of us and anti-spinward, up in country that rose toward the rim. "A high place. Old. There has been a keeping there a long time — I have heard of it, the way you hear of a thing for three hundred — for a very long time, without ever needing to go." The eye came up to us. "If we

go hard, we reach it before he does. And then, for once, we are not reading what he has done. We are standing between him and the next thing he wants."

"And then what," Mathen said. Not a challenge. A storyteller making sure he had the stakes right before he committed them to memory.

Third looked at the line in the dirt for a moment.

"Then we find out what he is," he said. "I have been chasing a hole in the world the shape of the things it has taken. I would like, before the Graveyard, to see the thing that fits the hole."

He scuffed the map out with his hoof, and we went hard.

We went hard into rising country, and the country answered, the second afternoon, by throwing rocks at us out of a clear sky. There was no cloud. That was the part I could not make peace with — the Spire was shining, the day was fine, and then a pebble cracked off the trail at my feet, and another, and Third said one word, "stony," and put us at a dead run for an overhang he'd already marked without telling anyone he was marking it. By the time we reached it the air was full of them, stones the size of knuckles and then the size of fists falling out of nothing at all, hammering the grass flat, hammering Roan's other shoulder hard enough to drop him before Mathen dragged him in under the rock. They say it's the glutton's teeth, Mathen told me, hunched beside me while the world cracked and rattled outside our little shelter — that the broken teeth of one of the Titans are scattered out ahead of us in fields, and that the sky over that country never quite forgives it, and drops stone the way other skies drop rain, for no reason and to no schedule and on whoever happens to be under it. It lasted the length of a short tantrum and then simply stopped, the last few stones pattering down into a silence that rang, and we crawled out onto a trail

strewn white with rubble that hadn't been there an hour before, and went on, because the place all the lines pointed was that same teeth-strewn country, and it had just told us, plainly, what it thought of visitors.

* * *

The keeping was a tower of dry-laid stone on a tor, the kind of high bare place where the wind has opinions, and it had been there long enough that the path up to it was worn into the rock a hand's-depth, and the keeper who met us at the top was as worn as the path.

She was old in the way that stops being about how many thousands of spins. She watched the four of us climb the last of it — a Forged, a swordsman, a guardsman, and a girl who served stew — and she did not reach for the bell-rope by the door, and she did not look afraid, and that was the first thing that frightened me, because everyone is at least a little afraid of Third, and she wasn't, because she had clearly decided some time ago that there was a worse thing coming and we weren't it.

"You're late if you're help," she said, "and early if you're him. Which."

"Help," Mathen said. "Late, possibly. How long have you known he was coming?"

"All my life. It's the keeping. You keep the thing, and you keep the knowing that one day someone comes for the thing, and your whole use is to have kept it that long." She stood aside from the low door. "My grandmother's grandmother kept it. I have no one to hand it to. I had started to hope I'd die first and make it someone else's morning." She looked at Third as we passed, and something moved over her face, recognition without fear. "You're old enough to know what it is. Tell them, if you like. I'm tired of being the only one who carries it."

Inside, on a stone shelf worn to a dish by the centuries of hands that had checked it was still there, lay the thing. It was not impressive. They never are, Third said once — the load-bearing things never look like much, because the Titan had no need to make them look like anything. It was a short rod of something that was almost glass and almost not, pale, the faint blue-white of the dried stuff in the geyser field, with a grain to it like wood. I reached to pick it up the way you'd pick up anything, and it would not come. Not stuck — fixed, as though the rod and the stone shelf and the hill beneath the stone were one piece and always had been. I pulled harder, feeling foolish, and it was like trying to lift a line drawn on the floor.

"You have to wake it," the keeper said.

"Tap this end, once." She touched the near end of the rod.

"Then it remembers it's a thing, and a thing can be lifted. Tap the far end and it forgets again — settles back into being a place, and a place does not come up for anyone." She watched me.

"This end, girl." I tapped the near end with one finger. Something let go — I felt it in my teeth more than heard it — and the second time I closed my hand around the rod it lifted easy, and had a weight to it then, like a held breath.

"It is a peg," Third said, very quietly, turning it in the firelight without taking it from my hands. "A small one. The Titan made the world and tied it down, the way you'd peg a tent against a wind, so that it would not — drift, unmake, I do not have the word, the word is older than words. There are pegs like this all through the world. Most no one will ever find. He is finding them." The eye dimmed. "I had thought he was gathering tools to build something. He is not building. He is pulling pegs."

"And when you pull all the pegs out of a tent," Mathen said slowly.

"You do not have a tent," said Third. "You have cloth, and wind, and whatever the tent was keeping out."

The keeper laughed, a dry awful sound. "There," she said. "Now there's two of you who know. I feel lighter already." And then, because the wind had changed, or because a lifetime of keeping had taught her exactly what the changing of it meant: "He's here. Put it back, girl. Putting it back never helped, but I'd like it to be on the shelf. I'd like to have kept it to the end."

I put it back on the worn stone dish and tapped the far end the way she'd shown me, and felt it take — felt the rod stop being a thing under my fingers and settle back into being a place, fixed, part of the hill again. My hands weren't steady.

I had to tap twice before it caught.

* * *

I had built him, in my head, out of the wounded man's words and the wreck of the town. I'd made him huge. A figure of smoke and ruin, something that came on like weather.

He came up the worn path like a man.

That was the first wrong thing — that he was man-sized, man-shaped, walking on his own two feet up the same hand-worn path we'd climbed, unhurried, as if he had all the spins there had ever been. He wore something that had been clothing once and was now mostly the idea of it. And on his back, rising over his shoulders like the frame of a pack, were six jars of magefire. I knew it on sight; anyone raised in Anka would. The white-with-a-hint-of-blue that comes off the powder inside, caged lightning, the stuff the militia loads into a Boltcaster and calls a shot — the same

cold clear glow that lived behind the seam of Third's chest. But a shot is a little thing, a vial you could hide in your fist, and there's a size a shot is and no other, and has been as long as anyone's been selling them. These were jars: great hand-shaped jars, each big enough to put up a hundred spins of preserves in, and older-looking than any shot I'd ever passed across a bar, as if they'd been made before anyone had decided what a vessel of the stuff should be. Six of them, lit from inside, casting no warmth, throwing his shadow six ways at once down the rock.

Third had said it back at the inn, and I had not truly heard it until now: *a great many bottles of it, more than I have ever seen one body carry, and I do not know why it needs so much.* I had imagined a rack of the little shots. I had not imagined six jars of caged storm riding the shoulders of a man strolling up a goat-path to rob a frightened town. He did not look at us. That was the thing I have never been able to make people understand. We were four armed and frightened people standing between him and the thing he'd come for, and his eyes — they were a man's eyes, that was the worst of it, just a tired man's eyes — passed over us the way yours pass over the furniture in a room you're crossing to reach the window.

Roan moved first.

I want it written down exactly, because I have heard it told wrong since, told as foolishness. It was not foolishness. Roan stepped into the doorway with his spear levelled and his voice shaking and he said "you don't go in," and he meant it, and he was more frightened than I have ever seen a person be, and he did it anyway, and that is the only thing bravery has ever been.

The man looked at him. For the first time, something behind the tired eyes engaged — mild, almost kind, the look you'd give a child who'd planted himself in your path

with his arms out.

And then he stepped sideways.

I felt Third go rigid beside me. Not move — the opposite of move. He went rigid the way you go rigid when you see a thing that cannot be, and the not-being of it nails you to the spot, and in the half-breath that Third stood nailed, the man was simply — past. Past Roan's spear, past the door, not through them, beside them, gone out of the world at that angle my eye could never hold and back into it on the inside of the tower, between Mathen and the shelf, and he reached out and took the peg off the worn stone dish the way you'd take a cup off a table in your own house.

He did not wake it. I had set it back into a place with my own shaking hands, and a place does not come up for anyone — and it came up for him, no tap, no catch, as though it had never been fixed to anything at all. Then Third moved. Too late, knowing it was too late, crossing the tower in a stride with his glaive coming round — and the man looked at him.

At Third. Only at Third. The mild eyes found the Forged and for one instant they were not mild at all, they were *interested*, they sharpened on Third the way they had not sharpened on four armed strangers, and his head tilted a fraction, the way you tilt your head at a sound you half-recognise from a long time ago. His mouth moved. I was close enough to see it and not to hear it, and I have spent a long time since trying to read the shape of the word off the memory of his lips, and the nearest I can come is that it was not a word of threat.

It might have been the start of a name.

Then he stepped sideways again and the tower was only the tower, wind through the door, the keeper on her knees by the empty dish, Roan still braced in the doorway against

a man who wasn't there anymore, and Mathen with his good blade half-drawn and nothing to draw it on, and Third standing in the middle of the round stone room with his glaive up and his single eye gone down to a coal, staring at the place where the air had closed.

* * *

Nobody had touched him. That was the whole of it, and it took us all a while to be able to say it. Four of us, and the worn old keeper, and her hand-deep path, and her grandmother's grandmother's keeping — and he had walked up like a man and stepped out of the world twice and taken the peg and not troubled to harm a single one of us, because harming us would have required us to matter, and we hadn't.

The keeper didn't weep. She knelt by the empty dish and put her hand in the worn hollow of it, the dish her people had worn smooth with checking, and she left it there, and she said, to no one, "well," in the voice of a person setting down a thing they have carried so long that the not-carrying is worse than the weight ever was.

Mathen got her up, and got water into her, and got a fire going, because that is what Mathen does, he tends the spaces between the standing and the falling. Roan sat in the doorway where he'd braced and looked at his own hands as if they belonged to someone he was disappointed in, and I went and sat by him, because I'd watched him do the bravest thing on that tor and I wasn't going to let him learn the wrong lesson from its uselessness.

"It didn't matter," he said.

"It mattered," I said. "It just didn't *work*. You'll want to keep those two apart in your head or they'll rot each other."

He didn't answer, but he didn't get up either, and we sat.

Third had not moved from the middle of the room.

I went to him last, because he was the one I understood least and feared most to ask. The coal of his eye had not come back up. He was looking at nothing, at the closed air, at the angle.

"Third," I said. "What did you see?"

And he was quiet for long enough that I thought he wouldn't answer, and when he did it was not to my question, not really, it was to some older one of his own.

"He went sideways," Third said.

"I — yes. He vanished. Both times. How—"

"He went sideways," Third said again, and there was something under the avalanche of his voice I had never heard there before, something I would not have a name for until much later, when I had learned what it cost a thing to be the only one of its kind for three hundred thousand spins and then, on a windy tor, in the middle of a robbery, to discover that it was not. "I have never," he said, "in all that time, met anything else that could do that."

He turned and looked at me then, and the coal of his eye had a question in it that I couldn't answer and he plainly couldn't either, and the glowing six-lamped shape of the man who'd walked up like a man was burned into both of us, and somewhere in the part of Third where the gears turned wrong, two cold blue-white lights I would not understand for a long time yet were quietly keeping him alive, the same cold blue-white as the six that had just walked back out of the world.

He didn't say that part. He didn't know to, or he knew and couldn't. But I think it was in him even then, the wrongness, the recognition with no shape — that he had

finally seen the thing that fit the hole, and the thing that fit the hole was lit by the same light he was.

"We've lost it," I said, because someone had to say a true thing that was the right size.

"We have lost this one," Third agreed. "Yes." The eye came up, by degrees, to something like itself. "Now we stop reaching the pegs after him. Now we go to the place all the lines point, and we are there before him, and we do not stand between him and a thing on a shelf." He looked out the low door, anti-spinward, toward the country that rose toward the rim and the fields and, back spireward of them, the place the whole crooked map had been pointing at since the town that died. "We stand between him and the last peg. The one the whole tent hangs from."

"The Graveyard," Mathen said quietly, from the fire.

"The Graveyard," said Third.

* * *

Twenty

There is a trick to not seeing a thing, and I was good at it, and the trick is this: you keep your eyes moving. You don't let them rest on the wrongness. You catalogue around it — the hooves, the bellows, the way the eye is a hole and not a lamp — you note each piece and you file it and you never, ever, lay the pieces out side by side on the same table, because the moment you do they stop being pieces and start being a picture.

I had been not-laying-them-out for a long time. Coming down off the tor, in the grey after the robbery, I caught myself doing it still — filing the new piece, the man who stepped sideways, the man who glowed, next to the old pieces and quickly looking away — and I understood, the way you understand you've caught a chill, that I wasn't going to be able to keep it up much longer. Some tables get too full. The pieces start lining themselves up while you're asleep.

We walked the rest of that day mostly in silence. Roan walked like a man carrying a stone he couldn't put down, and twice I started to talk to him about it and twice Mathen caught my eye and gave the smallest shake of his head — *not yet, let it sit* — and he was right, he usually was, about the spaces between people. Third walked in front, as ever. But I found I couldn't look at his back the easy way anymore. The pieces were lining up.

I took the watch with him that night, because I'd decided to, the way I decide most things, which is to say I

didn't decide it so much as discover I'd already made up my mind.

* * *

He stood a little apart, as he did now, at the edge of the firelight, his eye on the dark. I came and stood beside him, not too close, and for a while I just stood the watch the way he stood it, and let the wanting-to-ask build up its courage.

"How does he do it," I said, finally. "Going sideways. How do *you* do it." I made myself add the second part, because the first part alone was a coward's question.

Third was quiet long enough that I thought I'd hit the limit of him, the place where he simply declined. Then, without turning from the dark, he said:

"There is a place beside this one. I do not have a true name for it; the name I have is borrowed and probably wrong. It is grey. There is no up in it, and no down, and very little ground, and the wind in it is not weather." The eye stayed on the dark. "You do not pass *through* the world to reach it. You step *beside*. From there, this world — the fire, you, the trees — is only smears of pale light, very far off, and you can walk a little way along the grey and step back in somewhere the wall, or the carts, or the man with the spear, can no longer stop you."

"That's — " I didn't have the word. "That's how he walked past Roan."

"Yes."

"And the carts. At the causeway. You did that. You went there and came back on the other side."

"Yes."

I'd known it — I'd *seen* it — but hearing him say it plain, name it like a fact about the weather, did something to the back of my neck. "How long have you been able to?"

"Since the beginning. Since I woke. It is not a thing I learned. It is a thing I am." The eye came round to me, the glow level. "Which is why tonight was — " and there he stopped, and the glow guttered, and I watched him reach for a true word and find only the size of the thing. "I have been able to step beside the world since before there were towns to step into. In all of that, I have never once met another thing that could do it. Not a Forged. Not a sorcerer. Not a beast. I had decided it was mine. The single thing in the world that was only mine." A pause. "Tonight a man walked up a hill and did it twice in front of me, and looked at me while he did, and his face — Tasha, his face did the thing your face does when you hear a tune you knew as a child and cannot place. He half-knew me. And I do not know him. And I do not know how that can be true, and it is the first thing in a very long time that I have not known and could not simply wait until I did."

It was, I realised, the most frightened I had ever heard him. Not loud. Third was never loud. But there was a thing missing from his voice that was always there, and the missing of it was the fear: the certainty. Third always knew. It was the most Third thing about him, more than the hooves or the eye — that flat unhurried *I have seen this, I know what it is, here is what it does.* And the man on the tor had reached into him and taken the certainty out.

"You think he's the same as you," I said. "What you are. You think you're — kin, somehow."

"I think the evidence permits it," he said, which was the closest Third came to *yes, and it terrifies me.*

* * *

I should have let it lie there. I am good at letting things lie. But the pieces were on the table now, all of them, lined up while I'd been not-looking, and a picture is a hard thing to

unsee once it's assembled, and the picture had a hole in the middle of it the exact shape of a question I hadn't asked.

"When you go there," I said. "The grey. You come back — less. Every time. The carts. The boundary stone, the night Roan asked about the Kr. You go, and you come back with the light in your eye gone down to nothing, like a fire somebody sat on. And you told me, at the carts, that you come back the same as you leave." I kept my voice even, which took some doing. "That was the only thing you've ever said to me that I knew was a lie. I let it go then. I'm not letting it go now. What's *there,* Third? What costs you that much, just to cross a few paces of grey?"

He didn't answer for a long time. The fire ticked. Roan murmured something in his sleep, and Mathen — I'd thought Mathen was asleep — shifted, and went still again, in the particular way of a man who has decided to let a conversation belong to the two people having it.

"The grey keeps things," Third said, at last. "That is the part I can tell you, and it is true. It is very old, and it is mostly empty, and into the empty go the things a person does not look at directly. They wait there. They are patient. When I cross — even for a few paces, even to step past a cart — I cross *through* them, and they rise, and they walk the grey beside me, and they are not the kind of thing you set down again on the other side just because you have arrived." The eye was on the dark, not on me. "That is the cost. It is not the crossing. The crossing is nothing. It is what is waiting in the place I cross."

I understood about half of it, and the half I understood was enough.

"You go there to be with someone," I said. Quietly. Not a question. "Not just to cross. The good ones, you said — you said you'd been somewhere good and come back lessened, and the good ones were the ones worth walking back into.

You *go*. On purpose. To be with — someone you lost."

The watch went very quiet.

He did not say yes. He did not say no. He did the thing he had done in the inn when I'd asked the first careful question of him, a whole lifetime of road ago — his hand, at his side, closed and opened, once, the way it had in the Snake Forest, and again on the tor — and the eye stayed on the dark, and the bellows drew long and slow, and he said, after a while, in a voice I had to lean in to hear:

"You are better at seeing than you let yourself be, Tasha. I had wondered when you would stop arranging the pieces around the gap and look into it." A pause. "Yes. There is someone. There were several someones; that is what a long life is, mostly, a accumulation of someones who are no longer there. But there is one. And the grey is where I can still — " the coal of his eye sank, and held, and steadied — "where I can still find the warm part, before the end of it. I do not tell you who, or how it ended, and I am asking you not to ask, not yet, not on a road with this much walking still in it. Some things you cannot carry and walk at the same time. But you have seen true. There is someone. That is what it costs me. Not the grey. Her."

Her.

He hadn't meant to give me that, I think. Or he had, exactly that much and not a grain more — *her*, one word, a door opened the width of a finger and held there. I did not push it wider. I had pushed enough, and I found, to my surprise, that I didn't want the rest of it tonight, that knowing the shape of it was already almost more than I could stand, that the *content* would have buried me and I wasn't ready to be buried.

So we stood the watch. The pieces stayed on the table. And the picture they made, now that I'd finally let them

make it, was this: a thing older than the towns, who could step out of the world and had thought that was the loneliest thing about him until tonight; who carried a dead someone in a grey place and went back to her when the world got quiet enough; who ran on two cold lights he hadn't made and couldn't replace; and who was walking, with the four of us strung along behind him, straight toward a creature that wore his own impossible strangeness like a second skin, to stand between it and the last peg in the world.

I had followed him out of an inn because I was bored.

I looked at the side of his ruined patient ancient face, the coal of his eye watching a dark that held nothing yet, and I understood that boredom had been the last simple feeling I was going to be allowed for a while.

* * *

"Tasha." Mathen, low, when I came off watch and Third had drifted out past the firelight to do the thing I now had a shape for. Mathen was awake, propped on one elbow, and he'd heard, of course he'd heard, the man heard everything.

"You saw it," he said. "Tonight. I watched you see it."

"Some of it."

"Aye, well. Some of it's how it comes." He lay back, looked up at the wound in the sky turning its slow turn. "I told him a thing, our first nights — that a story's how you make more than one person carry the weight. So it doesn't all rest on the one." A long breath. "I didn't think it'd be you so soon. I thought I'd have to do it. I'm a bit relieved, honestly. You're stronger in the back than I am. I just talk about carrying things." He closed his eyes. "Get some sleep. You've got a hard knowing ahead of you, and this was only the start of it. Best be rested for the rest."

I lay down. I did not sleep for a long while. Out past the fire, in the dark, Third stood his watch — and now and then, by signs I had only lately learned to read, he was not standing it at all: gone a breath beside the world, in the grey, with her, whoever she had been, and back before the fire could miss him. Getting the warm part while he still could.

I'd begun to see him. That was the thing about that night. Not all of him. But I'd stopped looking away, and you only get to look away the first time for free.

* * *

Twenty One

The blizzard was waiting for us on the far side of a warm afternoon, and it was not coming, and it was not going. It simply stood.

We came down a long gold slope into grazing country, the kind of soft easy ground that lets you forget for a while, and there across the bottom of it was a wall of white. Not cloud. Snow — falling snow, a curtain of it from the ground to as high as I could see, churning, the wind inside it loud enough to hear from where we stood in the warm — and on our side of the line the grass was green and the air was mild and a few paces beyond it the world was a screaming whiteout, and the line between the two was as straight and as hard as the edge of a table.

I had stopped walking without deciding to. "That's—"

"Weather," Mathen said, in the tone of a man who has seen enough of Anka not to argue with it. "It does that, out here. Stands. Or walks at you in a wall, which is worse — you can outrun a storm that knows where it's going. This kind just sits and waits to see if you're fool enough to need the ground it's sitting on." He squinted at it. "We need the ground it's sitting on."

"It'll end," Third said. "They do. But not soon, and not for our convenience. We go through. Keep close, keep the rope, and do not stop inside it — inside it is where it wants you to stop."

We tied on, and we went through the table-edge of it, and the warm afternoon was simply gone, cut off behind us

like a closed door, and we were in the white.

I have been cold since. I have not been in anything like that. It was not the cold that took you, it was the *sameness* — no up, no down, no forward that looked different from back, no sound but the one enormous sound, the world reduced to a roaring white nothing with four roped figures struggling through the middle of it. Roan vanished to a shape at rope's-length. The wind ate our voices. And in the middle of it, where you could see nothing and hear nothing and the world had stopped being a world and become only a white waiting, I felt the rope go slack ahead of me, and I knew, the way I knew things about Third now, that he had gone — not fallen, not lost. Stepped. Beside. Into the only quiet there was.

I held the slack rope and I waited, in the screaming white, for him to come back from wherever the stillness had sent him.

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After Liwon, Third stopped.

He did not decide to. There was no moment he could afterward point to and say *there, that is where I chose to stop* — there was only the carrying of her, the small weight of what had been her, to a place with a tree he thought she would have liked, and the putting of her into the ground, and the sitting down beside the place to make certain nothing disturbed it, and then the not getting up.

He told himself, at first, that he was keeping watch. That was a thing he knew how to do; he could do it for a long time. But the watch had no end written into it, because the thing he was guarding was past being harmed, and a watch with no end is only a way of describing a thing that has stopped.

The Scar swung overhead, dark and light and dark, faster than it should have, or his sense of it loosened — he could not afterward say which. Greenery came up around him. A vine found his still arm and climbed it and he did not brush it off, because brushing it off was a thing a person did, and he had stopped being sure he was one. The weather passed over him the way water passes over a stone in a stream: he felt it, distantly, as pressure and temperature, and it wore at him, and he let it. He stepped to the grey more and more — a breath gone from the hillside, a long while on the far side of it, the warm part, the part where she still got the rhyme right — and he stayed longer and longer inside each breath, and minded less and less the coming back, until the coming back was the only part he still did out of habit, and even the habit was wearing thin.

He was, he understood without alarm, dying. Not the way the soft ones died. The way a thing winds down. The lights in his chest he could always have kept — he had kept them three hundred thousand spins, a bottle scrounged here, bought there, pried from some dead place, none of the small ones lasting much past a hundred spins before they went to ash, so that staying lit had never been the hard part, only the bothering. And it was the bothering that was failing now: the will of him, the part the Titan had not built and had no name for, going out like a banked fire nobody fed.

He watched the dim light gutter, and did not get up, and did not go looking for the next. He had been there long enough to be more shrub than statue when the woman sat down in front of him.

She did it without ceremony, the way you'd sit on any convenient rock, and she looked at him — at the eye, which still lit, the one thing the vines had not taken — and she

said, "You're not dead. I've buried dead. You're something else."

Third did not answer. Answering was a thing a person did.

"That's all right," she said. "I'll talk. I'm good at it, and you appear to have the time."

Her name, he would learn over the slow spins that followed, was Lujian, and she was a wanderer of the particular kind that the loss of everything sometimes makes — not aimless, but unanchored, moving because the places she stopped all had holes in them shaped like people who weren't there. She had been a scholar of something once; she still had the habits of it, the naming, the patience, the need to understand a thing before she would consent to fear it. She had lost — she told him this plainly, early, the way you'd hand a stranger your name — a husband and both her children, in one of the small endless wars the sundered peoples had been making of the world since the night the veins came, and she had walked away from the graves of them and not stopped walking, and she was not, she said, looking for anything, except possibly a reason to be looking for something.

She found the stopped Forged, and she did not loot it, and she did not fear it, and she did not try to wake it. She simply began, each day, to sit in front of it and talk, and to clear, idly, a little of the growth from its joints while she did, the way you'd worry a loose thread.

It took a long time. She talked about the war, and the towns, and the two peoples who could not stop killing each other, and the grey philosophies of a poet she'd loved whose name Third would hear again much later from another mouth on another road. And one day — he did not know how many spins in, the count had stopped meaning anything — she said the thing that woke him, and she did

not say it to wake him, she said it because it was true and she was tired and she had stopped, a little, performing patience.

"I don't know what you lost," Lujian said, to the silent overgrown thing. "Something. You've the shape of a thing that lost something. I know the shape; I wear it." She pulled a vine off his wrist. "Here's what I've worked out, in all my walking. There's a thing the world wants you to believe, when it takes someone. It wants you to believe it was *for* something. That it'll make sense later. That they're a — seed, or a lesson, or a step on the way to some better thing, and if you just hold still and trust the design, the grief'll turn into a meaning and you'll be glad." Her voice had gone hard, not at him. "It's a lie. It's the kindest-sounding lie there is and it's still a lie. They weren't *for* anything. They were *theirs.* And the only thing your stopping does — this, the vines, the winding down — the only thing it does is finish the job. It turns them into exactly what the liar wanted. A thing that happened on the way to you sitting down."

The eye, which had not moved in a thousand spins, moved.

"There it is," Lujian said softly, not surprised, only tired and a little glad. "No. Don't — you don't have to say anything. I'm only telling you. If you want them to have been a person and not a *reason*, you don't get to stop. Stopping agrees with the liar. Going on is the only way left to call it what it was." She sat back. "It's not a comfort. I know it's not. It's the opposite of a comfort. It's a debt. But it's theirs, and it's yours, and I'd think a thing that's carried a glaive since before there were towns to carry it past could carry one more thing that heavy."

Third's hand, when he lifted it — the first thing he had moved on purpose in longer than he could hold — closed

around the vine she had been worrying, and pulled it, slow, from the wood of his arm.

"They were a child," he said. The voice came out of him cracked and disused, a landslide that had forgotten the shape of words. "I called her little one. She made it into a name."

Lujian nodded, the way you nod at a thing set finally down between you. "Then she had a name," she said. "That's more than most of mine got, at the end. Come on. You've a great deal of going on to do, and the first step's the worst of it; after that it's only walking."

He stood. The growth tore away from him in sheets. He had been a long time stopped, and the standing was its own kind of agony, every wound he had let go unmended announcing itself at once — and under the agony, faint, unwanted, the terrible relief of a debt accepted.

He did not stay stopped again. Whatever else the spins did to him after — and they did the usual things, they gave him Lujian's company on the road for a good span and then, in the way of all of it, they took her too, quieter than Liwon, an old woman's ordinary end with Third sitting the watch he actually knew how to sit this time, the kind with an end in it — he did not, ever again, sit down to wind himself out. She had made that impossible. She had turned his stopping into a thing he would have been doing *to* Liwon, and he would not do one more thing to Liwon, not even the mercy of an ending.

It was, he understood much later, the same refusal twice. The Titan had said *seed.* Lujian had said *hers.* And every spin Third kept walking was a spin he spent on Lujian's side of it.

He stepped back into the white.

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The rope went taut. He was there, ahead of me, a dark shape resolving in the white, leaning back into the line of it, and we struggled the last of the way through the blizzard's far wall and out the table-edge of it into — of course — a mild grey ordinary evening, dripping, the screaming cold sealed behind us like it had never been, already shrinking at our backs to a white wall standing patient over grass.

We were all of us soaked and shaking, except Third, who did not shake, but whose eye had gone to the coal again, the lowest ember, the look I had learned meant he had been somewhere and paid for it.

I got the rope off and went to him while Mathen got a fire fighting the damp and Roan stamped feeling back into his feet.

"You went," I said. Not a question; we were past those.

"I did."

"Her again?" I had earned that much, I thought — the one word he'd given me, *her*, and the right to use it.

"Not only her, this time." The ember considered the shrinking white wall. "Someone who came after. Who found me when I had — stopped. And made me start." A pause. "She has been gone a long time also. They are all gone a long time, Tasha. That is the part the grey does not change. I can have the warm parts back, as often as I like, for as long as I can stand them. I cannot have any of them *back*."

I didn't say anything for a moment. The pieces were on the table, and I had learned to look at them now, and a new one had just been set down, and I did not like the shape it made with the others.

"How many," I said. "Have there been. People who — found you. Started you."

The eye came round to me, and held, and I understood he knew exactly why I was asking, and that he was going to answer honestly because he had decided, somewhere back there in the white, that he was done managing me.

"A few," Third said. "Across a long time. Not many. The child. The one in the snow just now. A swordsman who told a joke about a Grask. A woman who was unwell." The ember was steady. "And a girl who served stew, who followed me out of an inn because she was bored, and who has lately begun to look at me as though she has worked out that she is on a list."

I had. That was the thing. I had just worked out exactly that.

"It's not a curse," he said, gently, which from Third was an enormous gentleness. "I want to be clear. You are not doomed by standing near me. Most of them died of the ordinary things, in the ordinary times, that the soft ones die of, and would have died of them whether they had met me or not. I am not the thing that kills them." The ember dimmed. "I am only the thing that remembers all of them. That is a different curse, and it is mine, and it is not catching."

"That's not better," I said. My voice came out smaller than I meant it.

"No," Third agreed. "It is not better. But it is true, and you have lately preferred true, even when it is not better. I thought you should have this one accurately."

Behind us the blizzard stood its patient ground over the grass, going nowhere, waiting for the next fools who needed the dirt beneath it. Ahead the trail ran on alongside the rim, toward the fields where the glutton's teeth lay scattered, toward the place all the lines pointed. And I walked it knowing, now, that I was the latest entry in a list

a very old creature had been keeping for three hundred thousand spins, and that the list had only ever ended one way, and that I was going to keep walking it anyway — which was, I understood with a lurch, exactly the choice a woman named Lujian had once talked him into, in a different ruin, a long time ago.

Going on was the only way to call it what it was.

* * *

Twenty Two

The country had been getting meaner for two days. The trees thinned and then gave up; the green went to a low grey scrub that crunched underfoot and smelled of nothing; the trail stopped being a trail and started being the least-bad line across a waste of broken stone. We were walking toward the place near the edge of the world where the dead were said to crawl, and the land had begun, in the way of lands, to dress for the occasion.

I started talking about home. I do that when the quiet gets too big to stand — I fill it, and I fill it with whatever is smallest and safest, and home was both. I talked about the inn the way you talk about a place once you've put enough hard road between yourself and it that you can no longer remember being bored there. The stove that drew wrong until you learned its mood. Tondi's bucket she'd never once touched a coin out of. The three rooms upstairs that were empty more often than not, and the way the whole building seemed to lean a little toward the fire of an evening, like the rest of us.

Third walked beside me and let me talk, which he was good at — better than anyone I'd known. He had a way of being a silence you could pour into without it spilling.

"And Kern," I said. "There was always Kern."

"Kern."

"A Kr. A fixture. He'd been coming in longer than I'd been closing up, longer than Tondi'd had the place, maybe. Sat at the window table for one cup he'd make last the

whole afternoon and never said three words you didn't dig for. I think I went my whole life finding him as much a part of the room as the window. You don't wonder about the window." I smiled at the scrub. "He had this bow. Always had it with him, leaned against the wall by his knee. A beautiful old thing — carved all the way down its length, this pattern too fine to really follow, worn pale and smooth where his shoulder rode it, and red worked down deep into the bindings, the way the Kro do their fine —"

I stopped.

I stopped because I had heard myself, and what I had heard was a description I had heard before, in a different mouth, on a different night, beside a different fire — *exquisitely made, someone had spent a long time on it, cared about every part of it* — a boy by a brook with a drawn bow and shaking arms, who had asked a question instead of loosing the arrow, and a thing of wood and stone that had not had a name for itself yet standing in the water hearing, for the first time in its existence, that a made thing could be beautiful and not just dangerous.

I turned. Third had stopped walking. He was a few paces back, where I'd left him when my feet had kept going and the rest of me hadn't, and the coal of his eye was on me, level and very still, and I understood that he had stopped some sentences ago.

"Third," I said. "Third, that's — the boy. From your story. The one by the water. The one who said—"

"A Blank just used I." His voice came slow, the avalanche moving one stone at a time. "Yes."

"It can't be the same bow." But I said it the way you say a thing you already know is wrong.

"Describe the carving again," he said. "The pattern too fine to follow. Tell me where it starts."

"At the grip. It — it spirals out from the grip, both ways, like it's growing from his hand—"

"From the grip, both ways, like a thing growing," Third said. "Yes. He had only just finished it, I think, when I knew it. There was no smoothness anywhere on it then. The carving was sharp enough to cut a thumb on; I remember thinking a person could ruin their hands keeping a thing that detailed. The red in the bindings was new and bright, not gone to rust the way you would have seen it. And his hands were not steady on it. He was very young, and very frightened, and he had made the most careful thing I had ever seen, and he was pointing it at me with his arms shaking." The eye did not move. "It does not wear smooth in one lifetime, Tasha. It does not wear smooth in fifty. What you wiped around at your window table — what some Kro made last an afternoon over a single cup — may be the same bow, worn by every shoulder that carried it between his and yours. That is what the smoothness is. That is what your hand was brushing past on its way to the next table. The whole length of the world, gone soft under a hundred hundred grips."

I sat down. I didn't decide to; my legs did it. There was a flat stone and I was on it.

"He's dead," I said. Stupidly. "The boy. He's—"

"He was Virek." Third said it gently, which from Third was its own kind of terrible. "You have seen, by now, more than I have told you, what became of the Virek. They are not dead, exactly. They are the Kr. They are the things in the dark with the teeth, too. They went into a light one night and came out as two halves of themselves and neither half remembered being whole. So no — I do not think the boy is dead in the way you mean. I think the boy is *gone* in a way that has no word, the way a river is gone when it reaches the sea — still there, still water, no longer the

river. Whatever he became, he was not himself by morning, and he has not been, for longer than there have been words for any of it." A pause, and then the thing that I think he had not meant to say out loud, because his voice dropped under it: "He was the first one. The first thing that ever looked at me and saw a someone instead of a weapon. I have carried that for the entire age of the world, and he forgot it inside a single night, and could not have helped the forgetting, and I do not get to be angry, because there is no one left to be angry at. There is only a bow."

The wind moved the grey scrub. Far off, the thing we were walking toward sat at the edge of everything, patient.

"And it ended up in the corner of a room you were bored in," Third said. "Leaned against a wall. Warming itself at a stove that drew wrong. Some Kro who could not have told you whose hands carved it, drinking one slow cup, keeping it by his knee out of a habit handed down so many times that the reason had worn off it like the carving. That is what I cannot — " and here the avalanche stopped, the long bellows of his chest drawing once, slow, the only sound he made that I would have called grief if I'd dared call it anything. "He is gone past finding. His whole kind is gone past finding. And the bow is leaning on a wall in a town not worth a name, whole, cared for, carried all this way by people who never knew what they were carrying. I do not know what to do with that. I have not known what to do with it since you opened your mouth. It is the best thing I have heard in a thousand spins and I cannot tell whether it is a comfort or the cruelest thing in the world."

I looked up at him. The pieces I'd been carrying since the fireside story slid, all at once, into a different shape — and I saw, the way I was learning to see him now, that this was not only about a boy and a bow. There was something underneath it, something he was holding very still so it

wouldn't show, the way you hold a cup you've filled too full. *Her*, I thought, from the night on the watch. *He is thinking about her. He is finding out whether a thing can be gone and not gone at the same time, and he is doing it out loud, on a bow, because the other thing he cannot say yet.*

I did not say any of that. I had learned that much.

"Both," I said instead. "It can be both, Third. I think the worst things and the best things are mostly the same things, looked at from where you're standing." I got up off my stone. "It got carried. That's the part I'd hold onto, if it were mine. Nobody knew, and it got carried anyway. All the way to me."

He looked at me for a long moment, the coal of his eye steady.

"All the way to you," he said. "Yes."

And we walked on, into the meaner country, toward the patient thing — and I found I was no longer thinking about how bored I had been at the inn. I was thinking that I had spent six thousand spins wiping a table beside the first beautiful thing a monster ever saw, and had called it handsome, and in my way, and had never once wondered how it came to be there.

You only get to not-wonder for free the first time.

* * *

Twenty Three

Mathen wanted a story. He always wanted a story — it was the engine that ran him, the way some men run on drink and some on grievance — but that night he wanted one badly enough to go after Third for it, which none of us had ever seen him do.

"You," he said, pointing across the fire with a spoon. "Three hundred thousand spins. Do not tell me you are not carrying a thousand of them. I have met mayflies with better stories than mine and they only got the one afternoon."

"I do not tell stories," Third said. "I report. You have remarked on the difference yourself, at length, the night we met."

"I remarked that you tell the *accurate* one when a person wants the *true* one. So tell me a true one. I'll allow the once. As a favour to an old man who cooked." He'd cooked; we'd eaten; the debt was real and he knew how to collect.

I expected Third to deflect again. He was good at it — a wall you could lean a whole evening against and come away with nothing. Instead the single light of his eye went down a little, the way a coal settles when you stop feeding it, and he was quiet long enough that Roan looked up from oiling a strap, and then Third said, in the voice like stone moving slow over stone:

"I will tell the tree story. It is not mine. But I have the right to it."

And he told it the way you'd tell it to a child, which I understood later was the only way it had ever been told.

There was a little one, he said, who would not sleep. Who cried in a way that had no bottom to it and no door out of it, and there was a person who did not know how to help, who had only ever known how to end things, and who was very frightened of the crying because it was the one thing in the world he could not stop. So one day, out of all his being-frightened, the person did the only thing he had ever known how to do, which was to end things. He broke the wood all around him — pulled the branches down, put his hands through the trunks, made a ruin of a quiet green place — because breaking was the only tool he had, and the crying could not be broken. And when the place was wrecked and the little one was crying still, for of course it was, he picked the little one up, and he stood under the last tree left standing, one of the golden kind, with the leaves that sing when the wind moves them, small and thin and ringing like the inside of a bell — and a bird came down and sat in the branches, not afraid, because the violence was all over by then and the wood had already forgotten it. And the person did not know what to do, so he swayed. Just swayed, under the singing tree, with the bird watching. And the little one stopped crying. And slept. And the person stood there for the whole turn of the dark, not moving, in case moving was the thing that had been wrong all along.

"That is the whole of it," Third said. "There is no battle in it. No one is clever. A frightened thing learns it can be still. That is the entire story."

Mathen, for once in his life, did not say anything.

I was the one who saw it. I'll put it down and you can make of it what you like.

Past the edge of the firelight, where the dark started, there was — I want to be careful — there was the

suggestion of someone sitting. Small. Knees drawn up the way a child sits to listen, or how a small grown person sits, I couldn't have said which. Listening with its whole self, as you only listen to a story you already know and love anyway. I'd swear the firelight went a little way *into* it instead of stopping at it, the way light goes into smoke. And it was smiling — I could feel that more than see it — the easy fond smile of someone hearing their favourite part land right.

I looked away to find my own breath, and when I looked back the dark was only dark.

"Wally," Third said. Soft. Into the place where the someone had been.

It meant nothing to me. I had never heard the name. But the way he set it down — gentle, like a cup you didn't want to wake anyone with — told me it was a name, and that it belonged to someone, and that the someone was not at this fire and was somehow, also, not entirely not at this fire.

"He liked the tree story best," Third said, and I noticed he said *liked* and then, a breath later, fixed it, quiet, only for himself: "—likes. He says mine is not as good as it used to be." The light of his eye came back up to ordinary. "He may be right. A story wears where you hold it."

"Who's—" Roan started, with the open face of a boy who asks the question everyone's thinking, and I caught his eye across the fire and gave the smallest shake of my head, and bless him, he stopped. Because I'd understood something I couldn't have said out loud yet. That there are tellings a person does for the listener, and tellings a person does *as* a keeping — the way you'd carry water cupped in your hands a long way, not because you're thirsty, but because someone down the road is. That Third had not told us the tree story.

He had told it so that it would go on being told. So that whoever it was out past the light would have, for the length of a story, somewhere warm to be.

"It is a good one," I said, when the quiet had gone on long enough to start to hurt. "Your story. The true one. It's a good one, Third."

"It is the good part," he said. And he put another piece of wood on the fire, though the fire did not need it, and we sat with it a while, the four of us and the maybe-fifth, in the singing nothing where the leaves would have been if there'd been a tree, before Mathen cleared his throat and started, very gently, on one of his own.

* * *

Twenty Four

Mathen had told us about the fields while the stones were still falling, hunched under that overhang with the sky cracking outside, and I had pictured something terrible. I always do. The thing itself was worse and better than the picture, the way the real things on Anka always were: not terrible. Quiet. A quiet that had teeth in it, but you had to earn the teeth.

We came up onto the fields near the middle of a Scar-light, and they ran away from us yellow and red to the rim of sight — heather, knee-high, the colour of an old bruise going gold, rippling in a wind that smelled of nothing at all. And standing up out of the heather, scattered across the whole vast gentle slope of it, were the stones.

They were like plinths. That was the nearest I could come to it — squared-off blocks of white going to the grey of old bone, planted up out of the heather at all different heights, none of them taller than a person, some no higher than my knee, some that I'd have had to look up at a little, no two the same, each one standing alone with a space of grass around it as though the ground itself kept a polite distance. There was no pattern to where they stood, and no pattern to how tall, and that was somehow the worst of it — a field of pale blocks at every height between ankle and brow, scattered to the rim of sight with no more sense to the arrangement than a thing a child sets down and forgets.

"Teeth," Mathen said, soft, because the field was the kind of place that takes your voice down whether you decide to or not. "The glutton's. They pulled them out of his head in the war — imagine the size of the thing that wore these — and they came down all over the world and stuck where they landed, and grass grew up around them, and here we are walking through the dropped teeth of a god, calling it a field." He looked almost happy, in the way Mathen got happy at a thing that was too big to be anything but a story. "You can't make this up. You wouldn't dare."

I put my hand on the nearest one as we passed, the way I'd touched the causeway pillar, because apparently that's the kind of fool I am, I have to touch the impossible thing to believe it's let me. It was warm. Not sun-warm. Warm like a thing that had been alive once and hadn't entirely got the message. I took my hand back.

And then I saw the rocks that floated.

* * *

There were clusters of them, here and there among the plinths — fist-sized chunks of the same white, a dozen or so to a clump, and they hung in the air. Not falling. Not rising. Just *there*, at about chest height, turning very slowly around nothing, the way dust turns in a shaft of light, except these were stones, and there was no light-shaft, and there was no reason. They drifted, when the wind took them, but lazily, like they were only being polite to the wind and could have ignored it if they'd liked.

"Don't," Third said, when I drifted toward the nearest clump the way you drift toward anything that shouldn't be. It was the first he'd spoken since we came up onto the field, and I stopped.

"They float," I said, which was stupid, but I was past managing my mouth.

"They float." He came up beside me, his eye on the clump, level and careful. "The teeth do not like the black glass that veins the world; they shy from it, push away from it, and a chip with a vein beneath it will hang in the air, slowly turning, for as long as you leave it be. A small one gets carried home as a charm — a strange, harmless thing that tugs out of your hand toward any glass you bring near it." A pause. "People come here and harvest them. It is a trade. There is a town, rim of the fields, that lives on nothing else."

"So they're safe."

"Those are safe," Third said. "Those." And he did not point, because pointing is a motion, and I was about to learn why that mattered. "The trouble is that not all of them are those. And from here, with your eyes, you cannot tell which are which. Neither can Mathen. Neither can Roan." The eye came round to me. "I can. Mostly. It is the only reason I am useful on this particular ground, and it is why, from here to the far side, you are going to do a thing you will hate, which is exactly what I tell you, exactly when I tell you, and nothing else."

Behind me Roan said, "What's the difference?" and his voice had the careful flatness of a man who has already guessed he won't like the answer.

"The difference," Third said, "is that some of these clouds wake up when something moves."

* * *

He showed us, because Mathen asked him to and because we needed to see it once to believe it enough to obey. He found a clump a good way off — *that one, watch it, do not move toward it* — and he took a stone from the ground and

threw it, hard, so that it skittered through the grass near the floating cluster.

The cluster came apart.

That's the only way I can say it. The dozen polite turning stones simply *stopped being polite*, and the whole clump swept down off its place in the air and went for the moving stone like a dog off a chain, fast, a swirling shrieking cone of rock that hit the place the thrown stone had stopped and tore the heather to green rags in a circle the width of a room, and hung there, swirling, waiting — and when nothing else moved, it slowed, and rose, and gathered itself back up to chest height a few paces from where it had started, turning slowly around nothing, polite again. Patient again. A dozen fist-sized stones hanging in the gold light, for all the world exactly like the harmless ones forty paces to its left.

Nobody said anything for a moment.

"How many of them are the bad kind," I said.

"On a field this size? Perhaps one in six. Perhaps one in five today; they seem more numerous the closer you come to the Graveyard, and we are coming to the Graveyard." Third turned and looked at the long gold slope of standing teeth running away ahead of us, dotted everywhere with those slow turning clumps, harmless and lethal and identical. "We cross between them. We move when I say, in the line I walk, and we do not hurry, because hurrying is motion and motion is the thing they listen for. When I stop, you stop — not slow down, *stop*, mid-step if I say it mid-step, and you hold, however long it takes, until I move again. A cloud may come near you. It may come very near you. If it has not woken to *you* — if you have given it nothing to wake to — it will lose interest and drift off. The whole of staying alive on this field is being, for as long as necessary, less interesting than a stone."

"And the Scar," Mathen said, looking up. The dark edge of it was a long way off yet, but it was there, spinning its slow way toward us, the way it always was.

"And the Scar," Third agreed. "In the dark I cannot tell them apart either. So we are across before the light goes. Which means we begin now, and we do not waste the moving on being afraid. Be afraid while you are standing still. You will have time."

* * *

I will not pretend I can tell it the way it happened, because the way it happened was mostly nothing, for a very long time, and the nothing was the most frightening thing I have ever done.

We went out into the field in a line behind Third, slow, deliberate, threading the gaps between the clumps along a path only he could see. He would walk — six steps, ten — and then his hand would drop, the small flat gesture that meant *stop*, and we would stop, all of us, mid-stride, and stand among the white plinths with our held breath loud in our own ears while somewhere a cloud we maybe hadn't even clocked turned and turned and decided we were furniture. Then his hand would lift, and we would move again. The discipline of it got into my legs as an ache and then as a tremble. You do not know how much your body wants to move until you forbid it to, on open ground, with death hanging at chest height a few paces off and your every nerve screaming that the one correct thing a body can do is *run.*

Roan had it worst. I understood that, watching the back of his neck — that for Roan, who'd spent his whole short life learning that the brave thing and the moving thing were the same thing, this field was a kind of torture, because here the brave thing was to do nothing, perfectly,

while your whole self demanded you act. Once, early, a clump woke a little — not at us, at a hare that broke from the heather and bolted — and the cloud went after the hare in a shrieking rush and caught it and there was a sound I won't describe and then a stillness, and the cloud, unsatisfied, came drifting back toward the nearest other moving thing it had half-noticed, which was us, which was *Roan*, on the end of the line, and I watched every muscle in him lock against the want to bolt, and I watched him win, because Third had stopped beside him and gone utterly still in that way only a thing made of wood can manage, and Roan matched him, breath for unbreath, until the cloud lost the thread of us and rose and turned polite again an arm's length from Roan's face. An arm's length. He told me, after, that he had counted the stones. That there were eleven. That he was going to know how many were in a Grinding Teeth cloud for the rest of his life whether he wanted to or not.

I got the one graze of the crossing, and I got it from being good, not bad — I'd stopped clean on Third's signal, but a clump I hadn't seen drifted across our held line on the wind, just *drifting*, not woken, and one of its slow stones clipped the back of my arm as it passed, a single cold line of pain and a single line of blood, the stone not even interested, just close. I did not make a sound. I was proud of that for about a day. The stone turned on past me and rejoined its clump and hung there, and Third's hand lifted, and we went on.

We came off the field on the far side as the dark edge of the Scar was eating the gold out of the heather behind us, close enough that the last hundred paces had a speed in them Third permitted only because the clumps had thinned. And we stood on firm rising ground with our legs shaking from the held stillness more than the walking, and

behind us the Gnawing Fields went grey and then went dark, a whole quiet field of a god's pulled teeth with its lethal patient clouds turning in it, invisible now, and I thought: people *harvest* that. There is a town that lives on walking out into that and coming back. The world is full of people doing impossible things and calling it a trade.

* * *

It came on us slowly, the way a true horizon does — not a thing you turn and see, but a thing that is gradually more there each time you look up, until you understand it has been resolving in front of you for some while and you only now have the eyes to admit it.

It started as a darker line under the rimward sky, where the failing light went and did not come back, and I took it, the first while, for the dark simply being thicker over there. Then the line had a top edge to it, level and certain, and I thought, weather again, the flat grey kind. Then, as we walked and the light raked along it low, the top edge stayed put and the bottom of it lifted clear of the country, and I understood I was looking at a cliff — a wall of pale grey stone standing sheer out of the land, running off both ways past where the light would let me follow, and so high that I had to tip my head to find the top of it, and tipping my head was when it stopped being scenery and started being a fact about the world I now had to live inside.

And out from the foot of it, leaning into the last of the light, were the sheets.

That was the shape of them. Not spires, not splinters — *sheets.* Slabs of the same pale stone as the cliff, broad and flat and thin for their size, peeling away from the cliff-face and canted over at angles, the way the pages of a great book fall open and lean away from the spine when you crack the cover and lay it down — that, exactly that, a

hardcover the size of a country laid open on its back, the cliff its standing spine and the slabs its falling pages, except the pages were each as tall as the causeway was long and there were hundreds of them, near the face crowded close and upright, further out leaning further, further still lying fallen flat in the grass, a whole vast splayed book of stone with its leaves canted every way across the country at the foot of the wall.

"That's it," I said. Not a question. I'd learned, by then, to stop making them questions. "That's where he's going. The last one."

"That is where he is going," Third said. The coal of his eye was steady on the far pale slabs, and his voice had the flatness it got when he was looking at a thing he had already decided to walk into. "And we are going to be standing in it when he arrives."

Behind us the teeth of one dead god did not go dark with the rest of the field. They came up pale instead. Every plinth we'd threaded past wore a fur of chalky moss I hadn't marked in the daylight, and as the light failed the moss began to glow — a soft dead-white light, plinth after plinth of it, until the whole field we'd just crossed lay behind us glowing like a market of grave-candles nobody had lit. It was beautiful. I've given up apologising for the number of terrible places in this account that were also beautiful; the country never seemed to feel the two were in any tension, and had stopped waiting for me to catch up. Mathen named it — bone moss, that grew on nothing but the bone of the old dead and lit up like that every night, so the field-foragers could spot a fresh fall from a mile off. You could chew it for a hurt, he said; it numbed a wound better than anything short of a Mender. And you could always tell the ones who'd worked the Fields too long by their teeth, which it stained a permanent grey. He said it lightly, the

way he said most things. I looked back at a field of a dead god's teeth furred in a moss that numbed you and marked you, glowing softly in the dark, and thought: not a garden. Whatever else this was, I had to stop expecting it to turn into a garden.

Ahead of us the great book of stone leaned open in the last of the light, page on canted page. And somewhere between the two, four of us stood on the shaking ground and looked at the place all the lines had been pointing since a town we never saw died with its lockbox open, and none of us said the obvious thing, which was that we had finally nearly arrived, and that arriving had never once, on this whole road, turned out to be the good part.

* * *

Twenty Five

We reached the foot of it the next light, having crossed first a ring of fern and grey moss that softened the country as we came in — almost kind, almost a garden.

It was in that almost-garden that I saw the willows. A whole grove of them, pale-barked and drooping, lovely the way green growth is lovely after a hard country — except that they weren't green. Not one leaf of them. Every tree in the grove had gone a flat, dead, matte grey, crown to root, as though the colour had been lifted out of them in the night and never given back, and they hung over the path utterly still, a grove of grey ghosts that had every other sign of being alive. I slowed. I couldn't help it. "Greywillow," Mathen said, and for once there was none of the performer in it. "They go like that near a thin place — the colour drains out of them when the grey's awake close by. My gran's country had a stand of them, and you did not build downwind of it, and you did not ask why, you just didn't." He looked up the path toward the cliff. "Folk leave the old groves alone. Never knew there was one out here." Third said nothing at all, which by then I'd learned to hear as the loudest thing in the company — Third, who named everything, walking under a grove gone grey because the world was thin here, and not troubling to give us a single fact about it, because the trees had already said the only fact that mattered. We went up between them. Not one leaf moved. And I understood, before Third said a word of it that night, that we'd come to the place where the grey pressed so close it had reached up out of the ground and

pulled the colour out of living wood — just to show us it could.

Nearer, the almost-garden gave out to bare rock again, swept clean, as though the slabs did not permit much to grow within reach of them. And then we were in among them, and there is no part of me that was ready for being in among them.

Up close the open book was not a picture anymore. It was a place, and the place had a ceiling. Each slab went up past anything I had a feel for — the causeway laid on its end, and then more — pale grey, broad and flat and thin for its size the way a page is thin, and they leaned. Near the cliff they stood near-upright and crowded close, so that walking in among them was walking into a narrowing dark, slab-faces rising sheer on both sides with a ribbon of Scar-light far up at the top; and the further out you went the further they leaned, and the further apart they stood, until at the rim of the field they lay flat and fallen in the moss, whole toppled pages the length of a village street, with grass growing along their upper edges.

"They fall away from the wall," Third said, low — the slabs took your voice the way the fields had, and worse. "Always away. Never toward it. A new one stands up at the face; the old ones lean out, over a long time, and at the end they go over, out there, at the rim." He put a wooden hand flat against the nearest upright slab, almost gentle. "It is a slow thing. You will not see it happen."

"How slow," Roan said.

"That," said Third, "is the difficulty."

* * *

We learned the difficulty the way you learn most true things, which is by not believing them first.

Mathen, who had a mapmaker's habit in him along with all the others, took a stick of char and a scrap of hide and began, as we picked our way in, to set down the slabs we passed — this one tall and leaning spinward, this gap, this fallen one we climbed over, three close-set ones like a splayed hand — building us a way back out, because getting lost in there was a thing your body understood as a danger before your head caught up. It was good work. He was good at it. We went in perhaps three hundred paces, found a fallen slab that made a kind of sheltered angle against an upright one, agreed it would do to leave the packs, and turned to go back out by Mathen's map.

The map was wrong.

Not smudged. Not mistaken. Wrong, the way a room is wrong when you come back and a chair has moved — the splayed hand of three was a splayed hand of two, and there was a new one, tall and pale and upright, standing in a spot Mathen swore on his mother had been open grass when we passed it, and the fallen slab we'd climbed was still fallen but it was *facing the other way*. Mathen stood with his good map in his hand and his mouth open, and turned it over, and turned it back, and Third said, into the quiet:

"Do not trust it. You cannot map this place. I should have said so sooner; I had hoped to let you find a thing to do with your hands." He looked up the narrowing dark toward the unseen cliff. "It moves. Not while you watch — never while you watch, that is the whole cruelty of it — but the moment a place is behind you, or your eyes are shut, or you have only looked away to speak to the person beside you, it remakes itself. A new page at the spine. An old one over at the rim. And everything between, shuffled, by a hand you will never catch at it." A pause. "It has been doing this since before there were eyes here to be fooled. It never grows larger. It never wears down. There are exactly as

many slabs in this field today as there were when the Titan dropped the book, and not one of them is where it was."

I looked at the slab beside me — tall, leaning, a crack running up its face like a seam — and I did the thing he'd told us was useless, I *stared* at it, I tried to catch it, I held it with my eyes and dared it to so much as breathe. It didn't. Of course it didn't. And the not-moving, while I watched, was somehow more frightening than if it had lunged, because I understood that the stillness was a courtesy it extended to my attention, and the instant I spent my attention elsewhere the courtesy was withdrawn.

Then, somewhere off in the field, there was a crack like thunder on a clear day — I jumped, we all jumped — and Third said, without turning, "A new one, at the face. Stood up just now." And a while later, far out at the rim behind us, a softer sound, a *pop*, and then a long grinding crash that went on too long and shook the ground through the soles of my boots. "And an old one down, at the edge. The book turned a page." He said it the way you'd report the time. "We are camping at the rim tonight, on the fallen ones, in the open, where nothing stands tall enough to come down on us. Not in here. Things have built homes in here, or on the slabs. They are not here anymore, and neither are the homes."

* * *

We made camp the way he said, out on the toppled slabs at the field's edge, a flat pale floor under us the size of a market square that had been, until some unwitnessed night, a standing page of stone a hundred men high. Mathen got a fire going in the lee of a fallen edge and was quiet over it, which was its own kind of alarm; the absence of Mathen's noise told you more about a situation than most men's shouting. Roan kept looking back into the field,

into the narrowing dark of the upright slabs, the way you look at a thing you've decided not to turn your back on, which in there was a doomed ambition.

I went and found Third at the edge of the firelight, where he had taken up the watch he didn't need to be told to take.

"So," I said. "We're here." I had stopped, by then, dressing my hard questions up as easy ones. "We can't fight him — the tor showed us that, you can't fight a thing that steps out of the world. We can't map the ground; the ground won't hold still long enough to plan on. He's coming to take the last one, the big one, and it's somewhere up against that cliff, and we're going to be standing in it when he arrives." I looked at the side of his ruined patient face. "Standing in it doing *what,* Third? What's the plan? Because I've followed you a long way now, and I've watched you know things, and I need you to know this one."

He was quiet for a long time. Long enough that the fear had room to grow in it.

"I do not know," Third said.

The fire ticked.

"I have turned it every way I have," he went on, and there was that missing thing in his voice again, the certainty gone out of it, the way it had gone on the tor. "There is no maneuver. You have seen what he is. I cannot stop him taking the thing by standing where the thing is; he will simply be on the other side of me. I cannot kill what I cannot touch. I cannot out-wait a man who does not seem to age and runs on lights like mine. I have no plan, Tasha, of the kind you mean — the kind with steps in it, where you do this and then that and then it is won." The coal of his eye settled on the dark mass of the cliff. "I have only this.

That for reasons I do not understand, of everything in the world he might have looked at on that tor, he looked at *me.* That he half-knew me. That a thing this old and this careful does not waste a glance, and he spent one on me, and his mouth moved." A pause. "Whatever this is, I am part of it. Not a sword that happens to be nearby. Part of it. The shape of it has a place in it that is shaped like me. I do not know what the place is for. But I know that if I am not standing in it when he comes, then I have left the one piece of this that might matter sitting back at an inn, being bored." The eye came to me, and there was something in it that was almost an apology. "That is the whole of my plan. To be the piece of it that is shaped like me, in the place where it happens, and to find out what I am for when I find out. It is the thinnest thing I have ever asked anyone to stand on. You may say so."

"It's the thinnest thing you've ever asked anyone to stand on," I said.

"Yes."

"I'm still here."

"I know," he said. "That is the part I cannot make sense of either, and have stopped trying."

* * *

He left me at the fire and walked out a little way onto the flat fallen page, alone, into the dark past the light, and I knew the shape of it by now — that he was going to step beside the world — out of it and into the grey — the way you'd walk out into a storm to feel which way it drove, instead of watching it come from a dry window. I had learned not to follow with anything but my eyes, and there was a point each time past which even my eyes lost him: the dark would close over the place he'd stood, and I would sit, and wait for it to give him back. He was gone longer

than the carts. Longer than the boundary stone. And when he came back into the firelight he came wrong — not lessened in the grieving way, the lowest-ember way, but *unsteady,* the way you'd come back from a deck in a swell, one hoof set down and tested before the next, his eye flaring and guttering like a flame in a draft that couldn't find its level.

"Third?" Mathen was up. Roan was up.

"The grey is wrong here." He said it quietly and it landed like the grinding crash had. "It is always still. In all the time I have known it — empty, patient, still. Here it is — moving. Churned. There are currents in it I have never felt, all of them running the one way, toward the cliff, the way water runs toward a hole in the bottom of a bucket." He steadied himself against the fallen edge. "Something is draining the grey, here, into that wall. Or out of that wall, into the grey. I could not tell which, and I did not stay to learn, because the longer I stood in it the harder it pulled, and I am not certain — " the ember flickered — "I am not certain that if I had stayed much longer I would have been able to step back out."

Nobody said anything. The fire ticked. Out in the dark field, unwitnessed, a page of the great book turned itself over with a crack like thunder, and none of us so much as flinched at it now, because it had stopped being the frightening thing in the night.

"Then we don't sleep alone," Mathen said at last, practical, gathering us with it. "Watches in pairs. Eyes on the field and eyes on him." He looked at Third, gently. "Especially him."

And that was how we came to wait, the four of us, at the rim of a thing that rearranged itself in the dark, under a sky with a wound turning in it, on the thinnest plan a very old creature had ever asked anyone to stand on, for a man

who could walk out of the world — while behind the cliff that held the last peg in creation, the grey itself had begun, quietly, to pour toward the place where it would end.

* * *

Twenty Six

We kept the watches in pairs, the way Mathen said, and I made myself Third's pair before anyone could think too hard about who'd draw the short straw of sitting up beside the one who didn't sleep. It wasn't bravery. I want that on the record. It was that I'd seen him come back off the flat slab unsteady, testing each hoof like a man on a deck, and I had decided — somewhere I hadn't asked permission of — that I was not going to let him do whatever he was about to do with nobody watching but the stones.

So Roan and Mathen took the first half, back to back on the fallen page with the fire between them and the field, and when the Scar swung its dark edge up over us and the cold came down, they woke us, and Mathen put a hand on my shoulder in passing and said nothing, which from Mathen was a whole speech, and then it was me and Third and the fire and the rearranging dark.

For a while we just kept it. The field did its work out there in the black — a crack like thunder, far off; a long grinding fall, further; the book turning its pages where no eye could hold them still. I'd stopped flinching. You'd be amazed what you stop flinching at.

"You're going to go across again," I said, eventually. It wasn't a question. None of mine were, anymore.

"I must." The coal of his eye was on the cliff, that black mass blacker than the dark around it. "He is coming. I do not know when. But the grey will know before the world does — it always knows the weather of a thing before the

thing arrives — and I would rather meet him understanding something than meet him understanding nothing." A pause. "It is dangerous, here, to cross. You saw. It pulls. I told you it pulled."

"You told me you weren't sure you could've got back."

"I was not. I am still not." He turned the eye on me, and there was a request in it he plainly hated to make, because Third hated needing things, it was the most stubborn fact about him after the not-dying. "Which is why I am going to ask you for something I do not know how to ask for gracefully. I will not go all the way across tonight — going all the way across, out there, is how I nearly did not come back. I will hold at the edge of it, a foot in each, and reach. But the reaching is its own danger, and I need a thing to hold to on this side. A line back. The grey is quiet and it is patient and tonight it is *pulling,* and the danger is not that something in it hurts me. The danger is that it becomes easier to stay than to come back, and I stop wanting the coming back, and there is no edge to tell me I have waited too long." The fire ticked. "You are loud, Tasha. In the lived world. You have always been the loudest thing in any quiet I have stood in. I would like, if you are willing, to hold to that. To you. Talking. So that there is a thing on this side worth the difficulty of returning to."

I did not trust my voice for a second. Then I said, "You want me to nag you back from the dead."

"Essentially."

"Third, I have been told my whole life that's my worst quality. You're saying it's a rescue technique."

"I am saying," he said, with enormous gravity, "that tonight it may be the most useful thing in the world, and I would take it as a kindness if you did not stop, no matter how little I appear to be listening, and that if I tell you to

stop, you must understand that the part of me asking you to stop is the part you are saving me from." The eye held me. "Will you."

"Yeah," I said. "Talk you back. I can do that. I'm good at that."

"I know," he said. "Begin when I close the eye. Do not stop until I open it."

* * *

And then he set himself against it — not leaving, though leaving was the word that came; more the way a swimmer sets against a current that wants him, half his weight going out of the lived world and the other half digging in to stay — the eye dimming down not to the grieving coal but to almost-out, the last red wire of it, the wooden shape of him gone rigid with the work of being in two places and surrendering to neither. And I started talking.

I don't remember the half of what I said. That's the truth of it. You don't, after; it isn't speech you're making, it's rope. I talked about the inn. I talked about Tondi and her water cup and the way she never touched a coin, and the stupid sign that said *Only*, and Klar's first attempt at Shredder stew that he'd been so proud of, and the way the militia drank their courage before patrol and Roan was the one who didn't, and the smell of the place in the morning before the stew went on. I talked about my father telling me never to let them see my fear. I talked about the road, every dull stretch of it, the bog and the blizzard and the field of stinging glass, all the things that had nearly killed us made small and ours and *survived,* because that was the point, I understood that even while I was doing it — I wasn't telling him true things, I was telling him *ongoing* things, things with more of them still to come, a world that was not finished and therefore worth the difficulty of

returning to.

His eye stayed almost-out. The cold got worse. Out in the field the great book turned a page with a crack that I felt in the fallen slab under me, and I did not stop talking. A while into it — I don't know how long, time goes strange when you're being a rope — the red wire of his eye began, very slightly, to *drift,* the way a moored boat drifts when the line goes slack, his whole still shape leaning a hair toward the cliff, toward the black mass and the pull behind it, and something in me that wasn't thinking said his name instead of all the other words, just his name, *Third, Third, you've got stew to complain about, Third, I'm not done telling you about the sign* — and the drift stopped. Held. Hung there at the end of the slack line that was apparently my idiot voice. And then, slowly, came back.

The eye came up. Not all the way. But up, and toward me, and the rest of him came back into one place, the hoof testing the slab, the deck-in-a-swell carefulness, and I shut up at last because he'd opened the eye and that was the deal, and I was shaking, and I hadn't noticed I'd taken hold of his wooden forearm with both hands at some point and was gripping it like the rail of a thing going down.

"You came back," I said.

"You were very loud," he said. "It was very difficult to stay." And then, lower, the nearest thing to *thank you* his pride would let out the door: "I heard the part about the sign. It is a good detail. The crafter illustrated the only building in town." A breath of the bellows, the one I'd allow him. "I held to that. The absurdity of it. A world that makes a sign like that is a world with more in it. You were right to choose it."

* * *

I let him sit a while before I asked. I'd earned the asking and he knew it, but I let him sit.

"What did you see."

The eye went to the cliff again, but it didn't drift this time; he had it on a short line now, the both of us did.

"It is worse than I said, and simpler. The grey is always empty, Tasha. In all the time I have known it — and that is the whole of my time — it has been a still grey nothing with the lived world showing through it like a drowned town through ice. Patient. Untenanted." The wire of his eye flickered. "It is not empty here. It is *draining* — all of it, the whole patient nothing, pouring slow toward that cliff the way a flood finds the one crack in a wall — and it is carrying things with it. Shapes. Far off, and dim, and being drawn the way I was being drawn, toward the wall, toward whatever is behind the wall that has begun, already, before he has even arrived, to pull the world apart at its last pin." He stopped.

"And," I said, because there was an *and,* I could hear the shape of the held-back thing.

"And one of them turned." Very quiet. "Out of all that dim drifting cargo of the grey, one shape, far off, in the churn — it stopped being carried, and it turned, against the current, the way a thing turns when it has noticed it is being looked at. Toward me. And I do not know what it was." The eye came to me, and the not-knowing in it was the worst thing I had seen in his face on the whole road, worse than the lowest coal. "I have spent tonight telling myself it was the man from the tor, come early through the grey, because that would at least be a thing I could name. But I am not certain. It was too far, and there was something in the *way* of it that was older than him, older than me, and it knew me, Tasha, the way the man on the tor knew me, that half-knowing, that

hearing-a-childhood-tune — except this was not half. This one knew me entirely. And I have never in three hundred thousand spins been known entirely by anything, and I find I did not like how much I wanted to go to it." The bellows, again, ragged. "That is why I needed the rope. Not the pull of the grey. The pull of being known. I would have gone to it. You stopped me going to it."

I kept hold of his forearm. The fire had burned down and neither of us fed it.

"Then I'll keep the rope," I said. "However many nights it takes. You don't look into that thing without me on the other end of you. That's the deal now. You don't get to be known to death by something in the dark while I'm asleep ten feet away."

He looked at me for a long moment, the eye steadying toward something like its proper light.

"That is a great deal to take on," he said, "for a girl who followed me out of an inn because she was bored."

"Yeah, well." I looked out at the rearranging dark, the field that wouldn't hold still, the cliff that was quietly drinking the grey and everything in it. "I'm not bored now."

We kept the watch. Out past the firelight the book turned its pages where we couldn't see, and far behind the cliff the grey poured toward its ending, carrying its dim cargo of shapes, one of which had turned to look at a thing made of wood and known it entirely — and on the lived side of it all, a girl held a construct's forearm with both hands and talked, every time the eye began to drift, about a sign that said *Only*, and a stew nobody should have been proud of, and all the small unfinished things that are, when you are trying to keep someone in the world, the whole and only argument for staying in it.

* * *

Twenty Seven

The second night of the waiting was worse than the first, because on the first night the dread had been a new thing and you can stand almost anything once for its novelty, and on the second night it was just the furniture. The cliff drank the grey. The book turned its pages out in the dark. We sat our paired watches and ate cold and spoke little, and Roan had got to that brittle place a body gets when it has been afraid for longer than it can keep being interestingly afraid, where a person will either find something to do with the fear or start coming apart at a seam.

It was Mathen who saw it, of course, and Mathen who knew the cure, because the cure was the thing Mathen was for.

"Third," he said, into the cold, in the easy way he had of setting a hook so gently you didn't feel it go in. "You owe me a story. I've told every one I have twice over on this road, and you've told us exactly one, and it was a good one, but a man can't live off one. You've had — how long did you say? Don't answer that, it depresses the children. You've had longer than anyone. You must have a hundred you've never told a soul."

"I am not good at it," Third said. "You are good at it. I state things."

"Then state me one." Mathen settled back against the fallen slab, hat down. "You taught me yourself, near enough — no, *I* taught *you*, that's the one, a story's how you make more than one person carry a thing. You've a great

deal you've been carrying alone, master Forged. Set some of it on the fire where the rest of us can warm our hands at it. That's all a story is. Spreading the load."

The coal of Third's eye sat on the fire a while. Then it did a thing I'd not seen it do — it went not to the cliff, not down into him, but somewhere sideways and warm, the look of a person opening a drawer they keep meaning not to.

"I will tell you about Dorn," he said.

I sat up at that. I knew the name. I'd known it since the inn, the corner table, the Boltcaster he carried and never fired — *Dorn's*, he'd said, the way you'd name a grave. I knew the name and the fact of the death and not one thing else about the man, and I found I badly wanted to.

* * *

"Dorn was a fighter," Third said, "the way some are born singers — without effort, and without much sense of it being remarkable, which made him very restful to be near. We travelled together a long while. He hunted things that needed hunting, monsters that were troubling the roads, and he never once did it for the bounty, though he took the bounty, because, he said—" and here Third's flat voice did something almost like an impression, a fond clumsy reaching after another man's warmth — "'because it is the right thing to do, Third. The coin is just the icing on the cake.' I did not know what a cake was. He drew me one. He was not a good artist either, but he was a patient teacher of useless things, which it turns out are the things you miss."

Roan, despite himself, huffed a small laugh. Mathen said nothing, watching Third the way one craftsman watches another work in a difficult medium.

"He told jokes," Third went on. "Badly, mostly. But he had one — one he was known for, that he would tell to anyone who would hold still — and it was, I am told,

genuinely good, though I am the wrong judge of such things. I have remembered it exactly. May I tell it the way he told it."

"Please," said Mathen, and there was no mockery in it at all.

Third set down, deliberately, the thing he'd been holding without my noticing he'd taken it out — the Boltcaster, Dorn's Boltcaster, the squat ugly wooden thing he carried and never loaded — laid it across his knees like a man laying out a friend's coat. And he told the joke.

"A Mender, a Crafter, and a Grask are arguing over whose work matters most. The Mender says, 'Mine — I keep the whole world from coming apart at the seams; were it not for me you would all go about in rags.' The Crafter says, 'Mine — I *make* the world to begin with; were it not for me you would have no seams to come apart, and nothing to go about in, rags or otherwise.' And they argue. Mending against making. Making against mending. The length of a long night, each entirely certain the world would stop turning without him. And at last, having settled nothing, they turn to put it to the third one — the Grask, who has sat the whole time and said not one word. 'And you,' they say. 'What is it that *you* do, that matters?'"

Third paused, exactly the length Dorn must have paused.

"But there is only a hole in the ground, where the Grask had been sitting. And from somewhere beneath their own two feet, a voice says: 'There you are.'"

There was a beat of nothing — and then Roan barked a real laugh, the first true one I'd heard out of him since the tor, the kind that surprises its owner, and Mathen laughed properly, head back, and even I felt the thing crack open in my chest that a good joke cracks, the relief of it, in that

awful place, under that drinking cliff.

"Oh, that's *good,*" Mathen said, wiping his eye. "That's properly good. The two trades so busy being important they don't notice the world's already eating them. Your Dorn had timing, Third, you can hear it even through you, no offence. I'll have to remember that one." He was still smiling. "A Mender, a Crafter, and a Grask. I'll get a tenday's drinks off that, easy."

"He would have liked that you laughed," Third said. "He measured a day by how many he could make laugh. He would have counted tonight a good day, this far from anywhere, with the world the way it is."

And the smile on Mathen's face was the last easy thing about the night, though none of us knew it yet, and the joke about the Grask hung in the cold a moment longer than a joke should, and then the fire popped and we let it go.

* * *

"How did he die," I asked, when the laughing had settled, because I'd learned that the only respect worth giving Third was to ask the real thing.

"In the night," Third said. "The way they do." The fond drawer had closed; the voice was flat again, but it was the flatness I'd learned to hear *under* now, the flatness that was holding something down. "We were camped off the road. Hunting a Subsurface Shredder that had been taking travellers on a stretch outside a village — for the bounty, and because it was the right thing to do; he had me saying it by then. He was asleep. I was keeping the watch; I do not sleep, it should always have meant nothing could come on us unseen." The Boltcaster lay across his knees. "It did not come from where seeing helps. It came from below. A Shredder puts a limb up through the ground before any part of it you could watch for breaks the surface, and the

first I knew of it was the sound, and the sound was already through him. One limb. Through the chest. Before I had finished standing up."

The fire ticked. Nobody moved.

"I killed it," Third said. "That part was not difficult; they are only difficult to the people who cannot see them coming, and I could see it, after. It is a small skill, killing the thing that has already done the thing. I have a great deal of it." The eye stayed on the fire. "He was alive a little while. Long enough to ask me to remember him, which he said would make him immortal, of a sort, and which I did not understand then and am, perhaps, beginning to. I burned what was left, the way you do. I kept the head of the Shredder, to show the village it was ended. And I kept this." His wooden hand settled on the Boltcaster, not gripping, just resting. "It has no rounds in it. I have never fired it. I do not carry it to use. I carry it because he carried it, and a thing a person carried every day for a life holds some of the shape of them, after, if you keep it near. It is not a sensible reason. I have stopped requiring my reasons to be sensible."

"And the Shredders," I said. Quietly. I had a sudden, cold understanding of a thing I'd been told in an inn a road-and-a-lifetime ago and not known the weight of. "You hunt them. Still. You've hunted them this whole time. The one outside my town — Tondi's bounty, the head you brought back — that's why you took it. Not the job. Them."

"Them," Third agreed. "Wherever I hear of one. I do not take payment for those, when I can avoid it; it feels like the wrong kind of icing." A pause, the nearest he came to the thing underneath. "It does not bring him back. I am aware. I am very old and I am aware of exactly how little it does. I do it anyway. It is the one piece of grief I have found that has somewhere useful to go, and I have a great deal of

grief and very little of it goes anywhere useful at all, so I spend that piece where it spends." The eye came up, found me, found Mathen, found Roan. "That is Dorn. That is the story. Thank you for holding still for it. He would have liked you. He liked almost everyone; it was his great flaw as a judge of character and his great gift as a man."

Mathen reached over, after a moment, and put his hand flat on the Boltcaster beside Third's, just for a breath, the way you'd touch a coffin in passing to say you'd known the one inside.

"A Mender, a Crafter, and a Grask," he said softly, to no one, to the dead man. "Aye. I'll remember it."

We kept the rest of the watch in a better silence than the one before — the fire lower, the cliff still drinking, the book still turning its unseen pages — and I lay down when my half came and did not sleep for a long time, thinking about a man I'd never meet who drew cakes for a monster-killing machine because the machine didn't know what a cake was, and about how Third collected us, the warm restful ones, one after another across all that time, and kept our coats and our jokes and our Boltcasters when we were gone, and how the keeping was the whole of what he had, and how I had somewhere along this road become one of the ones he was going to have to keep.

I did not think, then, about the joke. About which of us was the Mender, and which the Crafter, and how the punchline always comes from under your own two feet while you're busy arguing about something else. I wish I could say I had. It would have changed nothing, but I would have had the warning, and I have since come to set a high value on warnings, having been given so few that did any good.

* * *

Twenty Eight

He came to me the next watch with the thing already decided in him. I could tell. After long enough beside a person you learn the difference between the silence of a creature keeping a thing back and the silence of one carrying a thing forward to set down in front of you, and this was the second kind, and it frightened me more than the first ever had, because Third did not set things down lightly. He'd been carrying whatever it was since the night the grey pulled at him, turning it, the way he turned everything, until it was the right shape to hand over.

Mathen and Roan were asleep at the far edge of the firelight. Third sat down beside me — sat, which he did not do, he stood his watches — and laid the Boltcaster across his knees, Dorn's Boltcaster, the way he had at the telling, and I understood I was about to be told something on the same shelf as that, or worse, and I put down the strip of dried fish I'd been pretending to eat.

"I have worked out what I am for," he said. "I would rather you heard it from me, sitting down, tonight, than worked it out yourself in the middle of the thing, when it will matter that you already understood. So I am going to tell you all of it. The part you have been letting lie. And the part I have only just been able to see." The coal of his eye was steady. "It will take a while. Do not say anything kind until I have finished. The kind things are the ones that make me stop."

"All right," I said.

"Her name was Liwon," Third said, and the grey-draining cliff and the rearranging field and the whole waiting world went very far away.

* * *

He told it plainly, which was the only way he had, and the plainness was the worst of it, because there is no flinching in a flat voice for you to flinch along with — you have to do all the flinching yourself.

He told me about a village his own kind had emptied, and a green-skinned infant on its back in the blood, too small to run, and the voice in his head that told him to finish it, and the thing he did instead, which was pick her up. He told me about the spins of learning to keep a small soft thing alive when he had been built to do the opposite — the food, the rivers, the chopping of whole glens to splinters when the voice got loud and the crying got louder and he could fix neither. He told me how she named herself, near enough, out of the only thing he ever called her; he had said *little one* a thousand times because it was the only true thing he had, and she had handed it back to him broken into *Liwon*, and he had liked the broken one better, and that was the first time, he said, that he had wanted a thing to be true over wanting it to be accurate, and he had her to thank for the whole of what he became after.

He told me about the Virek woman who took them in, and the spins of being a gate-warden to a village that had every reason to fear him and slowly, mostly, didn't; about Liwon growing into the people who were her own kind and away from the wooden thing that had carried her, which he said was right, which he said he had been glad of, and I believed about half of the gladness, which I think was all he believed of it himself.

And then he told me about the night the light flickered in the trees and the red veins came up over the world, and the Virek were simply *gone* — and in their place the two peoples you and I have walked among our whole lives, the pale ones and the green-toothed ones, the Kro and the Ork, made in a single instant out of the people who had been there a breath before. He told me it as a thing that had happened to the whole world — the sundering, the un-making of the first people into the two — and as a thing that had happened to one child on one floor, both at once, because they were the same thing, the great history and the small grief, one event wearing two sizes. He found her, he said. Or he found the two girls she had become, dying, one pale and one green, on the floor and beyond the window. And one of them, with the last of her, made a sound he knew. *Bada.* The thing she'd said when she was frightened, when she was small, when she wanted the wooden thing to come.

"And that," Third said, "is the someone. That is the her. You asked, on a different watch, and I gave you the one word, and you were kind enough not to take the rest. I am giving you the rest now, because you are going to need it. Not to grieve with me. I am not telling you so that you will grieve with me." The eye came round. "I am telling you so that you will know exactly what it is, when the time comes, that you are going to have to refuse to let me have."

I didn't understand yet. I almost did. I sat very still and let him bring it the rest of the way.

* * *

"The thing in the grey," he said. "The one that turned, on the watch. That knew me entirely. I told you I did not know what it was, and that was true when I said it. I know now." The Boltcaster sat under his stilled hands. "It is the one

that made me. I have heard it twice before — once when the last of them fell and it looked at me and *smiled,* before it came apart into the dust that woke me; and once on the floor of that village, over Liwon, when it told me her dying was a seed, that it must go into the ground to become something better, that the loss was a kindness I did not yet have the wisdom to see. The same voice. Patient. Gentle. It has always been gentle with me, Tasha. I took it, all this time, for the carelessness of a vast thing toward a small one. I had it backwards. It was not careless of me. It was *courting* me. It has been courting me since before there were towns."

"Courting you to do what," I said, though the cold coming up my spine had already half-answered it.

"To come home. To stop." The eye dimmed, not to grief — to something more frightening, a kind of longing held at arm's length. "I am a made thing, woken by its own essence. I can walk the grey, which nothing else of this world can do — nothing but the man on the tor, who is its hand, who has spent these spins gathering the pins that hold the world pegged to its place. I run on its blood. I am, Tasha — I have been trying to find a gentler word and there is not one — I am the *door.* The last thing it needs to come back through is a thing that belongs to both sides at once and will *open.* The pins are nearly all pulled. The grey is draining toward the last of them, behind that cliff. And the door is sitting on a fallen slab telling a girl who serves stew that he has finally understood what he is for, and what he is for is to *want to go.*"

The fire ticked. Out in the dark a page of the book turned over with a crack, and for once I'd have welcomed any noise that wasn't his voice.

"It cannot take me," he said. "That is the one mercy in the shape of it. It needs the door opened from the inside. It

needs me *willing.* And so it will not seize me — it will *offer.* It will offer me the thing it has been saving the whole of my life to offer, the thing it showed me a corner of on the watch and I nearly walked into the grey to reach." His hand turned over, the old tell, closing and opening on nothing. "The grey keeps the warm part, Tasha. I have told you that. The warm part, before the end. It will offer me *all of them.* Not a visit. Not a corner I climb back out of lessened. It will offer me Liwon — and Dorn, and Adura, and the woman in the snow who told me to go on living — kept, whole, in the warm, forever, on the only condition that I stop holding the door shut. That I come home and be known and never be alone again and have every single one of them back." The coal guttered. "And in time, it will be able to offer me you."

* * *

I had thought, when I started down this road out of an inn because I was bored, that the worst thing that could happen to me was dying on it. I want to put on the record that I was a child when I thought that, whatever my age, and that I stopped being one somewhere in the next little while, sitting on a fallen page of stone listening to the kindest creature I have ever known explain to me that he was going to be offered his murdered daughter back and that I was the thing that had to say no.

"You can't refuse it," I said. My voice did something I wasn't proud of. "If it offers you that. Third. Nobody could refuse that. *I* couldn't refuse that, and I've known her for the length of one conversation."

"I know." He said it without any drama at all, which was how I knew it was the truest thing he'd said. "That is the difficulty. The woman in the snow — Lujian — gave me the only answer I have, long ago, for exactly this, though neither of us knew it was for this. She said the loss was

hers. Liwon's. That it was not a seed and not a kindness and not for anything, that it was a person, and that the only way left to call it what it was, was to refuse to let it be made into a meaning. To go on. That stopping agreed with the liar." The eye came up, and there was something in it I had no name for, something older than the road. "If I take the offer, Liwon's death becomes the seed the Titan always said it was. The thing that softened me, and emptied me, and made me lonely enough to come home. Every death it ever arranged or allowed becomes a step on the path to opening the door. I would be agreeing, at the last, that the liar was right. I will not do that. I have decided. I am telling you on the night I have decided it, while I can still mean it cleanly."

"Then what do you need me for," I said, and I already knew, and I needed him to say it anyway.

"Because deciding it tonight is not the same as holding it then." For the first time the flat voice cracked, one hairline, and set again. "Because there will be a moment — at the cliff, in the thick of it, with the warm part open in front of me and her *in* it — when every part of me that is worth anything will want to go, and will believe, with total conviction, that going is right, that it is even good, that it is the loving thing, and I will turn to you, Tasha, and I will ask you with everything I have to let me go to her." The Boltcaster trembled, faintly, under his hand. "And you must not. That is the whole of it. That is what I am for and that is what *you* are for, the two of us, at the end of this road. I am telling you now, with the clean version of myself, so that you will know to distrust the other one. When I beg you — and I will beg you — you are to believe *this* me. Not that one. The me that is asking you, now, calmly, to refuse the me that will be on his knees. Can you —" "Yes," I said. I didn't let him finish it. I couldn't have stood the shape of

the whole question in the air. "Yes. I'll hold the rope. I'll say no. I'll be the worst thing that ever happened to you, right at the end, and I'll do it on purpose, and I'll hate it more than anything I've ever done." I was crying by then, which I'd sworn at the inn I would never do in front of any of them, my father's voice in my head the whole time, *never let them see.* I let him see. "But you have to know what you're asking. You're asking me to look at you wanting her — *her,* Third, your little one — and tell you no. You're asking me to be the reason you don't get her back."

"Yes," Third said.

"That's the cruellest thing anyone has ever asked me."

"Yes," he said again. "I am sorry. There is no one else. You are the loudest thing in any quiet I have ever stood in, and you are the only one who has ever held me to the world hard enough to bring me back across it, and I would not ask it of you if the world did not, regrettably, depend on a girl who served stew being willing to break my heart at precisely the right moment." The eye found mine, steady now, the longing folded back away behind it. "I have great confidence in you. It is the only confidence I have left that is not also a fear."

We sat there a long time, on the fallen page, with the cliff drinking the grey and the dead held warm behind it and the whole impossible weight of what I now knew sitting in my lap like a stone, and I did not let go of his forearm, and he did not ask me to, and neither of us said anything else kind, because the kind things were the ones that made him stop, and I had finally, fully, terribly understood that stopping was the one thing in all the world I was now sworn to never, ever let him do.

That was the night I knew. All of it. The shape and the centre both.

I have not been bored since. I would give a great deal, now, to be bored again.

* * *

Twenty Nine

The last ordinary thing Mathen ever did was complain about the cold.

We had three nights of waiting in us by then, and the third had brought a chill up off the bare rock that even the fire couldn't argue with, and Mathen sat working feeling back into his hands and delivering, to no one, a long and structured grievance against the entire concept of weather that stands still. "A storm that *moves,*" he was saying, "I can respect. A storm that moves has somewhere to be. This—" he gestured at the cold, the dark, the cliff, all of it — "this is just a thing that has decided to sit on us out of spite, and I have decided, in return, to take it personally." Roan was almost smiling. That was the gift of Mathen, even then, even there: he could get a boy who'd been afraid for three nights to almost smile, by being theatrically furious at the temperature. He looked over at me to see if I'd liked the bit. I had. I'd liked all his bits. I gave him the small nod that meant *that one landed,* and he looked pleased, and that is the last face I have of him that is whole.

Because that was when the whispering started, and we all made the same mistake at the same time.

We thought it was the grey.

It came up under the wind, under the fire-crackle — a thin braided murmur with no source, words in no language at the edge of hearing, and every one of us turned the same way: toward the cliff. Of course toward the cliff. We had spent three nights learning that the cliff was where the

wrong came from, the grey draining into it, the thing that knew Third, the whole vast danger we had walked across the world to stand in front of. So when the world began to whisper, we faced the danger we knew, all four of us, and we braced for the thing we were expecting.

And the ground came up behind us.

* * *

I have tried to set the next part down a dozen ways and they are all too slow. It was not slow. It was the fastest thing I have ever lived through and it is the one I can least bear to make quick.

The rock under the fallen slab heaved and split, and the thing came up out of it the way a fist comes up through paper — long, pale, wet, a body like an enormous worm with hands, actual hands, too many of them, sprouting from it at wrong intervals on long clawed arms, and it came up *between* us, into the middle of our braced and facing-the-wrong-way little circle.

And the whispering, which I had taken for the grey, came down on us all at once and *held* us.

I have to tell this part with care, because the way it is always told — in the joke, in the story, in every fireside Grask anyone ever laughed at — leaves out the thing that mattered, and the leaving-out is the whole reason we were no use. In Dorn's joke a Grask was a punchline. It burrowed and it waited and it ate the clever people while they argued and it said its line. A thing you could laugh at, a little, around a fire. The joke never once mentioned the whispering. The joke never said that when a Grask decides on you it puts a sound inside your skull that unstitches you from your own body — that you stand there with every muscle you own handed over to some other keeping, your mind shrieking the orders your training carved into your

spine, and your spine simply does not answer. The joke left that out. I have since worked out why the joke leaves it out, and it is the worst thing I know about stories: the people who learn that part do not come back to put it in.

Mathen was the best blade among us. I want that on the record beside everything else. On any other ground, with half a breath of warning, Mathen would have taken that thing apart and made it look easy and told us about it for a tenday. He had no breath of warning and, in the end, he had no body to do it with, because the whispering had him the way it had all of us — frozen, aware, screaming inside a statue. I know he was screaming inside his, because I was screaming inside mine, and our eyes could still move, and his found mine, and I watched a master swordsman understand, in perfect stillness, that the one thing he was for was not going to be permitted to happen.

All of us but Third.

I don't know why the sound didn't take him. I have wondered since whether there is simply nothing in him for it to unstitch — that whatever a Grask reaches for in a mind, Third's is built of other stuff, the Titan's stuff, wrong for the hook, so that the whisper went through him and found no seam to catch. He was not frozen. He was already moving, the instant the rock broke, the way he was always already moving.

He was one step too far away.

That is the whole of it. That is the sentence I have had to live inside since. One step — the thing came up *between* us and Mathen was on its side of the gap and Third was on ours, and a Grask does not spend the breath a step would cost. Its front split open, four jaws peeling back like the petals of something obscene, and in the wet centre of them a pair of eyes, and they found Mathen, frozen, and the whispering drew itself into one clear sentence, almost

gentle, in a voice like wet gravel:

"*Found you.*"

Not the line. Even then — even frozen, even with the world ending a step away — my idiot filing mind caught it and would not let it go: *that is not the line.* The joke said *there you are,* light, almost a greeting, the sort of thing you'd say glad to a friend across a room. This said *found you,* flat and final, the way you'd say it of a thing that had always been yours and had only briefly been mislaid. The joke had got even that wrong. The joke had made it almost warm. There was nothing warm in it, and I understood in that frozen breath that every Grask anyone had ever laughed at had said this colder truer thing to someone who never lived to correct the joke, and that we had walked into this one armoured in a story that had lied to us about its teeth.

Then Third reached them, one step too late, and the world started again all at once.

The arms had Mathen — round the chest, dragging him toward the jaws and beginning to pull him *down,* toward the broken ground, toward the burrow — and the freezing broke as the thing's attention bent wholly to its prize, and Roan got Mathen's name out in a tearing shout, and I got my own body back and it was no use to anyone, and Mathen — with a Grask's claws in him and the dark coming up to take him — *laughed.* A short, wet, astonished laugh, the laugh of a man who has just watched a joke he told come true in the worst possible way, and he got it out, around the blood, looking not at the thing that was killing him but at us, at me—

"—*told you* it was a good one—"

And then Third was on it.

* * *

He did not fight it. Fighting is what you do to a thing that might win. Third arrived at the Grask the way the Scar arrives at the day — completely, without hurry, without doubt — and the Falkas came out and the wrong-jointed arms came off, one, two, the hands still clutching as they fell, and the thing made a sound I will not try to spell, and tried to do the one clever thing it knew, tried to drop back into its hole and take what it had, and Third put himself between it and the ground. He would not let it burrow. He would not let it take Mathen down into the dark where even he could not follow. He cut it off from the earth and then he cut it apart, methodically, the way he cut back the flora at the geysers — the same way he did every necessary terrible thing — until the four jaws stopped working and the eyes in the wet of them went flat and the long pale body slumped down half in and half out of its own ruined hole, and the whispering stopped, and the only sound on that whole rearranging plain was Roan saying *no, no, no,* very fast and very quietly, over Mathen.

Third turned from the dead thing to the dying man and I watched something happen in him that I have no good word for. He knelt. He, who knelt to nothing. And he gathered Mathen up out of the bloodied moss the way I had seen him, in my mind's eye only, gather up a green-skinned infant from another field of the wrongly dead, and he held him, and the rest of us came down around them in the cold.

"Mathen," Third said.

"Don't," Mathen got out. He was going. We all knew the look by now; the road had taught us that look. "Don't do the — flat thing. The stating-facts thing. Not for this." A breath that didn't go all the way in. "Make it a *story.* Promise me you'll — you'll make it a story, not a — not a list of what the thing did to me. Tell it so they laugh at the start." His hand found Third's wooden forearm, the one that held him. "A

Mender, a Crafter, and a *Grask.* Eh? You've got the — you've got the ending now. Free of charge."

"I have it," Third said. The avalanche of his voice had gone to almost nothing. "I will tell it well. I will learn to tell it well, the way you would have."

"Spread the weight," Mathen said. It was nearly the last of it. His eyes went, with effort, from Third to me, and stopped on me, and there was something in them he was trying to hand over, the way you hand over a watch. "She knows how. Taught her m'self." The ghost of the grin. "Stronger in the — back. Told you." And then, to Third, fading, the thing I did not understand was a gift until much later, until the cliff, until everything: "Don't you stop, you old — you keep *going.* Whatever's coming. You keep — you go *on.* That's the whole — that's the whole trick of it. You just—"

He didn't finish the sentence. I have spent a long time deciding how it ended, and I have settled, for my own sake, on *you just go on,* because it was the thing he'd have said, and because it was, though he never knew it, the exact armour a dead woman in the snow had once handed Third for exactly this, given again now by a dying man who only meant be brave, be kind, don't let the road harden you — and who could not have known he was loading the one weapon his friend was going to need against the offer of getting him, and all the rest of them, back.

* * *

We burned him at the rim, on a fallen page of the great book, the way Mathen had once told me he'd want if it came to it — "somewhere with a view, and don't any of you dare be solemn about it, I'll know." We tried not to be solemn. We were terrible at it. Roan said three words and couldn't do the rest. I did a little better and hated every

steady syllable. Third spoke last, and he did not state facts; he told a small story, badly, about a man who cooked well and complained beautifully and could make a frightened boy almost smile on the worst night of his life, and it was the first story Third ever told without being asked, and Mathen would have given him notes, and that is the kindest thing I can think to say about it.

And when it was done, and the others had gone to the fire, I stood a moment longer by the embers with Third, and I felt the new thing settle on me, the thing I had not had room to feel until the burning was over — that Mathen was in the grey now. That the warm part had him. That somewhere behind that drinking cliff the thing that wanted Third to come home had just been handed one more reason, one more face, one more voice that could be offered back, *whole, in the warm, forever, if you only stop holding the door.* The world had not taken Mathen from Third. It had taken Mathen and *given him to the enemy,* to hold up at the end like bait.

I did not say it. Third knew it. I could see he knew it, the coal of his eye on the embers, doing the arithmetic of his own grief and finding, at the bottom of it, the trap.

"Three of us now," he said at last.

"Three of us now," I said. And I took hold of his forearm, where Mathen's hand had been, and I did not let go, because I had a job now, the cruellest job in the world, and it had just gotten one face harder to do.

◆ ◆ ◆

Thirty

He should not have gone in. He knew it the way he knew the weather of a blade coming — knew it before his hoof left the lived ground — and he went in anyway, because the alternative was to stand at the embers of his friend and not know whether the friend was anywhere at all, and that was a thing his three hundred thousand spins had not taught him how to bear.

Tasha had her hand on his forearm. He had told her he meant only to look, which was the first lie he had told her since the carts, and he suspected she knew it was one, because her grip was harder than looking warranted and her voice had already started — low, steady, the rope paying out before he'd even stepped — *I'm here, I've got you, you come back when I call, you hear me, you old fool, you come back.* He held the sound of her the way you hold a guide-rope in fog. Then he stepped beside the world, and the lived sound of her thinned to a thread, and the grey took him.

It was wrong, the way it had been wrong on the watch — churned, currented, the whole patient nothing sliding one way, toward the cliff, toward the drain behind it — but he had expected the wrongness and braced against it, leaning his will upcurrent like a man wading. What he had not braced against, what no bracing would have served against, was that the current was warm.

It had never been warm before. The grey was a cold neutral nothing; that was its whole nature. But the flow

toward the cliff was warm, and the warmth had a grain to it he knew, and he understood with a lurch that the warmth was *company* — that the thing draining toward the cliff was not empty grey but grey full of the held warm parts of everything that had ever been lost here, all of it flowing home, and that if he let go his will and stopped wading he would flow with it, into the warm, toward the gladness he could feel waiting patient at the bottom of the pull, the thing that knew him, that had always known him, that was so very pleased he had finally come this far in.

And in the warm, a few steps downcurrent — close, so close — was Mathen.

* * *

He was sitting the way he sat at a fire, one knee up, easy, and he was *talking,* of course he was talking, telling some story to no one with his hands going, and when he saw Third his whole face did the thing it did, the lighting-up, the pleasure at company, undimmed.

"There he is," Mathen said — warm, glad, and the words went through Third like a blade because they were nearly the other words, the wet-gravel words, *there you are,* and here they were turned back into kindness in the mouth of the man the other mouth had killed. "I wondered if you'd come. I hoped you wouldn't, and I hoped you would, which is the usual way of hoping, I find."

"You are here," Third said. The avalanche of his voice came strange in the grey, muffled, near.

"I'm somewhere. I'm here when you're here. I don't ask it too many questions." Mathen patted the nothing beside him, an invitation to sit, the way he'd patted a thousand fire-logs. "Sit a while. You look terrible, which I'll grant is your natural state, but more so. Sit. Tell me a story. You owe me one — you never did pay back the Dorn telling, and

now look, I've gone and given you a second one, the whole dramatic exit, you could dine out on me for a tenday." The grin. "Make it a good one. Laugh at the start."

And Third wanted to sit. That was the thing he would carry out of the grey if he carried nothing else — the size of how much he wanted to sit down beside Mathen in the warm and tell him a story and have it be, for as long as forever lasted, exactly this easy. The grief he had carried up out of the lived world did not lessen in the warm; it was held there, but held the way a note is held, sustained, sweet, unbearable, and the only thing that promised to end the unbearable sweetness was to give in to it, to sit, to stay, to stop wading and let the warm current carry the two of them down to where all the others were, because they were there, he could feel them now, the whole downcurrent abundance of them — a green child, a swordsman with a Boltcaster, a woman who had been unwell, a woman from the snow — all of them, *kept,* all of them a few steps further into the warm, and the gladness at the bottom of it saying, without words, in the voice that had smiled at him as it fell: *yes. all of them. you have only to come the rest of the way. you have been alone so long. let me know you. let me give them back.*

* * *

He had been warned. He had warned himself, sitting on a fallen slab with Tasha, naming the trap aloud so that he would recognise it when it closed. He had thought, naming it, that knowing the shape of a trap was most of escaping it.

He had been wrong. Knowing the shape of it did nothing. The shape of it was *Mathen, glad to see him, asking for a story,* and there is no knowledge that armours a creature against being wanted by someone it loves.

So he reached, drowning, for the only thing that was not in the warm.

"Mathen," he said. "Are you Mathen?"

The grin flickered — not gone, but troubled, the way the living Mathen's face had gone troubled when a thing mattered. "Now that," he said slowly, "is a question I can't answer, and the fact that I can't is probably your answer, isn't it. Clever. You were always cleverer than you let the room think." He looked downcurrent, toward the warm gladness, then back, and something old and sad and entirely *himself* came up in him. "I'll tell you what I know. I know I feel like me. I know I'd tell you to stay, if staying were the kind thing — I never could stand to see you carry what you carry. And I know that *because* I'd want you to stay, you can't trust me to tell you to. If I'm really me, I'm compromised by loving you. And if I'm not really me—" the grin came back, rueful, terrible "— then I'm the prettiest hook that's ever been baited, and you should be halfway gone already." He spread his hands. "Either way, old friend, you can't take the word of anyone in here. That's the cruelty they built into the place. You'll never again be able to tell your dead from the thing wearing them. I'm sorry. I'd undo it for you if I could. Which is, of course, exactly what the hook would say."

And that — not the warning, not the will, not the wading — that was the thing that turned him. Because it was so precisely the move the living Mathen would have made, to look the trap in the face and name its teeth even at the cost of his own comfort, that Third could not tell if it proved the man real or proved the bait perfect, and in the not-being-able-to-tell he understood, finally and in his bones, what Tasha had understood for him with only a road's worth of watching: that the warm part was lost to him now. Not Mathen. The whole of it. Every grave he had

ever visited in the grey, every warm note he had gone there to sustain — poisoned, every one, because he would never again know whether he was grieving or being fished.

The grey had been the one place his dead were safe. The Titan had made it the one place they were bait. It had taken from him the only comfort his unkillable life had ever found, and it had done it gently, and there had been, as ever, no cruelty in the doing — only the warm, and the gladness, and the patient certainty that he would, in the end, come home.

He would not give it that. He had decided this on a slab in the lived world and he decided it again now in the warm, with Mathen's face on it, which was harder by an order he had not imagined.

He turned upcurrent, into the wading, away from the warm and the abundance and the green child a few steps downcurrent that he did not let himself look at, that he would not look at, that he would spend the rest of whatever he had not-looking at, and he reached for the thread.

It was still there. Thin, lived, loud. *—come back, you hear me, you don't get to do this, you don't get to leave me here doing the watch alone, there's a whole stupid world out here with a sign that says Only and a boy who needs you and me, Third, me, I'm still telling you about the sign, come back and let me finish—* He took hold of Tasha's voice with everything that was left of his will, and he waded, and the warm pulled, and Mathen — or the thing that was kind enough or cruel enough to wear him — called after, the last of it, the living man's exact cadence:

"*Go on,*" Mathen said. "Whatever's coming. You go on. And Third—" almost lost now, under the rope, under the wading "—tell it well. Laugh at the start."

Third stepped back into the world.

* * *

He came back wrong, and he knew he came back wrong, because the first thing he was aware of was Tasha's face very close to his and both her hands fisted in the vines of his arm and tears on her and her voice gone hoarse from how long she had been throwing it after him into a place she could not see.

"I had you," she was saying. "I had you, I had you the whole time."

"You did," he managed. The lived world was very loud and very cold and very full of unfinished things, and he had never in three hundred thousand spins been so grateful for any of them. "You did. I heard the sign." The bellows dragged, ragged, the one he allowed himself. "Tasha. It was worse than I told you it would be. I told you it would be hard. I did not know — I could not have known until I was in it — that knowing would not help. That I would want it *with the knowing.* That the wanting does not care what I understand." The coal of his eye found hers, and there was naked fear in it, the certainty gone, the old sureness nowhere. "When it comes — the real offering, at the cliff, with all of them and not just the one — I am not certain my will is the thing that decides it. I think it may be yours. I think the rope may be the whole of what stands between that thing and the door. I am sorry. That is a terrible thing to hang on a person. I would carry it myself if there were any way at all to carry it myself."

"I know," Tasha said. She didn't let go of his arm. "I've got the rope. I'm not putting it down." A breath. "What did it offer."

He looked, for a moment, the way she had learned meant he was choosing the true thing over the easy one.

"Him," Third said. "And all of them behind him. Kept. Warm. Forever." The ember sank to almost nothing. "And the worst of it, Tasha — the worst of it is that I could not tell, at the end, whether the Mathen who told me to go on was Mathen being kind, or the thing being clever. I will never be able to tell. It has taken even that. I went in to grieve my friend and I came out unable to be sure I have ever grieved anyone, or only ever been fished by something patient wearing the faces of my own dead."

The fire had burned to coals. Out past it, unwatched, the great book turned a page. And the three of them sat in the cold lived world that was loud and unfinished and *true,* and none of them slept, and Third did not go into the grey again, though I think — I came to think, after — that the notgoing was its own slow kind of starving, and that he did it for us, and that it was one more thing he never once asked us to thank him for.

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Thirty One

Grief in a party of three is a different animal from grief alone. Alone, you can let it have all of you; there's no one watching to be frightened by how much. With two others, you have to keep enough of yourself back to be a person they can stand near, and the keeping-back is its own exhaustion, on top of the grief, which does not take kindly to being kept back and finds other ways out.

We were very bad at it, the day after. We were bad at it because the person who would have been good at it, who would have known exactly the right thing to say and the right moment to say nothing and the right way to put a bowl down by your hand so that you ate without deciding to — that person was ash now, and his absence was loudest precisely in the places he used to fill. The silences he'd have broken sat there unbroken. The food I made was just food, fuel, grey in the mouth, and I understood for the first time that Mathen cooking well had never really been about the cooking; it had been about giving us a thing to look forward to three times a day on a road that otherwise offered nothing to look forward to at all. He had been feeding us hope in the shape of stew. I couldn't do it. I didn't have the recipe.

Roan came apart quietly, which is the way the strong ones do it. He did his watches and ate what was put in front of him and answered when spoken to, and somewhere behind his eyes a door had shut, and I watched him standing at the rim of the field that second evening looking out at nothing with the specific stillness of a young man

doing arithmetic he doesn't want the answer to. I knew the arithmetic, because I was doing it too, and it wasn't hard to write out his version. *We're three. Mathen was worth any two of us in a fight and the thing took him in a breath, before he could lift the blade he was the best with. We cannot win this. Whatever Tasha and the Forged know that I don't, it did not save Mathen, and it will not save me.* And then the line his sums had that mine didn't: *I am young — too few spins behind me to have learned how to spend the rest of them well — and I do not want to be a pile of ash on a rock at the edge of the world.* So I went and stood beside him, and I gave him the thing nobody had given me, because I'd had no one to give it: the door, held open.

* * *

"You can go, Roan."

He didn't look at me. "Don't."

"I mean it. I'm not — this isn't a test, it's not me checking are-you-brave. You've nothing left to prove to me; I watched you stand still on that field with a Grinding Teeth cloud an arm's length off your face, I know what you've got." I kept my voice level, which took some doing. "But this is going to get worse, and it's not your fight. You came out because a Forged needed a head brought back and it turned into something nobody could have signed up for. Mathen would skin me if I let you die here without telling you, out loud, that you are allowed to walk away. You go home. You guard a gate. You get old. Nobody — not me, not Third, not him, wherever he is — nobody thinks one thing less of you. That's true and I need you to have it."

He was quiet a long while. The Scar's dark edge was coming up over the field. Out in it a far slab went over with a crash, and neither of us flinched, which tells you something about what a tenday at the Graveyard does to a

person.

"Is it worse than you're saying," he asked. "What's coming."

"Yes."

"Can you tell me how?"

I thought about it. About what Third had laid on me on the slab — the door, the offer, the dead held warm, the cruellest job in the world. It was not mine to hand to Roan, and it was too heavy to hand to anyone you were also telling to feel free to leave. "No," I said. "Not all of it. Some of it's Third's to tell or not. But the short of it is: there's a thing coming that wants something only Third can give it, and it's going to offer him the world to get it, and my job — the reason I can't take the door I'm offering you — is to make sure he doesn't give it. That's the whole of what I am here to do now. Stand between Third and the thing he's going to want more than anything. So no. I don't get to leave. But you do."

Roan turned and looked at me then, and the door behind his eyes was open again, just a crack, the arithmetic abandoned.

"Mathen didn't leave," he said. "He could've, loads of times. He stayed because — " Roan's jaw worked. "He stayed because of you two. Because you don't leave the people. He told me that once, not in those words, he never said anything in those words, but that's what it was. You tend the people. That's the — that's the whole job, he said. Everything else is just where you happen to be standing while you do it." He wiped his face with the heel of his hand, rough, done with the coming-apart. "I'm not going. Not because I'm brave. I worked out on that field that I'm brave enough, which turns out to be a smaller and worse thing than I thought it'd be. I'm staying because you two

are the people, now, and I'm not going to be the one who leaves them. That's it. That's the whole of my reason and it's not a grand one and I don't care."

And there it was — Mathen, sitting up in him, wearing his face, saying his things in not-his-words. I'd buried a man yesterday and here he was today, transplanted whole into a frightened brave boy who hadn't even noticed it happen. I didn't tell Roan. You don't tell someone they've started carrying your dead; they find it heavy enough without knowing what it is.

"Okay," I said. "Then you're staying. And Roan—" I made myself say it, because Mathen would have, because somebody had to be the one who said the warm thing now and the job had apparently fallen to me. "He'd be unbearable about this. He'd have a whole speech. He'd make you cry and then make you laugh and you'd hate him for it."

Roan laughed, once, wet and surprised, exactly the way Mathen had laughed at the end, and I had to look away at the field for a moment.

"Yeah," he said. "He would've."

* * *

Third I found where he always was now, at the very lip of the rim, as close to the cliff as he let himself get, watching the thing he would not walk into anymore.

He had not gone into the grey since that one time after Mathen. I knew what it was costing him — that the grey had been the one place he could set the weight down, visit the warm parts, and now he wouldn't, both because it would take him and because he could no longer trust what he found there to be his dead and not their wearer. He was carrying all of it awake now, all the time, with no relief, the way the rest of us carry our griefs, except he had three

hundred thousand spins of them stacked up and no end coming to set them down at. I had started to understand that this — the not-going, the carrying-awake — was its own slow dying, and that he'd chosen it for us, and that the choosing was using him up.

I could see the using-up. When I came alongside him the seam down his chest caught the last of the light, and through it, faint, I could see the two small lights he kept in there, and the dim one was dimmer. Not gone. But lower than the geysers, lower than yesterday, a wick guttering toward a wick-end.

"It's lower," I said. "The light."

"Yes." He didn't pretend not to know which I meant. "The grey pulls harder the longer I stand near it, and standing near it is the whole of my purpose, so. It draws on me. I had perhaps twenty spins in the dim one when we reached the geysers. I have rather fewer now." The coal of his eye stayed on the cliff. "It does not matter, Tasha. Truly. Whatever happens at that cliff happens long before the light does. I mention it only because you asked, and because you have decided to know the true things now, and that is one of them. I am running down. We are all of us running down. Mine is merely visible."

"Don't," I said, and didn't have the rest of the sentence, so I just put my hand on his forearm, the place that had become mine, where Mathen's hand had been, where I would put it again when it mattered most.

"He is close," Third said. "The man. The hand of the thing. I cannot look into the grey to count the days, but I do not need to. It pours toward the cliff faster every watch. The field is changing more — you'll have noticed, the cracks come closer together now. Everything is being drawn in. He is coming to the last peg, and we are sitting on it, and it will be soon. A day. Perhaps two." The eye

came round to me, and the fear was in it, and under the fear, the thing I had come to trust more than I trusted his strength: the decision, held. "You remember what you promised me."

"I remember."

"You will not believe the version of me that begs."

"I'll believe this one," I said. "The one telling me not to. I've got it written down in here—" I tapped my own skull "—where the begging can't get at it. I'm ready, Third. I've been ready since the slab. Being ready is most of what I do now."

"Yes," he said. "You are very good at it. Better than I am, and I have had longer to practise." Which was the closest Third came to a compliment, and I took it, and we stood the last of the light together looking at the cliff that was drinking the world.

* * *

That night the three of us sat the watch all together, no pairs, because what was the point of pairs now, and because none of us wanted to be the one not in the firelight when it came. Roan sharpened things that didn't need sharpening. I told them, badly, the story of the inn and the burglar Third scared off by warning it which way not to break in, and Third corrected three of my details and Roan almost smiled and it was nothing at all like Mathen doing it and it was the best we had and it was, I decided, enough. You do the thing the dead taught you, badly, in your own clumsy hands, because the alternative is to let the thing die with them, and we had buried enough.

Out past the fire the great book turned its pages faster than it used to. The grey poured toward the cliff, carrying its warm and terrible cargo, and somewhere out in the dark a man with six cold lights on his back walked the last of his

straight line toward us, toward the last pin in the world and the door that was the only thing left that could open it.

We were three. We were tired. One of us was running down where you could see it and all of us were running down where you couldn't. We had a plan thinner than river ice and a job crueller than any of us had agreed to when we set out, and not one of us was leaving.

I had followed a monster out of an inn because I was bored, and I had found, at the cold edge of the world, the only thing I have ever been certain was worth the whole terrible trip: three of us at a fire, with the end coming, choosing to stay.

Let it come. We were ready. We were as ready as the unready ever get.

* * *

Thirty Two

We knew it was the day because the field stopped pretending.

For a tenday the open book had played its patient game — moved only when we looked away, settled its great canting pages a little nearer or a little further each time our backs were turned, so that you could almost believe you'd misremembered, almost believe stone behaved. That morning it stopped bothering. We woke to a field rearranged in plain sight, not while we slept but while we watched: a slab the size of a barn sliding its base across bare rock with a sound like a slow tooth, grinding itself a hand's breadth spireward and stopping, as if it had remembered it no longer needed to be shy. The grey was running so hard toward the cliff by then that even I could feel it, and I have no gift for the grey at all — a tug, low in the chest, the exact place you'd press if you were trying not to be sick, except the pull was outward, toward the pale wall, as though the morning itself were draining into it.

Third stood at the rim with his back to our dead fire and looked at the cliff the way you look at a debt you have always known you would have to pay.

"He is on the field," he said. "He came in the dark, while we kept the watch facing the wrong way again." A dry sound, not quite the bellows. "We are very bad at facing the right way. It is, I think, the most humin thing about all of us." The eye came round. "It is today. Do you still mean to come, or have you the sense the night might have given you?"

"Don't," I said. "You know I'm coming. Roan?"

"Coming," Roan said, and checked the lashings on his spear for the fourth time that hour, which was how Roan said *I am terrified and I am coming anyway,* and which I had learned not to comment on.

"Then we go to it," Third said, "while we can still choose the ground. He will make for the spine. The spine is the last of it — the last pin, the place the whole shape is hung from. If he reaches it unopposed he has everything he needs and we have a long walk home with nothing to show for it but our lives, which he will not let us keep regardless." He took up his glaive, the Boltcaster, and his Falkas, and he did not put on the cloak. He had no more use for looking like a man.

* * *

I have crossed bad country. I grew up a walk from a black swamp; I had been over the Gnawing Fields with their floating teeth and their pale plinths; I had stood a tenday at the rim of this place watching it crawl. None of it taught me what it was to walk *into* the open book, out among the pages, with the rule of the place — *do not look away* — turned from a curiosity into the only law that mattered.

Because you cannot watch everything. That is the whole cruelty of it. You have a front and the field has no manners about which direction it uses. We crossed in a tight knot, the three of us, each facing a third of the world, turning our heads in a slow shared sweep we fell into without discussing, like oarsmen finding a stroke — and still, every time the sweep came round, something was *different.* A slab that had leaned left now leaned right. A gap we'd meant to walk through had closed to a seam. A flat page we'd marked as our path had tilted in the breath our eyes were elsewhere and become a wall, and we had to find the

path again from nothing, in a place that rearranged its own evidence the instant we trusted it.

Roan said, once, very low, "It's like being watched by something that stops the moment you turn." And none of us answered, because he was exactly right and there was nothing to add to it except more fear.

The pages got bigger as we went in. At the rim they had been barn-sized; here they were the size of town walls, of hillsides, vast flat sheets of pale stone canted at angles that hurt to stand under, each one a leaf of a book the size of a country laid open and reading itself in the dark. And between them, in the low places, the grey had come up out of the ground. I had never seen it from the lived side — Third's country, not mine — but there it was, pooled in the troughs between the great stones like ground-fog that had forgotten to be white, a faint moving greyness with the wrongest light in it, all of it sliding, all of it pouring, the same direction we were walking. Toward the wall.

* * *

The wall took its toll on Third by lengths.

I'd promised to watch him and I watched him, and what I watched was a slow leaning. Not of his body — his body crossed that field like it crossed everything, sure-hooved and exact — but of *him*, the him inside the make of him, tilting toward the cliff the way the slabs tilted, the way the grey poured. By the time the pages were hillside-sized he was walking at a slight cant against nothing, leaning upcurrent into a wind only he could feel, and the seam down his chest showed both lights working hard, the dim one guttering with the effort, and his answers had gone short.

"Third."

"I am here."

"Say the thing. The whole thing. Out loud, for me."

He knew what I was asking. We had made it a drill on the slab two nights back — that if the pull got into him I was to make him *talk,* because the part of him that talked to me was the part that was still walking to the cliff to stop a thing, and not the part that wanted to lie down in the warm and be known.

"I am Third," he said, and the avalanche of it steadied as he said it, the way a man's hands steady on a rope he has remembered he is holding. "I am going to the spine to refuse him. I will not be made willing. You will not believe the version of me that begs. There is a girl named Tasha walking on my left who is going to be the whole of my will if my own gives out, and a guardsman on my right who has chosen the people over the sense, and they are mine, and they are *here,* and that is more true than anything that wall is going to offer me." A pause. The cant of him eased, a degree. "Thank you. Ask me again when I go quiet."

"I will. I'll ask you the whole way."

"I know you will. It is why I let you come."

* * *

We saw him when the field gave us a long straight aisle between two leaning pages — a corridor of bare rock running spireward, and at the far end of it, small with distance, a figure walking.

He walked the way the grey-faced traveller had described back at the inn, and worse for the seeing of it: dead straight, unhurried, putting one foot exactly in front of the other along a line only he could see, as though the field's crawling did not apply to him, as though the slabs declined to rearrange in front of *that.* And riding his back, even at that distance, even in the day, six small cold lights — bottled lightning gone to dying embers in their jars — six

of them where Third had two, and one of Third's already failing. He did not look at us. He had not, I understood, looked at anything in a very long time that was not the thing he was walking toward. He went building to building through a dead town and never turned his head; he would cross a field that ate the unwary and never break his line; and he was going to reach the spine at the same time we did, from the other arm of the open book, the two of us converging on the hinge of the world like the covers of the book closing.

"There," Third said, unnecessarily. The eye had gone very bright and very steady. "The hand of the thing under everything."

And then he went still — stiller than the moment asked for, a stillness with a different grain to it, the same stillness that had come over him in the inn the day the grey-faced traveller spoke, as though the shape of that far walker had reached across all the bare rock between us and pressed on something in him he had no intention of letting me see. Whatever it was, he didn't say it. His head stayed level on the distant figure, and his answer, when I asked with a look, was only the bright steady eye and nothing behind it I was allowed to read.

I filed it. Of course I filed it; it is the curse Mathen used to tease me for, and I had no Mathen now to tease me, so I filed it alone and said nothing, and we walked the last of the aisle toward the place the whole shape was hung from, where the grey stood up out of the ground in a pale drowning wall against the pale dead wall of stone, and where a thing was waiting that had a place in it shaped exactly like Third, and a girl from an inn was going to have to be a rope.

The spine rose in front of us, and resolved, the way the cliff always resolved on approach — gradually, grudgingly,

a little more true with every step until you could not unsee how big it was. And at its foot, in the last of the bare rock before the stone and the grey, there was room enough to stand and say the things that had to be said before the other thing arrived to say his.

"Here," Third said. "We say what we must here. Quickly. He is close, and once he is closer there will be no more saying, only doing."

I looked at Roan, who did not know yet all of what he had walked into.

It was, I realised, my turn to hold a door open for someone — and this time, the cruel kind, the kind that only opens inward.

* * *

Thirty Three

There is a particular cruelty in knowing exactly how a thing is going to land before you do it, because Third had done it to me, on a slab two nights gone, and I had felt the floor of the world go out from under me one fact at a time, and now I was going to do the same to Roan with the cold man a thousand paces off and closing, and there was no kind way and no slow way and no time for either.

So I did it the way Tondi would have set a broken arm. Fast, and straight, and without asking him to hold still first, because asking only makes them tense.

"Roan. Listen to me and don't say anything till I'm done, because we don't have the breath. You know some of this. Here's the rest."

He looked at me. The spear had stopped its endless re-checking. That was how I knew he'd already understood that the talking part was over and some other part had started.

"The thing under the world wants back in. It can't come on its own — it's too big, it's in pieces, half of it's in the grey. It needs a door. Third is the door. Not because he's willing — because of what he's *made* of, what woke him, the way he walks in both places at once. It can't force the door; that's the one mercy in the whole rotten business. It can only get him to *open* it. From the inside. On purpose." I kept my voice flat, the way you keep a hand flat for a frightened animal. "So it's going to offer him a price. And the price is everyone he's ever lost. All of them. Whole, and

warm, and back, forever — Liwon, the swordsman, the woman who was sick, the woman in the snow. Mathen."

That one I watched land. I'm sorry to say I had to. I needed to know he'd heard it.

"Mathen's in there now, Roan. In the warm. The thing has him. And it will hold him up at the end like the last coin in a purse and tell Third *all he has to do is open the door and he gets them all back, Mathen included,* and Third is going to want to. Not might. *Going to.* I've seen what it does to him just standing near it; I watched it nearly take him with my own voice the only thing holding the other end. He is going to stand at that wall and want, with everything three hundred thousand spins has piled up in him, to say yes. And if he says yes, the thing comes through, and there is no more world. Not our lives — the *world.* Everyone's. Everywhere. That's the size of it. That's what we walked out here to stand in front of."

I made myself stop. I let him have the breath I'd told him to save.

* * *

He did not bolt. I will love him for that as long as I have left to love anything. The size of it went through him — I watched it go through him, the way a swallow of something too strong goes through you, all the way down, and his face did several things and settled, at the end, on the one I'd hoped for and not dared expect: not the slack of a man who's quit, but the stillness of a man who's decided to be useful with whatever he's got left.

"What do I do," he said. Not *can we win.* Not *are you sure.* What do I do. Mathen, I thought. Mathen all the way down.

"You keep me on him." I turned him by the shoulder so he was facing Third, who stood a little apart, giving us this,

watching the cold man come. "That's the whole of your job and it's the worst one and I'm sorry it's yours. Whatever happens, I am the rope. As long as my voice is on Third and my hand is on Third, there's a chance. The thing knows that now. So it's going to try to take me off him. Maybe through the cold man. Maybe—" I made myself say it "—maybe through Third. If it turns him, if it gets him moving, he is stronger than the three of us stacked up and he will come through me to get to that wall and he will not know he's doing it."

"And I stop him." Flat. Already accepting the impossible arithmetic of it.

"You don't *stop* him. You can't. None of us can. You're not meant to." Third's words, from the drill; I gave them to Roan now because they were the truest thing I had. "You're meant to cost it time. You put your body between me and whatever's coming and you make it spend seconds getting through you. Ten breaths. That's the job. Buy me ten breaths to finish refusing, and you'll have done more than any hero in any of Mathen's stories, and most of them only had to die for a *town.*"

He took that in. Then, the boy in him surfacing one last time before whatever he was about to become: "Will it hurt him? If I have to. Will I hurt Third."

And there it was — the thing that told me Mathen had built better than he knew. Roan, told he might have to throw his body in front of a three-hundred-thousand-spin war-construct to buy a tavern girl ten breaths to save the world, and the question he stopped on was whether *the construct* would be hurt by it.

"No," I said, which was a lie, and a small one, and the kind Mathen would have approved of. "You won't be able to hurt him. Just slow him. That's all."

* * *

Third came to us then, because the cold man was close enough now that there was no more *here* to be said in, only *now.* He looked at Roan for a long moment with the bright unblinking coal of his eye, and Roan looked back and did not flinch, which still, after everything, was rare.

"I brought you to this," Third said. "You were going to guard a gate and grow old. I am sorry. It is the truest apology I have, and it is not enough, and I am giving it to you anyway because you should have it before, and not after, in case there is no after for the giving."

"You didn't bring me," Roan said. "I came. There's a difference. Mathen taught me that one too."

Something moved in the make of Third — not the bellows, nothing so loud, just a settling, the sound a house makes accepting a weight. "Yes," he said. "There is a difference. Thank you for the difference."

And then he turned to me, and his whole attention came round and landed, and I knew from the quality of it that whatever the three of us had just been was finished, and that the next thing he had to say he had to say to me alone, and that I was not going to like it, and that I was going to have to carry it anyway, because that, in the end, was the difference I had chosen too.

* * *

Thirty Four

The first thing he did was set down the glaive.

He did it carefully, the way you set down something that has a history of being mishandled. He leaned it against the foot of the spine, upright, the wide pale blade he had carried since the day he was made — since before he was anyone, when he was only the thing the Titan had wrapped a purpose around and called finished — and he stepped back from it and left it standing there against the pale stone like a tool returned to a shed. He kept the Falkas. The two curved blades he'd spent thirty spins of the Scar learning to dance with, the weapons that were his choosing and not his making, those he checked at his hips with the small unconscious touch of a man making sure of his hands.

I understood it without being told, which is a thing that happens between people who have walked far enough together. He was not going to meet the end of the world as the instrument someone had built. He was going to meet it as the thing that instrument had decided, against every line of its making, to become. The glaive could stand there and watch. It had never been his anyway.

"Tasha," he said. "The last of it. The part I have not told you."

"I know. I saw it on your face. Get it said; he's nearly here."

He was. Down the converging aisle the cold man had grown from a far mark to a near one, close enough now

that I could see the lights riding his back had a faint and constant tremor, like something breathing. We had a hundred breaths, perhaps. Perhaps fewer.

* * *

"You are the rope," Third said. "That is true and it remains true and it is the first thing. As long as you hold me, I have a chance to hold myself. But you are going to need to know the second thing, and the second thing is worse, and I have not let myself say it until now because saying it makes it real and I wanted, selfishly, a few more spins of it not being real." The eye was very steady on me. "If the rope fails — if it gets so far into me that I begin to open, and you cannot pull me back — then holding me is no longer the job. Ending me is the job."

I had known, somewhere, that this was coming. Knowing did not help. It never does; he'd taught me that himself, coming back out of the grey with Mathen's face still on him.

"No," I said.

"Tasha—"

"I heard you. I said no. Tell me the rest of it anyway, because I'm going to need it, but you should know my answer first so you understand what it costs me to change it."

Something in the make of him that was not quite the bellows let go, a small mechanical sigh of a thing that had been braced for a fight and been handed honesty instead. "Thank you," he said. "That is exactly why it is you."

And then he reached around to his back, with that wrong boneless ease that still put a flutter in my chest after all this time, and he brought out the Boltcaster.

Dorn's Boltcaster. I knew it the moment I saw it because he'd shown it to me once, early, at a fire, and told me

whose it had been and how he had died — a tendril through the chest from below, before Third had finished standing up — and told me he had never once loaded it, having carried it a very long time and never fired it, because it was not a weapon to him. It was a person. It was the last weight of a man he had failed to save by the width of a single breath.

He held it a moment longer before he gave it over — and then, with the same wrong boneless economy, he brought a single magefire shot up from somewhere on him, a little vial of caged lightning, and he loaded it. I watched him do it and felt the floor go out from under me a second time, because at the fire, the night he told us about Dorn, he had said it plain to the whole table: *I do not carry it to use.* He had carried it unloaded across more road than I could imagine, kept it the way you keep a grave tidy, and now, here, he was thumbing a shot into it with his own two-fingered hands.

"I have never loaded it," he said, as if he'd heard the thought. "Not once. Loading it would have made it a weapon again, and it stopped being a weapon the day it became Dorn. I am loading it now, because this is the one thing left in the world he would forgive me for aiming it at." Then he put it in my hands. It was heavier than it looked, and warm where his grip had been.

"There is a seam down the centre of my chest. You have seen the lights through it. Those lights are the whole of what keeps the door a door — they are what the wall wants, the same as the cold man carries, the same make, the same dying glow. If you put one of Dorn's shots into that seam, into the lights, the door stops being a door. Permanently. There is no repairing it; I have repaired everything I am, a hundred times over, and I could not repair that. It would be the one wound I have ever taken

that I could not stand up from."

"You're asking me to kill you."

"I am asking you to unmake a door. That the door is also me is the cruelty of it, and I will not pretend it is anything else, because you have earned better than pretending."

* * *

"How do I know," I said. My voice was doing something I did not give it permission to do. "How do I know when. You already told me you'll beg. You already made me promise not to believe the begging. Now you're telling me to — and the begging version is going to beg me not to, isn't it. It's going to look at me with your eye and beg me to put it down. How do I tell the difference. How do I know when there's no more you to save and it's only the door wearing you."

"Because the begging means I am still there." He said it gently, the way you'd explain a hard thing to a child you loved. "While I beg, hold me. The begging is the part of me that still wants you to win fighting the part of me that wants to lose. As long as I am begging you, in either direction, I am still a fight you can win, and you must not use the Boltcaster, no matter how it sounds, no matter what I promise or threaten — you hold." A pause. The lights in his chest guttered, the dim one nearly out. "You will know it is time when I go quiet. Not the begging-quiet. The other one. When I stop arguing with you, when I stop arguing with myself, when I go still and turn to the wall and reach for it and have nothing left to say to you at all — that silence is not me resting, Tasha. That silence is the door swinging open. That is the only moment. You will have a breath, perhaps two, between the silence and the world ending, and in that breath you put Dorn's shot through the seam and you do not hesitate, because the hesitation is the

exact size of the gap the thing needs."

I looked down at the Boltcaster in my hands. The whole stupid weight of it. The dead man in it. The friend who'd carried it unloaded and unfired across more road than I could hold in my head, because using it was unthinkable, handing it to me so that I could fire it into him.

"Why me," I said. "Roan would— no. Don't say it kindly. Say it true. Why is this mine."

* * *

"Because Roan would do it too soon," Third said. "He loves me as a boy loves the thing he's decided to be brave for, and that love would flinch at the begging and end me to spare me the struggle, and the struggle is the whole of the chance. And the cold man would do it too late, or not at all, because to him I am a mechanism and he would want to see if the mechanism could be made to work after all." The eye held mine. "You are the only one who will do it at exactly the right moment, which is to say the last possible one, which is to say only when there is truly nothing left — because you do not want to do it. Because you will hate every breath between the silence and the shot. I am not choosing the person most able to kill me, Tasha. I am choosing the person least willing. That unwillingness is the most precise instrument in the world. It is the only thing I trust to wait long enough, and still not wait too long."

He looked, for a moment, at the cold man coming, and then back at me, and he said the thing under the thing, the thing he had been walking toward saying since the slab field, since the geysers, since the inn:

"I am afraid I am going to want it. The opening. The price. I have been alone inside this make of mine for three hundred thousand spins and it is going to offer me everyone, all at once, warm, and I am afraid — I, who am

not built to be afraid of much — that I am going to want it more than I have ever wanted anything, more than I will want the world. So I am giving you the thing that means my wanting it will not be enough. I am putting the size of my own longing into your hands and I am asking you to be bigger than it. That is the whole of what I have ever asked anyone. I am sorry it is so large."

I did not say *I can't.* I had already used my no, and he had thanked me for it, and we both understood it had been the last one I was allowed.

I said, "Then you'd better beg loud, you old fool. Because I am going to need to hear you in there right up until the last breath, and if you go quiet on me one second before you have to, I will never forgive you, in this world or whatever's left of it."

"I will be as loud as I am able," Third said. "It is a promise. It may be the last one I am able to keep as myself."

And behind him, at the foot of the spine, where the pale grey stood up out of the ground against the pale dead stone, the cold man stopped walking.

We were out of breaths. He was here.

* * *

Thirty Five

Up close the cold of him was a real thing, a weather. It came off him the way heat comes off a stove, except backwards, except wrong — a steady draught of cave-air that found the sweat on you and made you regret having a body at all. Roan, three paces to my left with his spear low, flinched at it before he caught himself. I didn't catch myself in time and shivered like a wet dog. Third did not feel it, or did not show it, which by then was the same thing.

I had braced, I think, for a monster. For something that looked like what it did. But the cold man just looked old — old past any use the word usually gets put to, old the way the cliff was old, a person who had been a person so long ago that the being-a-person had worn off him like paint off a fence. His face was all still there, eyes and mouth and the rest, and there was nothing behind any of it but patience. That was the worst part. Not menace. Patience. The patience of a thing that has already won and is only waiting for the rest of you to notice. And riding his stooped back, close enough now that I could see them clear, the six lights: bottled lightning long dead in their jars, the same blue-white as the two in Third's chest, except his were guttering and these six only sat there, steady and spent and somehow worse for it, like eyes that have stopped expecting anything.

He stopped a few paces from Third, and the two of them stood there, and I understood — watching the way they held themselves, both of them somehow a half-step out of the world, both leaning on a wind no one else could feel —

that I was looking at two of a kind. Not the same. But kin, the way a key and a lock are kin: made to fit, made by the same hand for the same wound.

* * *

"You are awake," the cold man said.

His voice was nothing like Third's. Where Third was an avalanche, low and felt in the bones, this was the thin dry whisper of air pulled through a long-dead place, a sound with no warmth in it to lose. He said it the way you'd say a thing you had wanted for so long that getting it had stopped being a joy and become only a fact. There was no triumph in it. There was something far worse — something almost like tenderness.

"I felt them make you," he went on, when Third said nothing. "All of you. A long time ago, when the hand that made you struck you out — I felt each blow of it, here—" and he did not point to his chest, he pointed down, at the rock, at the cliff, at whatever was under it "—because I am fixed to the thing they struck you against. I have felt every one of your kind woken since, the way you feel a door open somewhere in a house you cannot leave. Most never woke. The ones that did were too far, or too broken, or died too soon." The patient eyes rested on Third. "I have waited a very long time for one of you to wake near enough, and whole enough, and last long enough to walk to me. And here you are. Do you know what you are?"

"I am Third," said Third. The avalanche held. "I know what I have made myself."

"That is not the question I asked." Not unkind. A teacher correcting a beloved pupil. "I asked if you know what you *are.* You do not. You have wondered — I can see that you have wondered, the whole long walk of your life. Why you can step beside the world when no other made thing can.

Why the grey lets you pass and pulls at you both at once. Why, of all the things the Titans struck out, *you* woke." The cold deepened, or seemed to. "I will tell you, because I want you to understand what you are giving, when you give it. There is no joy in taking a thing from someone who does not know its worth."

I had the Boltcaster under my cloak, loaded, Dorn's whole grave of a weight against my ribs, and my hand on Third's forearm, and my voice already low in my throat saying the small steadying nothings I'd sworn to say — *here, I'm here, you're Third, I've got you* — and I felt Third lean, the smallest degree, toward the cold man's voice. Not toward the lure. There was no lure yet. Toward the *answer.* After three hundred thousand spins, somebody was finally going to tell him why.

* * *

"Under us," the cold man said, "is the Anvil. It is not a stone. It is the thing the Titans set everything else against when they were striking the world into shape — the surface they beat creation on. It is in the grey, and it is larger than this cliff, larger than the country, and it cannot be moved; I have had an age to try, and I am fixed to it, and one does not move the thing one is nailed to." For the first time something that was not patience crossed him — a very old, very tired frustration, worn down to almost nothing. "Everything you have felt these last spins, the pulling, the grey running one way like water down a drain — that is the Anvil. That is me, drawing the world toward the place the world began, because that is the only thing a fixed thing can do. Pull. I have pulled for longer than your kind has had names." The eyes came up. "But pulling is not opening. And I need it *opened.*"

"Then open it," Third said. "You walk in the grey. I have watched you do it. Step across, here, where it is thin, and reach your Anvil, and leave us be."

"I can go to it." A sound came out of him that might once, very long ago, have been a laugh. "I have gone to it more times than there are days in your life. But I am a passenger, made thing. I cross the wall; I do not breach it. I can carry one body sideways into the grey — myself, a thing I collect, no more — the way a man swims a river. The river is not opened by his crossing; it closes behind him as he goes. What is wanted is not a swimmer. What is wanted is a *door* — the wall held wide, and held, long enough for what is on the far side to come *through,* into here, into Anka, in its own vastness and not one body at a time." The patient eyes, the terrible tenderness. "A wall is not opened from without. It is opened from within, by the part of it that is alive. You are the only living part of the wall, made thing. They forged you against the Anvil; the making wove you into the seam of the two worlds; and then the last of them, dying, woke you with its own essence — the very essence that now wants through. You are not a soldier who happens to walk in the grey. You are the grey, and you are Anka, in one skin, with one will. You are the only seam in all the world that can be asked to part. That is what you are. That is what I have waited for. I did not make you, and I do not know your name, and neither of those things has ever mattered. I only ever needed one of you to be *alive,* and *here,* and able to say yes."

* * *

The silence after that had weight, like the air before a stony.

I felt the whole of it land on Third — felt it through my hand on his arm, the way you feel a tree take an axe-blow

through the ground. Everything he had ever wondered, answered, in a dead man's whisper, at the end of the world: not a fluke, not a mercy, not a question the Titans forgot to answer. A purpose. He had spent his entire long life believing he had *escaped* his making — refused the glaive, refused the killing, made himself into something his makers never intended — and here was a thing older than his makers telling him, gently, that the escape itself had been the design. That he had been woken to be a door, and everything he'd become since, every kindness, every refusal, every companion buried, was just the door learning to want things, so that one day it could be offered the one thing that would make it open.

I want to tell you he answered like a hero. He didn't. He went very still, and the lights in his chest stuttered, and for a moment — one moment, the worst of my life to that point — I thought I had already lost him, that the silence I'd been warned to watch for had come this early, before the cold man had even named a price.

"Third," I said. Out loud. Not a steadying nothing. His name, hard, the way you'd throw a rope. "You're Third. You made that name yourself; nobody struck it into you. Say it."

A long breath of bellows, ragged, the first he'd spent in days.

"I am Third," he said. To me. Only to me. "I made myself. Whatever I was struck for." The eye came back to the cold man, and the avalanche came back into the voice, and I could have wept. "You have told me what I am. You are mistaken about one thing only. A door can be a door, and still choose to stay shut. That is also a thing a living seam can do."

The cold man did not look troubled. He looked, if anything, fonder.

"Yes," he said. "It can. That is why I have not come to threaten you, or to break you, neither of which would serve. I have come to *offer* you something. You will want to hear it. Everyone, in the end, wants to hear it." He tilted his worn face, and the six dead lights shivered on his back, and the grey stood up off the ground behind him like a held breath. "Shall I tell you what is waiting, on the other side of the wall you are?"

And Scar help me, I felt Third want to say yes.

* * *

Thirty Six

He did not describe it. I think that is what I had braced for — a speech, a temptation laid out in words I could hear and hate and argue with. Instead the cold man simply opened his hand, palm up, toward the wall of standing grey behind him, and the grey thinned where he gestured the way frost thins on a window when you put your thumb to it, and Third made a sound.

I have heard Third make a great many sounds. The bellows-wheeze, the avalanche, the dry not-laugh. I had never heard him make this one. It was small, and it came from somewhere the bellows didn't reach, and it was the sound a person makes when they see something they had decided, for the sake of going on living, to stop letting themselves want.

I couldn't see it. That is the thing I have to keep telling people, the thing that makes them look at me like I failed him: I could not see into the grey. Whatever opened in that thinning, whatever stood in it warm and reaching, it was shown to Third and not to me. I fought the whole rest of it blind. I had a hand on his arm and his name in my mouth and a dead man's Boltcaster against my ribs, and I was holding him against a thing I could not see, by the one thread I had, which was that he had asked me to.

"There," said the cold man, soft as falling dust. "You know her."

* * *

"Liwon," Third said. Not to me. Not to the cold man. To the thinning in the air, to whatever stood in it. The avalanche had gone all to gravel. "Liwon."

"As she was," the cold man said. "Before the sundering took her. Whole. Small, and afraid of the dark, and certain, the way the very young are certain, that you would never let anything happen to her. She has been kept exactly so. The grey does not let go of what it holds; it only waits to be asked for it back." A pause, weightless, terrible. "You remember what was said to you, the night she died. A seed must die, and be buried, before it can blossom into something beautiful. You thought that a cruelty. It was a promise. This is the blossoming. The seed was planted three hundred thousand spins ago and I am offering you the flower. All of it. Her, and the swordsman with the squat Boltcaster, and the woman the illness took, and the one who taught you to want quiet, and — most lately, still warm, barely cold — the one who taught you to make your losses into stories. Mathen. All of them. Kept. Returned. The moment you open."

I felt Third lean. Not his body. The thing inside the body, the way it had leaned crossing the field, except the field had been a breeze against this. He leaned the way a drowning man leans toward air.

"You can't," I said — to him, low, the rope. "You're Third. You're here. I've got you. Whatever it's showing you, I've got you."

"It is Liwon, Tasha." He said it like a man explaining why he has to let go of the ledge. "She is holding up her arms. She does that — she did that — when she was frightened and wanted to be carried. She is doing it now. She is asking me to carry her. I have not been asked to carry anything in a very long time."

* * *

I want to be honest about how close it was, because the people who weren't there tell it like it was never really in doubt, like Third was always going to refuse, and that is an insult to what it cost him. It was in doubt. It was in doubt for longer than I will ever admit to anyone but this page. He stood at the foot of the spine with his dead daughter holding up her arms in a place I couldn't see, and every part of three hundred thousand spins of being alone reached back toward her, and the lights in his chest guttered low and lower, and his hand under mine had gone slack, and I talked, and talked, and felt the words going into him and falling through, like dropping stones down a well too deep to hear them land.

"Ask me what you are paying," Third said suddenly, to the cold man, and I heard him reaching — reaching for something, a handhold, a counter. "You always tell them the prize. You are too patient to tell them the cost. What is the cost."

"The world," the cold man said, without the smallest hesitation, and that was somehow worse than a lie would have been. "You know this. Everyone, everywhere, all that lives. I will not insult you by softening it. That is the price, and I am telling you plainly, because you are the first of your kind worth telling plainly, and because—" the worn face did something that might once have been gentleness "—because it does not matter. You will reach for her anyway. They always reach. I have watched a great many smaller souls than yours weigh the whole living world against one held face, and the world has never once been heavy enough. It is not a flaw in you. It is the shape of love. I am not your enemy, made thing. I am only the one who understands what you are for."

"Tell me your name," Third said — and I understood, dimly, that he was doing something, that asking was a way of staying, of keeping his feet, of making the thing in front of him a someone he could refuse rather than a force he could only fall into.

The cold man considered. "Sougad," he said. "It is the one thing I will give you for nothing. Everything else in the world has a price now; I have seen to it. But a name is cheap, and you have been honest with me, and I find—" the dust-dry voice paused over the unfamiliar shape of it "—I find I would like one person, before the end, to have known me well enough to use it. Sougad. There. Now refuse a thing with a name, made thing, if you can. It is harder. I know. I have a name too, and it is why I am still fixed to that Anvil and have not let myself fall into the grey and end, all these ages. A name is a small hook, but it holds."

* * *

"Liwon was not a seed."

Third said it slowly, and I felt the first thing in a long time that was not slack — a tension coming back into the arm under my hand, a man finding, in the dark, the edge of something solid.

"You say it as if it were a kindness. The seed, the blossom. But she was not a seed. A seed is a thing that is for something else, that has not happened yet, that is only worth what it becomes. Liwon was not for anything. She was small, and afraid of the dark, and entirely herself, already, finished, real. She was not waiting to become beautiful. She was beautiful, and then she was killed, and the killing was real, and the losing was real, and they were the last true things left of her." The gravel was firming back toward stone. "If I take her back as your flower, I agree with you that she was only ever a seed. I let you

make her into raw material for a thing that comes later. I unmake the one true thing I have — that she lived, and was hers, and not yours, and not the world's, and not a price. A woman in the snow taught me that, once. I did not understand it until just now, with my daughter holding up her arms."

And for a moment — one bright unbearable moment — I thought that was it. I thought he'd done it. I felt him straighten, felt the armour hold, felt the rope go slack in my hand because he didn't need it, he was standing on his own—

And then Sougad, gently, did the cruelest thing in this whole cruel book. He did not argue.

"I know," he said. "You are entirely right. She was herself, and the loss was true, and taking her back dishonours all of it. I am not going to pretend otherwise; you have earned better." The grey thinned a little further. "Knowing that changes nothing. You are going to reach for her anyway, because being right has never once stopped anyone from being lonely. I told you. It does not matter if she is real. It does not matter if it is true. I do not need you to believe me. I need you to *want* her. And you do. You are right, and you want her, and the wanting is the door, and the door is opening, and I am sorry — I find, to my surprise, that I am actually sorry — but I have waited so very long."

And Third stopped talking.

Not the begging-quiet. I knew the difference; he'd carved the difference into me two nights gone. This was the other one. This was the going-still. His hand slid out from under mine. His head turned, slow, toward the wall of grey, toward the small reaching shape only he could see, and he took one step toward it, and he had nothing left to say to me at all.

I had a breath. Perhaps two.

And my hand, Scar forgive me, would not go to the Boltcaster. It went tighter around his empty arm instead, because he was my friend and he was walking away from me into the arms of his dead and the thing I had sworn to do in this exact moment was the one thing my whole body refused to do.

"ROAN," I screamed. It was not the plan. It was the opposite of the plan. It was the only thing in me.

* * *

Thirty Seven

Roan had been three paces back and to my right, where I'd put him, where I'd told him to wait for the worst and not before. He couldn't see into the grey any more than I could; he didn't know about the seed or the blossom or the door. All he had was what I'd given him at the foot of the spine — keep her on him, and when it goes wrong, cost it time. He'd been standing in the cold with his spear and his terror the whole while the cold man talked, waiting for a wrongness he could recognise.

My scream was the wrongness. He didn't ask what for. That, in the end, was the whole of Roan: he didn't ask what for.

He came past me in a lunge that knocked my shoulder half around and did the one thing none of us had planned because none of us had been able to say it aloud — he threw himself not at the cold man, not at the grey, but at *Third.* At his friend. At the wooden back already turning toward the wall, the hooves already lifting for that first long stride into the place where the dead were holding up their arms. Roan got one arm across the seam of Third's chest, over the guttering lights, and his other hand to his own wrist, and locked, and set his heels, and hauled — a boy trying to arm-wrestle a landslide back up its hill.

It did nothing, in the matter of strength. Third took the step anyway, dragging the both of them, Roan's heels furrowing the bare rock toward the standing grey.

So the cold man did the other thing. The thing that told me, finally and completely, what he was.

* * *

Sougad sighed. Actually sighed — the dust-dry ghost of a man put to a small tedious chore — and he said one word.

I did not know it. It was Titanspeech, the old inversion-tongue, the one the greybeards say carries no vowels of its own and borrows whatever ones you lend it, and though I could not read it I felt the shape of it go past me like a draught under a door: a word built backwards, *take* turned cleanly inside out, the old, old word for casting a thing forever out of your keeping. He did not point. He did not so much as lift a hand. He said the word, and the space between Roan and Third simply declined to go on holding him — and Roan was torn off Third's back as though the world had tilted under him alone, flung up and back and down, spear and limbs clattering across the bare stone, and he came to rest a dozen paces off in a heap that did not move.

He did not get up. I could not let myself look long enough to learn whether he *would* — whether the chest rose, whether there was breath left in him at all — because I had a door to hold and only the one pair of eyes to hold it with. I have had to live, since, with not knowing in that moment. It is its own small permanent wound.

And under the horror, cold and clear, I understood the thing that mattered: *he could have done that at any time.* To any of us. To Third. One word, no hand raised, and the strongest thing on that rock thrown down like a swatted fly. He had not done it to Third. He would never do it to Third — could not, dared not — because a door flung and broken is no door at all, because the single lesson of all his ages fixed to that Anvil was that the seam cannot be forced,

only *asked.* He would unmake a guardsman with a breath and not so much as raise his voice at the made thing he needed. Everything true about him was right there, in the gap between what he was willing to break and what he was not.

* * *

And Third saw it.

That is the whole of it. That is what Sougad, in all his patience, in all his ages, had never once had to reckon with — because he had only ever watched souls reach toward what they had lost, and had never watched one get *held onto* by what it still had, and so he did not understand, even now, what he had just done.

One hoof in the grey. His dead daughter an arm's reach into a place I would never see, holding up her arms. Every part of three hundred thousand spins reaching for the warm. And Third turned his head — the smallest degree, a thing that should not have been possible against that pull — and he *saw the boy.* Saw Roan thrown down and unmoving on the cold rock for the single crime of having tried to keep him.

The dead were asking to be carried. And here, flung bleeding on the stone, was the price of the carrying — counted out in front of him, in a living boy, by the very hand that wanted him to say yes. Sougad, who needed Third willing, had reached for the one tool he understood and shown Third precisely what his yes was worth.

"That's it," I said, and I do not know where the steadiness came from; I think it came from Roan. "That's your yes, Third. That. On the rock. He came because you tend the people — Mathen's whole law, the only thing he had to leave us — you tend the people, and Roan tended *you,* and that is what your yes does to the ones who tend

you. Walk into that wall. Go on. And he doesn't let go of you in his heart even now, so the grey takes him too, and you make another one. You make another Liwon. You make *him* one of the little arms reaching, forever. Is that the carrying you missed? Is it?"

* * *

And Third — one hoof lifted, the grey an arm's reach, the dead reaching, the boy bleeding — stopped.

He did not turn around. He was not back; the silence still held the most of him, and I could see the wall's pull on him like a current on a wading man. But the lifted hoof did not complete its step into the grey. It came down. On the lived side. On the cold honest rock.

And into the stolen breath where that step should have finished, Third said the first word he had spoken since the going-still closed over him — not to Sougad, not to the dead, not even to me, but low, over his shoulder, toward the heap of a boy a dozen paces off on the stone:

"...Roan."

It was not the refusal. The refusal was still to come, and it would cost him the worst thing he ever paid for anything, and I would have to watch him pay it. But it was the first crack of light under a door I had given up for shut, and I put my shoulder to that crack and shoved with everything I had left in me.

* * *

Thirty Eight

I have been asked to describe what happened next more times than I have been asked anything else in my life, and I have never once done it well, because the truest answer is the one nobody wants: I don't know. I couldn't see it. The most important thing that has ever happened in the world happened a half-step sideways from me, in a place my eyes were not made to go, and all I had was the back of a wooden man and the things he said out loud and the slow terrible arithmetic of watching someone decide.

So this is not what happened. This is what it looked like, from the rock, from the wrong side of the wall, holding a rope I couldn't see the far end of.

It looked like a man saying goodbye to his daughter.

* * *

"Liwon," he said. The hoof was down. The other had not lifted again. But he had not turned from the grey either, and his voice when it came was not the avalanche and not the gravel — it was small, and careful, the voice you'd use on a child you were not going to be able to keep from crying. "Liwon. Look at me. No — keep your arms down a moment. I know. I know you're frightened. I know it's dark in there. Listen to me."

I could not hear an answer. There was no answer to hear; she was in the place I couldn't go. But I watched Third listen to one, watched his head tilt the exact degree it must have tilted over a sling three hundred thousand spins ago, and I have never in my life felt so much like an

intruder on something holy and so unable to leave.

"I cannot come and get you," Third said. "I know I said I would always come. I know. I have thought about that promise every day you have been gone, and I am breaking it now, on purpose, with my eyes open, and I need you to hear me say that it is a promise I am choosing to break and not one I forgot." A pause. The lights in his chest had stopped guttering; they had gone very steady, very low, the way a flame goes steady right before. "Because the you in there is not the last true thing about you. The last true thing about you is that you were *mine,* and you were *real,* and you were taken, and it was wrong, and it has stayed wrong every day since, and that wrongness is the only honest grave you have. If I take the warm copy this thing is holding up, I have to agree with it that you were only ever a seed for it to grow me a flower from. And you were not a seed, Liwon. You were a girl. You were my girl. And I would rather keep the empty place where you were, true, forever, than fill it with something that calls your whole short real life a *down payment.*"

* * *

I felt it through the rope before I understood it. The arm under my hand — slack since the going-still took him — came back. Not pulling toward the wall. Not pulling anywhere. Just *his* again, weight in it, a man inhabiting his own limb.

"You taught me this," Third said, and I knew, this time, it was not to Liwon, and not to me; it was to a woman who had died old in a bed a long way from here, who had lost everything and gone on anyway. "You said going on was the only way to call the loss what it was. I did not understand you. I thought you meant *endure.* You meant *refuse.* You meant that to take the bargain is to let them

tell you it was never really a loss at all — and that the loss is the last of the love you get to keep. I am keeping it. I am keeping all of it. Thank you. I am sorry it took me until the end of the world."

And then, to the grey, to the small reaching shape in it, the worst sentence I have ever heard a person say, said gently, said like tucking someone in:

"Goodbye, Liwon. I love you. Stay where it's warm. I am not coming."

* * *

I will tell you what I saw, and you can believe what you like about what it means.

I saw the standing wall of grey go *out* — not torn, not slammed, nothing violent. It went out the way a held breath goes out. It had stood up off the ground like something about to speak and now it simply sat back down into the rock and the troughs and the ordinary low places, thinning, paling, becoming again the faint wrong fog I'd watched all the way across the field, and then less than that, and then gone, and the bare honest rock of the world lay there under the Scar's grey light with nothing standing up out of it at all.

And I felt Third lose her.

I had braced for triumph. There wasn't any. What came through the rope, through the arm under my hand, was the thing I had no name for until I'd felt it — the second losing. He had buried her once, a child, three hundred thousand spins ago, with no choice in it. Now he had been handed her back, whole, warm, asking to be carried, and he had given her up *again,* with every choice in the world, and chosen the empty place on purpose. The first time the world took her from him. This time he handed her back to the dark with his own two-fingered hands, so that the world

could keep being a world.

He made a sound then. Once. I won't try to spell it. It was not the bellows and it was not a word. It was the sound the make of him made around a grief it had chosen, and I hope I never hear anything like it again, and I will hear it for the rest of my life.

* * *

Sougad did not rage.

I think, if he had raged, I could have hated him cleanly, and it would have been easier. Instead the worn old face simply… settled, the way water settles when you stop disturbing it, back into the patience it had worn coming across the field — except the patience had nothing left to be patient *toward,* now, and so it was just a face, very old, looking at a wall that had closed and a door that had chosen, with the six dead lights guttering on his stooped back.

"You understand what you have done," he said. Not a threat. Barely a question. "I cannot be killed. Not by you, not by anything that lives on this side. I will go back to the Anvil, because there is nowhere else a thing like me can go, and I will be fixed to it as I have been fixed to it since before your makers had names, and I will pull, because that is the only thing a fixed thing can do. And one day, made thing — long after the girl beside you is dust, long after the boy on the rock is a name no one says — another door will wake. They always do. I am very patient. I have just been taught how patient I am going to have to be."

"Yes," Third said. He had turned, finally, away from the place she'd been. The single light of his eye found the cold man, and there was no triumph in it either, only a kind of terrible kinship. "You will wait. And I will spend whatever I have left making certain the next one who wakes is found

by someone who loves them, before it is found by you. That is the whole of the war, I think. That is the only war there ever was. You have patience. I will leave behind people."

Sougad looked at him a long moment. Then he stepped sideways, the half-step out of the world that I had watched Third make a dozen times, and the cold went with him, all at once, like a door closing on the cold — and the rock where he'd stood was only rock, and the Scar wheeled its slow light over a world that had, against everything, not ended.

I became aware that I was still holding Third's arm. That my other hand had, at some point I never felt, finally found the Boltcaster under my cloak, and was gripping it white-knuckled, and had never drawn it.

And a dozen paces off, on the cold stone, the heap that was Roan made a small, wet, outraged groan — the single most beautiful sound in the entire language of the living — and tried, and failed, and tried again, to sit up.

* * *

Thirty Nine

The world did not feel saved. I want to put that down plainly, because the stories will say we saved it and the word will do what words do, it will round everything off smooth, and there was nothing smooth about that rock in the grey light with the cold man gone and the three of us still on it, breathing, which is a different and much smaller thing than *saved*. The world felt the way a room feels after someone has been very ill in it and the fever has finally broken: not triumphant. Just quiet, and wrung out, and aware of how close the other thing had come.

I went to Roan first, because Roan was the one making noise, and noise meant alive.

He'd got himself half-propped on one elbow by the time I reached him, and he was swearing — a low steady creative stream of it, the kind you only manage when the hurt is real but not the worst kind, the kind that's furious to still be here rather than grateful — and when he saw my face he stopped and tried to rearrange his own into something braver, and failed, and I loved him for the failing.

"Don't move," I said, getting my hands on him. "Let me see."

"It threw me," he said, as if I hadn't watched. "It didn't even — Tasha, it didn't even *touch* me. It said a *word*." His outrage at this was total and somehow the most healing thing in the world. A man does not waste breath being indignant about the rules of his injury unless he intends to live to complain about it properly later.

His leg was wrong below the knee — not bone-through-skin wrong, but wrong, already swelling, the kind of wrong that would make the walk out a long ugly business. Two of his ribs grated under my hands in a way that made us both hiss. There was blood drying at the corner of his mouth and a deeper greyish cast to his skin that I didn't like and didn't have a name for, the toll of having been flung so near a wall he was never meant to touch. But his eyes tracked. His swearing scanned. His hand, when I gripped it, gripped back hard enough to grind my knuckles.

"You're going to be unbearable about this," I told him, which was the truest comfort I had. "You threw yourself at a Forged and got cast off by a magic word and lived. You'll dine out on it for the rest of your life."

"Mathen," Roan said, and his voice cracked clean in half on it, "would've gotten a *tenday* of drinks."

"A hundred spins," I said. "Easy."

And we both looked away from each other for a moment, because that was as close as either of us could go to him just then, and it was enough, and it was the first time we'd been able to go even that close since the Grask.

* * *

Third had not moved.

He stood where he'd turned to face Sougad, a little apart, and he was looking at the place the grey had been — the ordinary rock, the ordinary low troughs, nothing standing up out of any of it — and I knew, the way I'd learned to know him, that he was not looking at the rock. He was looking at where she had been. At the empty place he had chosen to keep empty. The lights in his chest had gone back to their small steady burning, the dim one no worse than before, no better; the make of him was intact;

he had taken no wound that he could repair or that anyone could see.

He had taken the other kind.

I left Roan propped and bound as well as I could manage and went and stood beside Third, not touching him, just there, the way he'd stood beside me a hundred times in the dark and let his being-there be the whole of what he offered. For a long while he said nothing. The Scar wheeled. Somewhere far off across the field a slab went over with a crash, because the place was still the place; the world had gone back to being only ordinarily terrible.

"I had her," he said at last. Not to me. To the empty rock. "For the length of a goodbye, I had her back, exactly as she was, and she was holding up her arms. And I gave her to the dark with my own hands so that he—" the eye moved, a fraction, toward Roan "—could keep being a boy who complains about magic words. I want you to understand that I do not feel I did a great thing, Tasha. I feel I did a murder. I murdered the chance to have my daughter, and I did it on purpose, and the only thing I can say for myself is that I would do it again, which is not the same as being glad, and I am so tired of people thinking those are the same."

"I don't think they're the same," I said.

"No," he said. "You don't. It is why I could bear for you to be the one who saw it." A pause. "Thank you for not telling me it was worth it. Everyone is going to tell me it was worth it."

"It wasn't worth it," I said. "It was just necessary. Those aren't the same either."

The single light of his eye came round to me, and held, and something in the make of him eased a fraction — not healed, nothing was healed, but eased, the way a weight

shifts to a part of you better made to carry it.

"No," he said softly. "They are not. You have gotten very good at the true things, Tasha. I am sorry it was my company that taught you."

* * *

He saw the Boltcaster then. It was still in my hand. I had not been able to make myself put it away, and I realised, looking down at it, that my fingers had cramped around it, that I had been holding it that hard for that long, and that the safety of it — the loaded, ready, never-drawn weight of it — was the only thing my body had let itself do with the thing it could not do.

"You did not use it," Third said.

"No."

"When I went quiet. When I went to the wall and reached. That was the moment. That was the only moment, the one I drilled into you, and you had it, and you did not use it." He said it without accusation, the way you'd note the weather. "You could not. Could you."

"No." It came out of me in a rush, the confession I'd been dreading, the failure under the relief. "I couldn't. I had it aimed in my head a hundred times those two nights and when it was real my hand just — it wouldn't. It went tighter on your arm instead. I broke the plan, Third. The one thing you built the whole of it on, the failsafe, the precise instrument, *only when there's truly nothing left* — and when there was truly nothing left I screamed for a hurt boy instead of doing the one thing you asked me for. If Roan hadn't— if Sougad hadn't spent him in front of you— the world ends, because I couldn't open my hand."

Third was quiet a moment. Then he did a thing I had never seen him do and never saw him do again: he reached out, slow, with that wrong boneless ease, and he closed his

own wooden hand around mine, around the Boltcaster, gently, over the cramp, and held it.

"I chose you," he said, "because you were the one least willing to do it. I told you that. I thought I was choosing the most precise blade — the hand that would wait until the last possible breath because it hated the cutting. I was wrong about what I was choosing. I was not choosing a blade at all. I built a failsafe because I needed to believe there was a bottom under me before I could step out over the drop — and the failsafe I actually built, without knowing it, was a person whose hand would not open on me no matter what. Who would scream for help instead of for an ending. Tasha. The reason you could not use it is the same reason it worked. You did not let go of me. That was always the only thing that was going to hold. Not the threat of the shot. The fact of the grip. I am only sorry I made you carry the shot at all, and I am taking it back now, and you will never have to decide that again."

He took Dorn's Boltcaster out of my cramped hand, as gently as he'd given it, and somewhere in the taking it became a memento again instead of a weapon, and he put it away at his back, and that was the end of the failsafe, which had never once been the thing that saved us.

* * *

We did not stay long. You don't, in that country; the place had spared us its worst but it had not become safe, and a slab the size of a barn settling half a field off is a poor lullaby. There was the matter of Roan, who could not walk, and the matter of how far we were from anywhere that wasn't trying to kill us, and the matter of the long impossible distance between a cliff at the cold edge of the world and any roof at all.

Third lifted Roan as easily as he'd once lifted an infant, one arm, settled, and Roan made a noise of protest that turned into a noise of pain that turned into the quiet of a man saving his strength, and we turned our backs on the spine.

I looked back once. The glaive was still standing where Third had leaned it, upright against the pale stone, the wide pale blade he'd carried since before he was anyone.

"You're leaving it," I said.

"It was never mine," said Third, with the boy on his arm. "Let it stand there. Let the next fool who climbs all this way looking for treasure find a door-warden's glaive and no door, and no warden, and let them make of it whatever story keeps them warm on the walk home. Mathen would like that, I think. A thing left behind on purpose, to be wondered at. He always said the wondering was the point."

And we walked out into the open book, the three of us, one of us carried and one of us carrying and one of us holding a rope that had no far end anymore and not yet knowing how to put it down — out across the crawling field toward a horizon that was a very long way away, with no notion in the world of how we were going to cross it, and behind us a glaive stood guard over nothing at all, exactly as it had been made to do, and was, at last, free of us.

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Forty

The water was the first thing it had ever stopped for that was not a threat.

It did not have a word for what it was doing. It was crouched at the edge of a brook in a blue-green wood, and the water ran over stones and made a sound, and the sound was not the sound of anything coming to kill it or anything it had been made to kill, and so the thoughts in its head had nothing to say about the water and were, for a moment, only quiet. It put two fingers into the cold of it. It watched the running thing break around its fingers and close again downstream, unbothered, as though the hand had never been there. It did not know why this was worth doing. It did it for a while anyway.

That was when the green one stood up out of the reeds with the bow already drawn.

The thoughts came back at once, fluent and calm, the way they always were. *A Virek. Armed. One step left takes the line of the arrow; one swing of the glaive takes the bow and the arm that holds it in the same arc. It is small. It will be slow.* It had heard this kind of thing its whole short existence and had never once had cause to doubt it. Its body began, very slightly, to do what the thoughts described. The weight came onto the left hoof.

Then it looked at the bow.

It did not mean to. The thoughts had not asked it to. There was no use in looking at the bow — the bow was a problem already solved, a thing to be broken on the way to

the thing that held it. But it looked, and what it saw stopped the weight where it was.

The bow had been carved down its whole length. The carving spiralled out from the grip in both directions, fine past following, as though the wood were not cut but coaxed, as though someone had spent a great many days persuading it to become this. There was red worked deep into the bindings, new and bright, not yet gone to the dull of age. It was not a parody of anything. The glaive in its own hands was a parody — a Virek shape, a Virek weapon, made by a Titan as a joke against the Virek, made for the one purpose of ending them and nothing else, and it had never once thought of the glaive as anything but the most efficient version of itself. But the bow was not a joke and not efficient. The bow was a thing a frightened young person had made slowly, with their whole care, knowing it would mostly hang on a wall, and had carved anyway, every length of it, where no enemy would ever look closely enough to see.

Something happened that it had no name for, because it had never happened before.

The thoughts stopped.

Not quieted. Not argued down — it did not yet know it could argue them down; that would come later, with practice, the way the fire would come, the way the warmth would. They simply stopped, the way a voice stops in a room when something walks in that it does not know how to speak about. For the length of a held breath there was nothing in its head telling it where the line of the arrow was, or how the swing should fall, or which part of the small green thing would come apart first. There was only the bow, and the care in the bow, and the strange new pressure of finding a made thing beautiful and not knowing what to do with the finding.

Into that silence — the first silence it had ever been given — the green one spoke.

"What are you doing?"

And it heard its own voice answer, a sound like a slope giving way, a sound that startled the thing that made it:

"I… do not know."

I. The word came up out of the new silence as though it had been waiting under the floor of every order it had ever followed. It turned the word over. It did not break against anything. There was room for it now, in the quiet the bow had made, and once there was room the word simply walked in and stood there, and the thoughts did not come back to push it out.

"What am I?" it asked the green one, and meant it, and the asking was the second thing it had ever done that no one had told it to do.

The green one's arms were shaking. The bow stayed up, but the young face above it had stopped being only afraid and started being something else, something that leaned forward despite itself.

"Blank," the green one said. "You're what we call a Blank."

It looked at the bow a moment longer — the spiral, the red, the whole patient length of it — and then it opened its hands and let the glaive fall forward into the reeds, because the glaive was the efficient version of itself and it had just discovered, in the silence a stranger's bow had made, that it did not want to be the efficient version of itself anymore.

It did not know what it wanted to be instead. It would spend the whole length of the world finding out. But it knew, crouched there with the water closing over the place its hand had been, that the wanting itself was new, and was

its own, and had come in through a door a frightened child had carved without meaning to, every length of it, where no enemy would ever look.

And then it bent and took the glaive back up out of the reeds. Not because the wanting had changed — but the world was full of things that had made no discoveries that day, and an unarmed thing alone in it would not live long enough to find out what it wanted to be instead. The wet wood was the same weight it had always been and sat in its hands the same way, and nothing about it had changed except that it was now a thing being carried, and no longer a thing being been. It would carry it for the whole length of the world. It would set it down at last on a hill at the edge of everything, against a pale stone, and walk away and not look back. The setting down began here, in the reeds, in the silence a bow had made. It simply took three hundred thousand spins to finish. Behind it, as it turned downstream, it heard the green one say, very low, to no one:

"A Blank just used 'I'."

It did not look back. It had not yet learned that there were things worth looking back at. That, too, would come.

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Forty One

The stories will tell you we walked out of the Giant's Graveyard. They will make it sound like a single motion, a thing with a shape — *and then they walked out* — the way stories tidy a distance into a sentence. It was not a sentence. It was most of a day and into the dark and most of another, across a field that had gone back to merely trying to kill us in the ordinary ways, with Roan on Third's arm making the small involuntary sounds of a man whose ribs disagreed with being carried and being still equally, and the cliff at our backs never seeming to get any further away no matter how long we put it behind us. That is what walking out is. It is the part the stories cut.

Third said almost nothing the whole of it. I had learned to read him by then, well enough to know he was not sulking and not broken past speech — he was a long way back, somewhere behind his own eye, somewhere I'd been given the shape of but not the rooms. Once, when the Scar came round and the light caught the side of his ruined patient face, I saw the coal of his eye go soft in a way I had only ever seen it go on the watch, the way it went when he was off a little beside the world with someone he'd lost — except he wasn't beside the world now. He was just walking, and remembering, the ordinary way the rest of us do it. I let him. You learn, eventually, which silences are yours to fill and which are a person keeping company with their own dead, and the second kind you leave alone and match your steps to, and that is most of what love turns out to be when you strip the songs off it.

We came over a long low rise of broken pages on the second evening, and there it was, sitting on the air the way a fat gull sits on water, fans going *clatter-clatter-clatter* against the dusk.

The Porter.

I knew it for a skybarge before I knew anything else about it — everyone knows the clatter, the way you know rain coming — but I had never seen one close, and I had certainly never seen one that had a *porch*. Because it did. Lanterns strung along a rail. A board by the ramp with the day's pot chalked on it. A barge built like a building, like somebody's stubborn warm idea of an inn that had simply declined to stay on the ground with the others. Down both flanks of the hull, set in cradles of dark banded hexwood, ran a row of bottled magefire — fat vessels of that caged blue-white light, the same as lived in Third's chest but the size of ale-kegs, throwing a cold glow down onto the rock and holding the whole impossible weight of the place up on nothing I could see. At the stern a single great push-fan stood as wide as a mill-wheel, and as I watched it slowed, and slowed, and came round to a halt — the barge easing to a stop at the rim of the rise and coming no closer, hung there on its cold lights with the lanterns swinging.

"It won't come over," Third said — the first full thing he'd said in a day. "The spine is still shedding — letting go of itself a page at a time, the way you've watched it do. No barge-master takes a hull in under falling rock, and Waj is too good a one to try. They hold the edge. No further." He shifted Roan higher on his arm. "We walk the last of it. As we walked in."

So we did. And a figure leaned over the rail as we came up the last stretch of stone, and cupped their hands, and called down in a voice built for being heard across a full common-room:

"We saw the devastation. In a line. Right across the bad country, like something had been *editing* it." A pause, and even at that distance I could hear the dry shape of the next part coming. "And we thought — well. We thought there was a fair chance you'd be involved." Another pause. "Again."

"Waj," Third said, in the tone he kept for the very few. "You came back to the rim."

"I keep a tab, ser Forged. You're on the wrong side of it, still, since the business with the Ravagers and my ramp." They were already cranking the ramp down, this Waj — a broad, unhurried person with an apron over travelling leathers and the particular calm of someone who has watched a great deal of trouble walk up to their door and decided, long ago, to simply feed most of it. "I don't forget who covered my retreat walking *backward*. I think you'll find we're square after a ride and a few hot meals. Don't tell me what happened back there. I run an inn. I'd rather not know what I'm ferrying, it puts me off the cooking."

Getting Roan up the ramp was its own small war, and Waj took his weight off Third at the top without being asked and without making it a moment, the way good innkeepers move you out of a doorway — and then we were aboard, on a floor that shifted, very slightly, underfoot, the whole warm strung-lantern length of it, the pot on the stove and the bedding rolled in the corners and the smell of somewhere that fed people for a living.

I stood on it and felt it move and I laughed. I couldn't help it. It came up out of me ugly and sudden and I had to put my hand over my mouth.

Because here is the thing the stories also leave out. I left my inn — a good inn, a still inn, an inn that did not go anywhere and never would — because I was bored, because I wanted a floor that took me somewhere, because

there had to be more than wiping the same six tables under the same unmoving roof for the rest of a life. I had said almost those words, once, closing up alone. And now I was standing on a floor that moved, in an inn that came to *you*, that went wherever the trouble and the trade were — I had got, down to the grain of it, the exact thing I'd wanted — and I'd had to walk out of a place where the dead crawl, carrying what we were carrying, to get it. I laughed because the alternative had my hand over my mouth for a different reason, and I have never been one to let a room see which it was.

We rode through the dark. Waj fed us and asked nothing. Roan slept the sleep of the finally-safe-enough. And late, when the lanterns were down to embers and the fans had settled to a drone you stopped hearing, Third sat with his back to the warm flue and I sat near him, and I said, because somebody had to and it had been sitting in me the whole walk:

"Tell me the good part again. The tree story. I want to hear it on a floor that moves."

He was quiet a moment. Then the avalanche turned over, gentle, and he told it — the little one who would not sleep, the singing leaves, the bird, the swaying, the frightened thing learning it could be still. He told it better than he had at the fire. A story wears smooth where you hold it, he'd said once; this one had been held a great deal, lately, and it had gone smooth in the good way — the way the bow had, worn by being carried and not just kept.

And at the edge of the failing light, where the dark started past the last lantern, there was — I will say it plainly now, because I have stopped being afraid of the things I see — there was the suggestion of someone small, sitting with their knees drawn up, listening to a story they already knew and loved anyway. The lanternlight went a

little way into them, the way it goes into smoke. I did not look away this time. I let them be there. And when the story ended they were gone, the gentle way, no worse than before, and Third set the last word down soft into the dark the way you'd set down a cup you didn't want to wake anyone with.

"He'll be back," Third said, to me, or to the dark, "for as long as it gets told. That is the whole of what he is, now. A thing that is here while it is told." The coal of his eye came round to me. "It is not nothing, Tasha. I spent a long time thinking it was nothing — a thing you could only *almost* keep was the same as a thing you'd lost. It is not the same. I gave up the chance to have my—" and there he stopped, the way he always stopped, and then, because we were on a floor that moved and the worst was behind us, he went on, quietly, the first time he ever said it to me whole: "—to have my daughter. At the cliff. He offered her back and I said no, because the price was the world, and saying no was the hardest thing I have ever done, and I would do it again, and it has left a hole in me the exact size and shape of her that I am going to carry for whatever is left of a very long life." The eye held steady. "But she is not *gone*. That is what the bow taught me, in your mouth, on the road. The boy is gone past all finding and his bow is on a wall being handsome and in someone's way. Unrecognisable is not the same as gone. She is in every story I will not stop telling, and in a green thing somewhere with her eyes that will never know my name, and in the hole itself, which is hers, which I would not trade for a full and easy chest. I lost her. I did not lose *her.* Do you see. I am only now beginning to."

I saw. I didn't say so, because some seeing is bigger than the saying of it, and he knew anyway.

So that is the end of it, or the end of the part I was there for. We rode out of the bad country on an inn that flew.

Roan mended, mostly, and limps on the other leg now, which he says makes him symmetrical and which Mathen would have got a hundred spins of drinks out of, and we say so, often, because that is how you keep a man who liked drinks. Third went on, of course. There is always another peg, another patient thing, another door that might wake; and there is, he says, the matter of leaving behind people, which is the only argument he has found that beats *I am very patient*, and which he intends to keep making with his whole long life. He left the glaive on the hill. He kept the Boltcaster. He keeps the hole.

And me — I am telling you this. That is the part I have left to do, and I have come to think it is not a small one. Mathen said a story is how you get more than one person to carry the weight, so it doesn't all rest on the one. I didn't understand him then. I was wiping tables. I understand him now, on a floor that moves, with the lanterns down and someone small at the edge of them for as long as I keep the telling going: I am carrying. That is what this is. Every name I say keeps a door open the width of a finger and holds it there.

I followed a monster out of an inn because I was bored, and nothing was ever going to change, and that was the thing about quiet towns.

I was wrong about the quiet towns. I have never in my life been so glad to be wrong about anything.